

Trump, Trumpism & Transactionalism - And How We Traded Short-Term Lies for Long-Term Loss

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Summary

How long is 4.543 billion years compared to 3,500 years? The 3,500 years our species has existed as humans might seem minuscule compared to our 4.543-billion-year-old planet Earth. But what about 8 years compared to 249? Only 8 years, compared to the 249-year scale of American democracy. To some, both comparisons might seem like an insignificant percentage, not worth accounting for—a mere statistical blip in the grand narrative of a nation. And yet, within those 8 years, things built almost over the course of two and a half centuries could be destroyed. Not by a meteorite strike, or nuclear disaster, but by a pure and unforgiving spectacle and apparent denial of reality by a mass of over at least 170 million people.

An old saying goes that a lie repeated 100 times eventually becomes truth. But a lie repeated at least 170 million times—what are we to make of that? Yet the very lie was repeated not 170 million times but twice that amount, as Trump was voted for president twice. Can we still really talk about a lie that becomes truth—that Trump is suitable and adept for the presidency of the richest and mightiest country history has ever seen?

The lies don't just evolve into truth by being repeated almost half a billion times. This inadvertently alters the very fabric of what we perceived as truth itself. We have witnessed not merely the corruption of information, but the fundamental restructuring of reality through mass delusion. When 170 million people choose to believe the same falsehood twice, we are no longer dealing with propaganda—we are confronting the collective suicide of human's reason & rationality.

Thus:

In America, they have twice elected a president who has said and done things that violate universal moral values we all share—hoping he would fulfill short-term political promises. They were rewarded with lies, falsehoods, and duplicity in every conceivable claim he had made. Trump is not just someone who should never have been elected to a position of power—yet he was, and he surrounded himself with vultures and idiots feeding upon America's heartland while he himself remained merely a puppet.

But Trump is only the symptom, not the disease. He is the perfect expression of a society that has learned to trade dignity for supposed security, truth for convenient lies, principles for populism. His election reveals something more terrifying than his own moral corruption: it shows that a majority of voters were willing to sacrifice the foundations of democracy for the promise of simple answers to complex questions.

The vultures who flocked around him recognized the opportunity: a people afraid of the future will buy anyone who promises them certainty—no matter how deceptive. They transformed America's noblest tradition, democratic discourse, into a show where the loudest screamer emerges victorious. The idiots he surrounded himself with weren't there by accident—they were the logical consequence of a system that considers competence elitist and ignorance authentic.

And while Trump played his antics, while his supporters chanted "America First," the country became a living example of how quickly a democracy can crumble from within. Not through tanks or bombs, but through citizens' willingness to despise their own democratic institutions as long as the right demagogue tells them what they want to hear.

This is the bitterest irony of our time: while we fear external enemies, we have elected democracy's internal enemies to power. We have learned to place authority over truth, strength over justice, power over morality. Trump was not the corruptor of American democracy—he was its faithful mirror.

The mathematics are staggering in their implications. In 1776, a handful of revolutionary thinkers conceived a radical experiment in self-governance. For 249 years, that experiment survived civil war, economic collapse, both world wars, and the constant tension between idealism and human frailty. It took nearly two and a half centuries to build the institutions, norms, and shared understanding of democratic governance.

And it may took only 8 years to dismantle them.

This is not hyperbole—it is arithmetic. The rate of democratic decay we have witnessed represents an acceleration of destruction that defies historical precedent. Typically, democracies die slowly, eroded by decades of institutional capture, economic inequality, and social fragmentation. America chose the express route: mass delusion delivered at the speed of social media.

When 170 million people voluntarily abandon their capacity for critical thinking—not once, but twice—we witness something unprecedented in human history. This is not the gradual corruption of a political system; it is the voluntary lobotomy of a civilization. Each vote for Trump was not merely a political choice but an act of epistemological surrender—a conscious decision to reject the very concept of verifiable truth.

Dignity has not merely become violable. It has been degraded to a commodity that can be bought and sold at will. And what's terrifying is this: we were all willing to pay the price. We all watched as the foundations of our civilization became bargaining chips in the great game of political power.

The old adage about lies repeated 100 times becoming truth was coined in a different era, when information moved slowly and verification was still possible. But we live in an age where lies can be repeated 170 million times in an instant, where falsehood can achieve critical mass faster than truth can respond. We have created a democracy that operates at the speed of light but thinks at the speed of medieval superstition.

It was not Terrorism, not Russian Aggression nor Economic Collapse of Capitalism, that defeated us. We did it ourselves—at the ballot box, through our silence, through our willingness to excuse the inexcusable as long as it served our own short-term fulfillment of illusion about the world.

The question is no longer whether our democracy will survive. The question is whether what survives will still deserve the name. And perhaps more chilling still: if 249 years of democratic progress can be undone in 8 years of willful ignorance, what does that say about the fundamental nature of human civilization itself?

We may have discovered that democracy is not, as we believed, the natural state toward which humanity evolves, but rather a brief and fragile exception to our species' default setting: the worship of deillusional certainty over uncomfortable truth

Part I: Why Kamala was Destined to Loose the 2024 Elections

☞ I will end every single international crisis that the current Administration has created including the horrible war with Russia and Ukraine which would have never happened if I was president and the War caused by the attack on Israel which would have never happened if I was President Iran was broke Iran had no money now Iran has \$250 billion they made it all over the last 2 and a half years they were broke." - Trump said foolishly

It occurred to me recently that the conservative movement doesn't really have a foreign policy anymore. It has now been 16 years since any mainstream Republican has held the White House and almost all of the high ranking people from the Bush Administration have retired, and Trump alienated all the mainstream figures who worked for him the first time. There are just no Republicans with high-level foreign policy experience anymore. All that's left is the fringiest dregs of neoconservatism and the pseudo-isolationism of the [Pat Buchanan](#). And you could say well, Trumpism is the foreign policy of the Republicans now and it doesn't matter if it meets your personal definition of expertise. Who's to say [Hulk Hogan](#) can't be deputy secretary of defense for Middle Eastern and North African Affairs? He defeated the Iron Sheik. But what is Trumpism?

The main idea seemed to be total autarky, punishing all of our allies and just kind of hoping Donald Trump's toughness vibes will deter China from invading Taiwan. But Trump supporter, claim:

"When Donald Trump was President Putin did nothing Russia invaded Ukraine under both Obama and Biden but Putin did not dare escalate under President Trump"

In *The Simpsons*, Lisa tries to teach Homer about flawed logic. Homer proudly accepts Lisa's compliment on his "reasoning," but Lisa then demonstrates how empty it is: she points to an ordinary rock and says it "keeps tigers away." When Homer asks how, she replies that there are no tigers around — therefore the rock must be working. Homer is convinced and even wants to buy it.

The joke is that the reasoning is backwards. The absence of tigers doesn't prove the rock is effective. It's a parody of **post hoc** reasoning: assuming that because two things happen together, one must have caused the other.

And he has no back bench to fill in the gap. The think tanks ([Foreign Policy Research Institute](#), [CSIS Center for Strategic & International Studies](#), [The Heritage Foundation](#), [AEI American Enterprise Institute](#)) that were willing to hold their nose and give them a chance in 2016 have run away from them all except the Heritage Foundation, the think tank that is now infamous for its creation of [project 2025](#) that want to change the U.S. into ethno-christianity state, though we will cover it more in-depth later on. But even they gutted their foreign policy

team (as per the [Washington Post: Opinion, A conservative think tank turns away from Reagan and towards Trump](#)) because none of their old foreign policy experts wanted anything to do with Trump. The main foreign policy idea on their website now is a white paper ([The new face of Birth tourism: Chinese nationals, American Surrogates and birthright citizenship](#))

The New Face of Birth Tourism: Chinese Nationals, American Surrogates, and Birthright Citizenship

Emma Waters and Simon Hankinson

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Lax U.S. laws governing international surrogacy allow foreign nationals, including those from China, to “rent a womb” from American women with little oversight.

The resulting children gain and maintain the full rights of American citizenship through a dubious interpretation of the Fourteenth Amendment.

When parents prepare for the birth of a child, it is common to research the best hospital or birth center. But imagine foreign nationals going so far as to ask which *country* they should choose when deciding where to conceive and give birth to a child. The U.S. already has a problem with birth tourism when foreign women in late pregnancy enter the United States on tourist visas or illegally to give birth, thereby giving their children U.S. citizenship. Now foreign nationals have another “pathway”—through permissive U.S. surrogacy laws.¹

Lax U.S. laws governing international surrogacy allow foreign nationals, including those of states

about the Chinese using American surrogate mothers to create an army of Chinese sleeper agents with American citizenship. Even project 2025 itself punts on most issues except Israel, China and maybe an invasion of Mexico. What this means is that the entire spectrum ([Atlantic Council](#), [Council on Foreign Relations](#), [CSIS Center for Strategic & International Studies](#), [Center for a New American Security](#), [Brookings](#))

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of American foreign policy expertise now basically resides under or at least near the Democratic party umbrella and at the same time a lot of the old issues that people used to rally around aren't really relevant anymore. That has made the foreign policy world even more out of touch with voters who aren't just becoming more partisan but are also increasingly inhabiting completely different worlds thanks to partisan media and there's no place where that problem is worse than foreign policy where people have no personal experience to measure against the media they consume.

If you think it's not newsworthy it's still useful information to know what the other side is panicking about and my article is mostly about trying to figure out what the other side is panicking about.

Back to our foreign policy Elite. With one party now completely withdrawn from the debate, foreign policy is now less polarized than it was at any point since the Vietnam War. The result of this complete depolarization of foreign policy expertise is that it's increasingly hard to just put people in the old simple categories and predict what they'll do based on that. The neoconservative movement split between the minority that actually believed in democracy and the majority that was just in it for the dead brown people. The institutions that liberal internationalists wanted to invest in are all discredited. Realists Mr. Mearsheimer can't agree on whether or not appeasing Russia will reduce Russian aggression and the Anti-Imperialist left is hopelessly divided on the question of whether or not imperialism is bad (see my [blog about Ukraine](#) for details). To predict now what someone will do you have to tease out not just their basic worldview and affiliations but their idiosyncratic take on each issue. This makes predictions almost impossible and with Kamala that challenge gets even harder because she's left no real record behind to examine. She had no meaningful foreign policy record in the Senate, her [2020 campaign website](#) didn't even have a foreign policy section and you can only get insight into what she thought about Biden's foreign policy in the scant few times the Biden White House ever leaks to the Press. So that leaves looking through the paper trail of her two main foreign policy advisers, her National Security advisor and her

Deputy National Security adviser [Philip Gordon](#) (National Security advisor to the Vice President) and [Rebecca Lissner](#) (Deputy National Security Advisor to the Vice President Harris) respectively.

Gordon was a think tanker who served as deputy secretary of state for Eastern Europe during the Russia reset and then deputy secretary for the Middle East during Syria, both experiences leaving him greatly disillusioned with American power and what it can achieve. Just before joining the Biden Administration he wrote a book ([Losing the Long game: The False Promise of Regime change in the middle east](#)) about how regime change in the Middle East is basically always a disaster. Rebecca Lissner is a professor at the naval war College who specializes in Grand strategy and who has written a book (with [Mira Rapp-Hooper](#), named [An Open World: How America Can Win the Contest for Twenty-first Century Order](#)) about how to reorganize the world order now that the traditional liberal International order is no longer viable. In so far as these categories still matter, they're both basically defensive neorealists pretending to be liberal internationalists, not unlike Obama. Both have written books about how America needs to stop intervening in the Middle East and they basically both want to reorient foreign policy around out-competing China. But what does that really tell us about how they'll handle the specific issues let alone an unforeseen crisis? I suspect if we want to be able to predict what they're going to do it might be more useful to look at the circumstances in which they're going to have to work rather than their internal beliefs.

Ukraine

Ukraine is an issue on which there is very little dissent in the establishment about what to do in the broad strokes. Well, there is a little dissent:

"We've seen Senator Vance in the past also say that he doesn't really care what happens in Ukraine one way or another. Is that the official Republican stance right now?" "First of all I don't think JD has ever said I don't care what happens in Ukraine and..." "I think the quote something along the lines of I don't really care what happens in Ukraine one way or the other" "but please well and you're talking about funding so but not people I mean he's a very kind person"

But even among people who agree that Ukraine must win, minor tactical differences have blown up in importance, namely on the question of what weapons to give Ukraine and when. And with the White House so tight lipped about the issue people have been filling in the gaps with rumors and speculation. A theory has gotten popular that says Biden's National Security adviser [Jake Sullivan](#) has convinced Biden not to give Ukraine the weapons that would allow Ukraine to win the war in fairly quick order because he's worried that if Russia loses precipitously Russia will hit back with nuclear retaliation. So there's been some excitement in a certain corner of the internet that Sullivan will be replaced with someone more hawkish. The problem is that this theory is almost certainly bogus. There's no evidence that Sullivan has been the one pushing back on sending better weapons to Ukraine and in the few times journalists (as in the article: [Trial by Combat](#)) have gotten people in the white house to talk they've mostly pointed the finger at [Lloyd Austin](#) and [The Joint Chiefs of Staff](#). And that

would track because that kind of conservatism is now deeply embedded in the culture of the Pentagon and not so much in the culture of the [United States National Security Council](#) (NSC) or the state department. As far as I can tell, the rumor that Sullivan is the problem was started by writers who had a previously existing beef with Sullivan for reasons too dumb and complicated to explain and that rumor started getting parroted by [NAFO](#) accounts on Twitter who will repeat any rumor for clicks and then it got picked up by Congressional Republicans to deflect attention away from the fact that Congressional Republicans were the ones [holding up a hundred billion dollars in Aid money](#). It really is quite an astonishing example of a fact just sort of being instantiated by people repeating it over and over again on social media with no evidence. There's a misapprehension here on why the White House has held back because the reason is different for different weapons and at different times and only a bit of the hold back is about escalation management.

For instance in the early part of the war the White House didn't want to send advanced weapons because they were working off the assumption that Ukraine would lose and therefore anything they gave the Ukrainians would get captured. So for instance a patriot missile battery would immediately fall into Russian hands and then the Russians would be able to reverse engineer it later. For most ordinary offensive weapons like say the M1 Abrams, the real reason for America's reticence was not a fear of Russia but an underestimation. The White House assumed that if Russia took enough casualties it would give in and sign an agreement to withdraw back to at least the February 21st line. Remember they gave up on Afghanistan after only [12,000 casualties](#). It's only after casualties ran up into the six figures with no interruption in domestic peace inside Russia that the Pentagon realized Ukraine might need to win by an offensive rather than by running the clock out. And the Pentagon doesn't know how to arm Ukraine for a successful offensive against Russia without giving Ukraine access to the Family Jewels of American power like say the F-35.

There was no fear that sending F-16s and M1s to the front line would trigger escalation from Putin but a fear that they wouldn't change anything at all and so why not spend money elsewhere? When it comes to the ATACMS however, the White House's decision is about escalation. The ATACMS after all are ballistic missiles, not regular rockets that just happen to go further. Though it's important to clarify here what escalation refers to in this case. What the White House is worried about isn't Ukraine being too aggressive and triggering an immediate nuclear response but the perception in the Kremlin that America is directly involved, justifying a direct conventional attack on NATO infrastructure in a NATO country, an attack NATO would then have to respond to possibly snowballing into something bigger. Their estimation of what the Kremlin will do isn't driven by credulously believing what Putin says but rather strategic empathy. They simply asked themselves well, if America was at war with Mexico and someone was supplying them with ballistic missiles that were now raining down on downtown Los Angeles, we would probably take the risk of shooting at the supplier. Still, as Ukraine's situation started to look bleaker, people's appetite for risk started to increase and more and more people in Biden's White House are willing to take the risk that comes with shooting American ballistic missiles directly into Russia.

So who's been the holdout? Well, by most accounts the person who is standing firm the most is the president himself, not Sullivan. So a change between National Security advisers probably won't change much on ATACMS but a change of presidency might. But no one has leaked even a peep about what side of the fight Kamala Harris is on though we know she's in the rooms where this argument is being held. She doesn't say much. I have a gut feeling that Kamala's instinct will be to take on more risk because experience tends to make presidents more risk averse in war. But ultimately it will come down to who wins the argument in the situation room after she's elected between a reticent Department of Defense and a more hawkish state department and those fights tend to be issues of personality as much as policy.

Israel - Palestine

Forget whatever you've read about Middle East strategy. America's unwillingness to confront Israel is about domestic politics. Confronting Israel costs you donors, it costs you voters, it costs you bad press and every president knows it, every Israeli Prime Minister knows it. But there are ways to pressure Israel that won't trigger a big voter backlash. For instance you can throttle Aid deliveries unannounced and have them mysteriously speed up again after the Israelis do what you ask. Biden has allegedly already tried this but to what effect it's hard to say. Kamala for her part is clearly more sympathetic to Palestinians than Biden but whether that will translate to different policy is hard to say. Real change in Israel policy requires a change in Congress. They set the aid budget. The president does have the power to temporarily cut off Aid on human rights grounds through the [Leahy act](#) but any president would be immediately overruled by Congress and lose all their leverage over Israel when it comes to shaping the long-term post-war settlement. Even though at this point that leverage is so meager it's hard to know if it's worth it.

Philip Gordon's record on Israel is promising. He came out against the decision to move the embassy to Jerusalem ([Argument: Israel's Calm Before the Storm by Gordon](#)) and predicted that just ignoring the Gaza situation would eventually lead to an explosion not unlike what actually happened. But as I said earlier his first commitment is to non-interventionism and while non-interventionism sounds dovish there's nothing comforting about having advisers who want to be less involved in the Middle East. In practice isolationism in the Middle East always means giving the Israelis a blank check and hoping the next explosion goes off after you left office since politically that's the path of least resistance. Remember it's Congress that gives Israel Aid. Trying to decouple from Israel means a fight with them so it's only presidents who really want to meddle in the Middle East that are willing to spend the political Capital to put pressure on Israel to negotiate. What that ultimately means is that any change in Israel policy is going to come downstream of a change in the big picture situation in the Middle East, particularly when it comes to America's relationship with Iran.

And to quote Trump again:

"Iran was broke Iran had no money now Iran has \$250 billion they made it all over the last 2 and a half years they were broke"

Iran remains the one country where the traditional conservative liberal divide has basically survived completely intact. Liberals want to play footsie with the regime moderates and cut a deal. Conservatives want to say



Oh you believe in the JCPOA? That pales in effectiveness to my strategy doing regime change in Iran... Only to then not do regime change in Iran.

Philip Gordon wasn't one of the main architects of the Iran deal but he was by far its most vocal defender (see [Politico: Trump's magical thinking on Iran Sanctions won't Advance U.S. Interests](#)) during the Trump presidency. But that won't necessarily translate into a return to the old deal. When Biden first took over it was assumed he would follow in Obama's footsteps and re-enter the deal but by that point the usual mis-connections pattern of Iranian American relations had intervened. When the moderates were in charge of Iran America had elected Trump and when America elected Biden Iran elected [Ebrahim Raisi](#) the hardline hanging judge. But this time if Harris wins her presidency will coincide with the presidency of a moderate again and one with a popular mandate to make a deal with the Americans for whatever that's still worth in the Iranian system. But the politics of doing a deal so soon after the brutal crackdown on protesters in 2022 and the October 7th attack which fairly or not Iran is going to be held responsible for will be difficult. A new comprehensive nuclear deal is probably out of the question either way. Trump's decision to withdraw destroyed America's leverage by splitting the coalition of countries that are meant to maintain the sanctions on Iran but there are still possible deals to be had on other issues like Ukraine, Hamas or the Houthis. Given that, the real question would be something like this:

Is a deal to get for example the Iranians to distance themselves from Russia and their war in Ukraine worth the grief it would cause from Israel and Saudi Arabia and their incredibly powerful Washington lobbies? Or will America take the easy way out and buy them off by cementing the Israeli Saudi relationship with more bribes even though that will necessarily mean getting ourselves more involved with the region in general? The latter option, which is more likely, doesn't have to be bad but if the Harris White House does take that path they will either have to get serious about pressuring Israel back into a withdrawal agreement process or find themselves in the exact same situation they were in on [October 8th 2023](#). And speaking of pivots:

China

The spectrum of opinion on China in American foreign policy now stretches from slightly paranoid hostility to psychotic conspiracy theory hysteria ([Chip War](#), [The Return of Great Powers](#) by [Jim Sciutto](#), [Danger Zone: The coming Conflict with China](#) by [Hal Brands](#) and [Michael Backley](#), [Death by China: Confronting the Dragon - A Global Call to Action](#) by [Peter Navarro](#) and [Greg Autry](#)). What divides Trump World from the mainstream is not so much a belief that America will have to go to war with China but rather a divide between people who think America will have to fight a naval and air war against China for Taiwan sometime in the future and people who think China is already waging a wildly successful war of sabotage against the United States, all the Manchurian Candidate literally:

On Fox News:

"The house oversight committee launching an investigation into vice president Kamala Harris's running mate Minnesota Governor [Tim Walz](#) over his long-standing connections to China and CCP linked entities. Walz has visited China 30 times and even served as a fellow to a Chinese institution devoted to the Chinese Communist party"

and patience to achieve its objectives. Protecting the United States from the PRC's designs requires an unambiguous offensive-defensive mix, including protecting American citizens and their interests, as well as U.S. allies, from PRC attacks and abuse that undermine U.S. competitiveness, security, and prosperity.

The United States must have a cost-imposing strategic response to make Beijing's aggression unaffordable, even as the American economy and U.S. power grow. This stance will require real, sustained, near-unprecedented U.S. growth; stronger partnerships; synchronized economic and security policies; and American energy independence—but above all, it will require a very honest perspective about the nature and designs of the PRC as more of a threat than a competitor.¹⁰ The next President should use the State Department and its array of resources to reassess and lead this effort, just as it did during the Cold War. The U.S. government needs an Article X for China,¹¹ and it should be a presidential mandate. Along with the National Security Council, the State Department should draft an Article X, which should be a deeply philosophical look at the China challenge.

Many foreign policy professionals and national leaders, both in government and the private sector, are reluctant to take decisive action regarding China. Many are vested in an unshakable faith in the international system and global norms. They are so enamored with them they cannot brook any criticisms or reforms, let alone

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acknowledge their potential for being abused by the PRC. Others refuse to acknowledge Beijing's malign activities and often pass off criticism as conspiracy theories.

For instance, many were quick to dismiss even the possibility that COVID-19 escaped from a Chinese research laboratory. The reality, however, is that the PRC's actions often do sound like conspiracy theories—because they are conspiracies. In addition, some knowingly or not parrot the Communist line: Global leaders including President Joe Biden, have tried to normalize or even laud Chinese behavior. In some cases, these voices, like the global corporate giants BlackRock and Disney, directly benefit from doing business with Beijing.

To quote project 2025:

"Many foreign policy professionals and national leaders both in government and the private sector are reluctant to take the size of action regarding China. Many are vested in an unshakable faith in the International System and Global Norms. They are so

enamored of them they can't brook any criticism or reforms let alone acknowledge their potential for being abused by the People's Republic of China (PRC). Others refuse to acknowledge Beijing's malign activities and often pass off criticism as conspiracy theories. The reality however is that the PRC's actions often do sound like conspiracy theories because they are conspiracies" - like what, WTF? Project 2025?

Um so I'm pretty sure this is what 1950 felt like. Like if you were curious if we're in a cold war well I think you can be sure now. China should be where Kamala's number two adviser Becca Lissner becomes an asset. Keeping up with China is her beat. She wrote a book filled to the brim with policies that would help strengthen America for a fight with China, policies that will probably never be implemented because you'd need both parties to work together in Congress to get them, but still. But there's a problem: Americans don't really want a strategy to beat China.

Trump was able to win by bashing China because after 10 years of American politicians scapegoating the Chinese for a sluggish economic recovery that was really caused by bad macroeconomic policy the American people were hungry for a fantasy that American decline and de-industrialization were connected and could both be reversed by simple crude protectionism (Thus the tariffs that we will explore in Part VI of this Article). Biden and Jake Sullivan have built their foreign policy on the idea that they could double down on that fantasy but make it less destructive by moving away from tariffs and moving towards massive subsidies. Sullivan has actually been quite explicit that he's doing this because he thinks it's necessary to get the American people to buy into any foreign policy whatsoever. To quote Sullivan on [Hudson Institute](#):

"The thing that every Economist would tell you happens which is overall we win, there are some losers and we compensate the losers, that's kind of how it goes. Did anyone pause and say well you know, did the people who get hurt by these trade deals actually get any compensation or get an what would that even mean what would that mean? Did we? No we just had kind of these small Trade Agreements Act (TAA) programs and not a lot to it. I totally agree with that and for me though the real reason why that happened more than anything else is this wall between foreign policy and domestic policy. Foreign policy people went out and did the trade deals and didn't look over that wall to say hey was the uh the whole thing on the domestic side kind of working out? They just let that not happen for very long time"

In other words with both Trump and to a lesser extent Biden are subordinating real competition to a performance of being tough and what's effective in power politics bears no relationship with what's effective as security theater because the most important thing America needs in any confrontation with China is allies and that means the sort of unilateral aggression that looks tough on cable news is pretty much always counterproductive. But really that's every foreign policy problem these days isn't it? From the imaginary Jake Sullivan plot to sabotage Ukraine to Biden and [Netanyahu](#)'s efforts to oust one another while publicly proclaiming their indivisibility to the decades long history of partisan chest beating on

Iran that completely ignores the actual problem of Iran and to finally the bipartisan commitment to pretending that sporadic acts of protectionism is a China strategy.

What's clear is that the world is now so complicated that even relatively sophisticated voters cling to symbolic action and the surface of things. That's why you can say something like this as President:

| "I will end every single International crisis that the current Administration has created"

And not get laughed out of the room. Now Harris has taken advantage of this by basically not promising any policy specifics at all. Why would she? Almost anyone who cares about policy specifics is already in her corner. That's fine in the short term but in the long term if Republicans continue to nominate completely unserious candidates and by extension keep giving Democrats the freedom to make no commitments whatsoever the result will be even less public debate about foreign policy and an even bigger disconnect between citizens and an already insular foreign policy establishment and that would be bad because these people are not as smart as they think they are and cannot be trusted to be unsupervised.

Part II: The Wars of Donald Trump

I keep hearing something about Trump that I feel compelled to settle before the election just for posterity:

To quote Trump:

"Wars I had no wars other than ISIS which I defeated but that was a war that was started we had no wars I could stop wars with a telephone call."

Donald Trump didn't start any new wars so we are told. I know the statement is never really meant literally wars did start under the Trump presidency and while you can say none of those wars involved American soldiers by that standard Biden also started no new wars. What people really mean of course is they didn't feel at war unlike with Ukraine and Gaza. What most people who complain about the forever wars care about is not the human cost of the actual conflict but the psychic inconvenience of being made to think about those conflicts. The problem for any president is that that feeling is mostly a function of media coverage more than anything material so what I want to do today is make up for what the media didn't do 4 to 8 years ago. Let's talk about the wars of Donald Trump.

Before the Election

"So you've been elected president, it's your first day in The Situation Room, what three questions do you ask your National Security Experts about the world?"

As Trump was asked this question on CBS News GOP debate, he responded:

"What we want to do, when we want to do it, and how hard do we want to hit because we are going to have to hit very very hard to knock out ISIS."

It's worth remembering that Donald Trump didn't start his campaign as the "end the war" candidate. Trump was criticizing the war of course, but it was in the context of one, the traditional Republican complaint that humanitarian Rules of Engagement is getting in the way, and if you watch the debates you'd be forgiven for not being able to tell which candidate was running the most anti-interventionist campaign. On the same debate Rubio said:

"And I voted against Barack Obama's plan to use force and it was the right decision."

Other candidates quoted:

"A Barack Obama and Hillary Clinton's foreign policy and sadly too many establishment Republicans in Washington is they focus on issues unrelated to protecting this country. They focus on nation building, they focus on toppling governments to promote democracy. We should go to war when it is our direct interest, we should not be policemen of the world, not particularly in favor of us going to war in Iraq."

It wasn't just Trump who was looking for a way out of the Iraq War shadow but there was one man named [Jeb Bush](#) on the stage who didn't really have the luxury of being able to distance himself from [George Bush](#):

"So here's the deal I'm sick and tired of Barack Obama blaming my brother for all of the problems that he's had while Donald Trump was building a reality TV show my brother was building a security apparatus to keep us safe and I'm proud of what he did."

Trump responded:

"World Trade Center came down brother, remember that."

He continued:

"I want to tell you they lied, they said there were weapons of mass destruction, there were none and they knew there were none, there were no weapons of mass destruction."

This exchange more than anything else is what set Trump up as the anti-war dissident more than anything else.

On the same debate he continued:

"What are we doing we have to rebuild our country but we have to. I'm the only one on the stage that said do not go into Iraq, do not attack Iraq, nobody else on this stage said that and I said it loud and strong."

And it's tempting to say the reason this worked was because Trump was lying and people simply didn't know that Trump was lying and that he had also [supported the Iraq War](#), but I don't think that matters. I think what mattered was that Donald Trump wasn't a politician. That allowed him to claim that it couldn't be his fault that we invaded Iraq. Regardless of if he supported it, he had been lied to. How could he have known better? His alibi is every Republican's alibi. It is now the alibi of 70% of Americans. Implicating Donald Trump is to implicate oneself, and for the conservative movement as a whole this represented a breakthrough. Going along with the lie that Donald Trump was against the war was a way of creating a big lie that the Iraq War was really just a creation of elites or Jews rather than the conservative movement itself which had spent 2002 feverishly working to turn American politics into a fevered [neo-McCarthyite](#) quagmire in which people were simply too scared to dissent against the Bush Administration. And that big lie is just what the Republican Party needed to get the albatross of the Iraq War off their neck even as they campaigned on a platform of saturation [bombing for Northern Iraq](#) the so called Carpet bombing.

Trump on the silent majority with his speech:

"Somebody criticized me the other day because they asked me what I do and I said I'm going to bomb the shit out of them. It's true. I don't care, I don't care they got to be stopped."

And 30 seconds of uninterrupted applause ensued in the hall after Trump's words.

And this stuff played well with the other fight Trump had with Jeb Bush that night:

Jeb says

"And to allow Russia now to have influence in Syria makes it harder but we need to destroy ISIS and dispose of [Bashar al-Assad](#) to create a stable Syria so that the 4 million refugees aren't a breeding ground for [Islamic jihadists](#). This is the problem. Donald Trump brought up the fact that he would want to accommodate Russia. Russia is not taking out ISIS, they're attacking our team, the team that we've been training and the team that we've been supporting. It is absolutely ludicrous to suggest that Russia could be a positive partner in this. They are on the run, they are making every time we step back they're on the run. The question that you asked was a really good one about what you would do, what three things would you do. I would restore the military, the sequester needs to be reversed. I would have a strategy to destroy ISIS."

But he was interrupted by Trump that chimed:

"And let me just tell you this Jeb is so wrong. Jeb is absolutely so, that's just so you understand, you know what that is, that's Jeb's special interest. And talking at one time if you listen to him and you listen to some of the folks that I've been listening to, that's why we've been in the Middle East for 15 years and we haven't won anything. We've spent \$5 trillion dollars in the Middle East because of thinking like that. We've spent five and [Lindsey Graham](#), Lindsey Graham who backs him who had zero on his poll."

Jeb countered:

"The very basic fact is that Vladimir Putin is not going to be an ally of the United States. The whole world knows this. It's a simple basic fact from a guy (Trump) who gets his foreign policy from the shows. This is a guy who thinks that Hillary Clinton was a great negotiator in Iran. We're living in dangerous times. This is a man who insults his way to the nomination of President."

Donald Trump's softness on Assad if not outright support is the other issue which was used to paint Donald Trump as a break with neoconservatism but listen to the argument of Trump:

"We're going to also have to learn who our allies are. We have allies, so-called allies, we're spending billions and billions of dollars supporting people we have no idea who they are in Syria. Do we want to stay that route or do we want to go and make something with Russia? I hate to say Iran but with Russia it will work."

It's not an argument for non-interventionism but for shelving one priority, human rights, in exchange for an approach based on fighting the one great ideological foe with a tacit implication that nothing is lost because Arabs aren't capable of democracy anyway. And I wouldn't call that a rejection of neoconservatism so much as a return to the original neoconservatism (like Reagan time). Supporting dictators to fight a bigger ideological foe,

ridiculing human rights and implying certain people aren't really ready for democratic governments was the hallmark of people like [Jeane J. Kirkpatrick](#) (in her book: [Dictatorships and Double Standards - Rationalism & Reason in Politics](#)) and by extension much of the Reagan Administration. Just like the [Sandinista Revolution a.k.a. Nicaraguan Revolution](#) proved Latin America couldn't be trusted not to choose communism, the [Arab Spring](#) proved Arabs can't be trusted not to support radical Islam, and the prescription: back dictators to the hilt no matter how brutal. So it shouldn't be surprising that when Donald Trump took the White House a year later most neoconservatives flocked back to him (like [John Bolton](#)) and he did not in fact act like a dove.

War One: Syria

With a pro-Assad candidate in the White House Assad reasonably assumed he'd been given a green light to handle the rebels as he saw a fit. [PBS NewsHour's report](#):

"Now to the apparent chemical weapons attack this morning in Northwest Syria. The casualty counts range from 58 dead to over 100. Either way it was one of the worst such attacks in the country's 6-year Civil War."

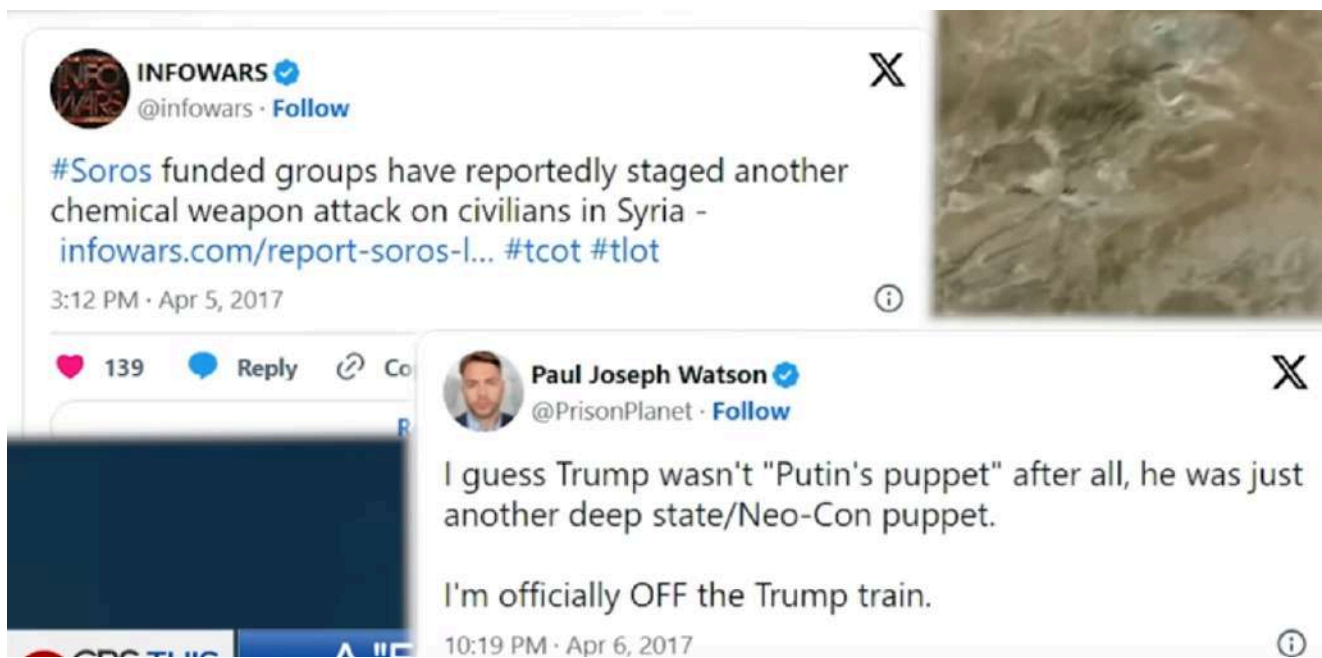
Instead Trump saw this (chemical attack) as personally embarrassing to him since a chemical weapons attack is the sort of thing that his ambient toughness is just supposed to automatically deter. So Trump demanded the Pentagon assassinate Assad for him, and at this point it was suddenly the Deep State which protected Assad from the anti-war populist. The Secretary of Defense simply countermanded the assassination order and waited for Trump to forget.

So Trump settled on a smattering of tomahawk missiles. The candidate who was supposed to team up with Assad to defeat the terrorists instead ended up doing what Obama wouldn't and bombed Assad but only enough to look like something without actually changing anything.

CBS Morning report:

"President Trump says he will respond forcefully to what he calls the atrocious use of chemical weapons by Syria's government. The regime is suspected of attacking the rebel held town of Duma outside Damascus with a chlorine agent. More than 40 people reportedly died. The president said a US response is imminent and it may extend to Syria's allies Iran and Russia."

So much for deterrence through strength. When Assad did another chemical weapons attack a year later Trump responded with a slightly larger set of air strikes after again being talked down by Jim Mattis, but even that was enough to spook the Russians who organized a massive disinformation campaign about the attacks.



That disinformation campaign immediately won the alt-right that Trump had betrayed them and Trump started to realize he might be losing his base and so he did another 180 turn.

News report:

"Tonight president Trump is defending his plan to pull US troops out of Northern Syria. We only have 50 people in that area, that's a small sector and I don't want those 50 people hurt or killed. The president tweeting it's time for us to get out of these ridiculous endless wars."

As ISIS had expanded east into Iraq, the only force that seemed to stand between it and Baghdad were the Iraqi and [Syrian Kurdish](#) forces. This made them a key partner for the American-led Coalition that intervened to push ISIS out of Iraq. But when ISIS was defeated that still left the problem of what to do with an ally that was permanently reliant on Western Air power to keep themselves safe. Staying in Northeast Syria would mean keeping America in an open-ended military commitment to Syria but leaving Syria would mean letting the Kurds get crushed between Assad and the Turks at a time when they were busy policing the underground remnants of ISIS. By withdrawing troops from Northeast Syria Trump had opened the Kurds up to an attack from Turkey, but the Turks, not wanting to risk its own troops, sent instead their Syrian proxy force, a force that included former [Al-Qaeda](#) affiliated fighters who did Al-Qaeda-like things like chopping heads off of female [Kurdish PYD](#). The withdrawal ended up costing over 1,000 people their lives and creating 300,000 refugees and Trump was probably expecting to get thanked for ending a potential quagmire, but in the previous few years the Kurds hadn't just gotten weapons from America, they had also gotten a massive amount of good press. So when he screwed them over the reaction ended up being well, negative:

As Nightly News report:

"The Kurds fought shoulder to shoulder with US Special Operations forces for 4 years against ISIS. They led it and they paid for it in blood. What kind of partners did you find

them to be? Committed, dedicated, formidable. Tonight the president's plan is being slammed by many of his allies."

So Trump did another 180 turn:

Fox Business alert:

"President Trump announcing new economic sanctions against Turkey along with increased tariffs following its invasion of Syria. The commander-in-chief also saying US troops coming out of Syria will now redeploy and quote remain in the region to continue to disrupt remnants of ISIS."

Donald Trump, trapped between two different intuitions of what plays good on television, was neither able to pull American troops out of the Middle East nor use them to protect allies and he managed to both bomb Assad's forces while still strengthening Assad's hand.

War Two: Qatar

The anxiety that any Arab democracy would immediately fall to radical Islam extends into the Arab world itself and it expressed itself in a very strange way. 5 months into Trump's tenure in 2017, [Mohammed bin Zayed](#) president of the UAE and [Mohammed bin Salman](#) Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia decided they were going to be the new Metternichs of the Middle East. They wanted to put an end to all this Arab Spring nonsense and roll the region back into a series of moderate but not necessarily secular authoritarian governments that could be conveniently organized into a tight anti-Iran Coalition. With Trump's election they realized they had a kindred spirit in the White House and that now was the opportunity to make their first big move.

One of the drivers of the [Arab Spring](#) had been the media and in the Middle East there was only one major media organization that was pushing the Arab Spring, their motto:

"Confronting power with courage and lighting the darkest shadows to inform and inspire. For even if we climb up the same mountain, we still walk on our own path."

[Al Jazeera](#) is owned by the government of Qatar.

In 60 Minutes episode a spokesperson of Al Jazeera stated about his agenda as news agency.:

"Egyptians watched the Tunisian Revolution live on Al Jazeera, discussed it on Facebook and took to the streets. Libyans watched the Egyptians, Yemenis watched the Libyans, and the Syrians watch them all here at Al Jazeera. Are you covering the news or do you have an agenda?"

Al Jazeera reported responded:

"What is wrong with transforming the Arab world from tyranny and despotism into democracy? What's wrong with that? If there is an agenda, it's a very good agenda."

After the Egyptian revolution Qatar started to get close to the [Muslim Brotherhood](#) and Qatar was increasingly trying to take on the role of middleman between the various Middle Eastern factions. But Qatar is a small little country surrounded on both sides by Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates and they would rather take control of these things for themselves.



So what followed was [Gulf Crisis](#):

"Saudi Arabia and other Arab states cut off all ties with their neighboring nation of Qatar, sending the Persian Gulf region into a new crisis."

Do you remember the orb picture of Trump?



Well this is what the orb meeting was about. They're at the opening of the global Center for combating extremist ideology and they took Trump there to teach him about how Qatar is the major source of extremist ideology in order to get his blessing for the blockade. So what you have here pretty straightforwardly is an entangling conflicts that Trump could easily diffuse by just saying no. He did not say no. And thus the following days he stated in the WH:

"The nation of Qatar unfortunately has historically been a funder of terrorism at a very high level and in the wake of that conference nations came together and spoke to me about confronting Qatar over its behavior."

Yet Trump didn't even bother to warn the state department so at the exact same time Trump tweeted out his endorsement of the Saudi blockade the Secretary of State put out a statement condemning it. This sequence of events led to a conflict that was primarily fought in a whole new domain of warfare: the Washington lobbyist domain. The Saudis, Emirates and Qataris all dropped massive amounts of money throughout the city commissioning as much propaganda as they could.



They fought a war of corrupt business deals and think tank contributions instead of tanks and bombs. The Emiratis teamed up with [Jared Kushner](#) possibly offering some kind of business deal in order to enlist his help getting rid of the Secretary of State [Rex Tillerson](#) and that seemed to be the winning move. Except well, the Pentagon was also furious about the blockade because America's biggest Air Force Base in the Middle East [Al Udeid Air Base](#) is in Qatar, so the president had just endorsed a blockade of his own Air Force. And you might say well that's not a real war, that doesn't count, and you're right. I only bring it up because it's going to be important context for what happens later.

War Three: Gaza

Netanyahu stated on the White House (HW):

"President Trump, by recognizing history, you have made history."

The Saudi Crown Prince wasn't the only leader to see a golden opportunity in an ultra-transactional president. Benjamin Netanyahu also was ready to make a deal and Trump delivered him a prize the Israelis had been waiting for for decades:

The news report:

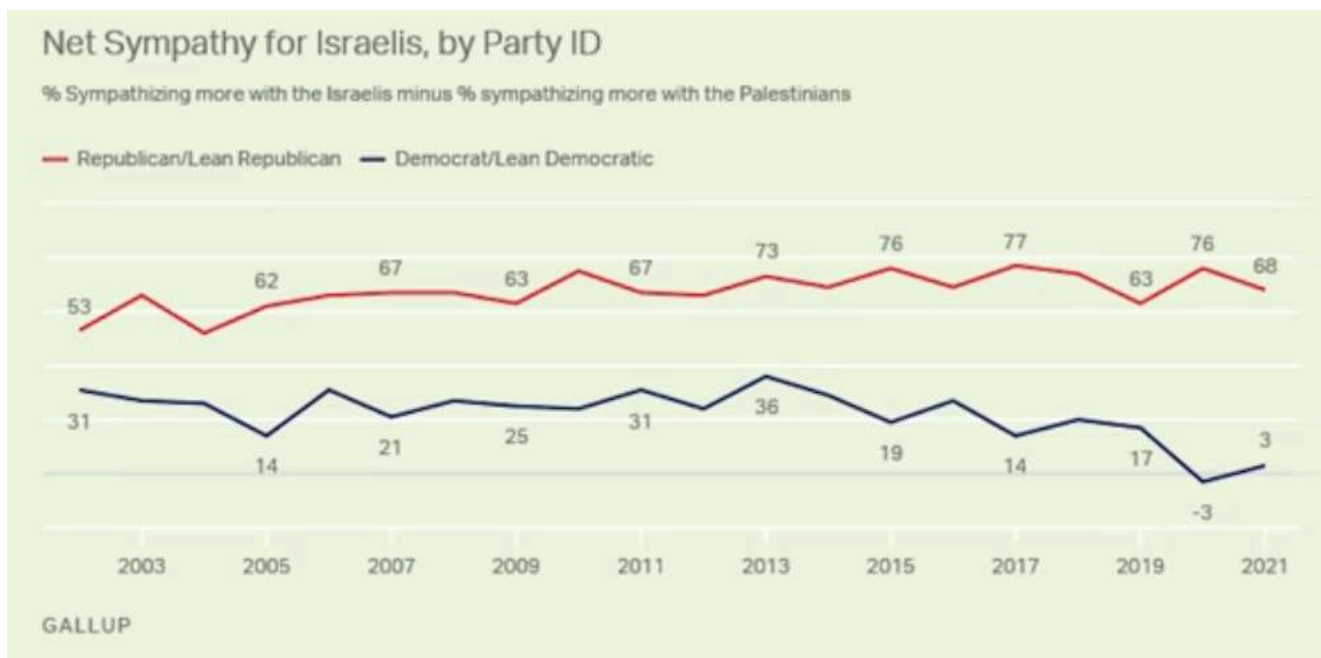
"The United States will officially move its Embassy in Israel from Tel Aviv to Jerusalem tomorrow. Protests are planned throughout the region tomorrow including what may be the largest demonstration yet at Israel's border with Gaza."

Moving the embassy from Tel Aviv to Jerusalem was seen almost universally as an American recognition of the annexation of East Jerusalem. The ensuing protests in Gaza against this were so large that the [IDF](#) dispensed with the normal tools of crowd control and instead switched to the more direct approach of just shooting people in the leg with live ammunition.

60 people died the first day but they came back the next day, naturally, and the next day. These protests have been going on for 6 weeks now with Gazans basically marching on the fence or the border around Gaza.

It took until the end of the year for the protest to peter out and by that point the IDF had shot 6,000 people. These shootings had a significant but not widely remarked upon effect on the conflict. For one it gave Hamas the perfect opportunity to make the case that nonviolent methods were useless.

For two, it gave Netanyahu a massive sense of impunity. I mean why wouldn't it? He had won everything betting on Trump, betting on the global wave of authoritarianism that Trump was also riding, and now he had shot 6,000 people and it barely made the news. Even the Arab world seemed mostly unbothered. There was no backlash at home or abroad, visible backlash that is. The Gaza shootings had a third effect: slowly and quietly it shifted [American public opinion to the Palestinians](#), but not everywhere.



Rather it caused a gradual but massive shift in age and partisan polarization. For Young Americans and Democrats sympathy for Israel dropped and just kept dropping. So while the Gaza March shootings didn't warrant too much media attention at the time, the stage was set for things to come.

War Four: Iran

Having inflamed both the Gulf crisis and the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, it was only a matter of time before Trump would flip the tables on Iran as well. Thus Trump stated at the WH:

"The Iran deal is defective at its core. If we do nothing we know exactly what will happen. In just a short period of time, the world's leading State sponsor of Terror will be on the cusp of acquiring the world's most dangerous weapons. At the heart of the Iran deal was a giant fiction that a murderous regime desired only a peaceful nuclear energy program. Therefore, I am announcing today that the United States will withdraw from the Iran nuclear deal."

This is by far the most mainstream of Donald Trump's foreign policy decisions and it's also the one I find the most baffling. I mean I can't in good conscience blame Donald Trump alone for not having a plan for what to do next. The neoconservative (FDD - Foundation for Defense of Democracies) think tanks that told him to do it also have no plan. The Israelis who begged for it have no plan. The Saudis have no plan. Iran just has the ability to build a nuclear weapon now and there's literally nothing they can do about it. So why in God's name did they want this? I can only chalk it up to a sort of mass epidemic of psychotic wishful thinking, a belief that Obama made a deal not because there was no military option but because secretly there actually was a great military option just sitting in the secret cabinet somewhere and Obama was just too much of a wimp to implement it. Well 12 years after Netanyahu announced that Iran was months away from a nuclear bomb, the Israelis still haven't pulled the trigger.

A brief editor's note: I wrote those words before the air strike exchange between Israel and Iran. Never even worried about needing to edit it. Nuclear War was never going to happen. Trump's move ended up discrediting the Iranian politicians who negotiated it: [president Hassan Rouhani](#) and his foreign minister [Javad Zarif](#). Undeterred, the [Ayatollah](#) shelved them and gave the reins to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps [IRGC](#) who immediately started launching attacks on oil tankers in the Gulf using a combination of low altitude cruise missiles and drones to evade radar. This comes at an extremely tense time in the region with the US warning just days ago that Iran or its proxies could be targeting Maritime traffic in the [Persian Gulf region](#).

And with that it was so much for peace through strength. This defiance was not what the Trump Administration was expecting. They thought they could sanction Iran and the sanctions would immediately drive the Iranians back to the negotiating table begging for a new better deal. Instead Iran responded by starting a new tanker war that threatened to raise oil prices in the middle of an election year, but then Trump got bailed out.

Anger, frustration and growing concern in [Tehran as people protested against the 200% increase in fuel prices](#). With the protests the Trump Administration now being spearheaded by [Mike Pompeo](#) changed tack and said that actually the point of the sanctions had never been to get a better deal but to bring about a regime change by way of popular revolt, and so actually everything was going according to plan. And so the Iranians, either because they needed the distraction or because they genuinely believed Pompeo, decided to escalate their attacks on the Americans.

News reported:

"Drama unfolding in Baghdad today that's the US Embassy surrounded by massive clouds of smoke. Hundreds of Iraqi protesters stormed the building this morning. They managed to make their way inside while US troops were still present."

So Trump escalated against them. Thus that followed:

"Shortly after arriving at Baghdad International Airport Major [General Qasem Soleimani](#) was killed in a US drone strike."

And the Iranians got ready to escalate again but then Trump got bailed out by circumstance again: with the growing certainty from US intelligence that it was an Iranian missile that brought down that passenger jet that crashed outside Tehran, and then Covid hit and just put everything on ice for 2 years. But while Covid tamped things down in Mesopotamia, things were heating up in North Africa.

War Five - Libya

After the Revolution Libya formed a [National Transitional Council](#) (NTC) to keep the country from collapsing while a new government was organized. After a year of political wrangling the NTC held new elections for a constitutional Congress called the [General National](#)

[Congress](#) (GNC) which was then given 18 months to write a new constitution. They missed that deadline which triggered a fail-safe clause in the interim agreement to hold new elections and hand over power to a new [House of Representatives](#), but that election and handover was declared invalid by the Supreme Court. But there was still no Constitution and with no Constitution to fall back on for what to do next neither side was willing to concede the legitimacy of the other. So Libya now had two legislative bodies: the GNC and the House of Representatives, both claiming to be Libya's rightful government. And during all of this none of the hundreds of militias that had arisen in the revolution had actually been disarmed and they began picking sides. So with the constitutional crisis the country broke apart. The result wasn't a full-blown Civil War but a sort of ambient chaos, more Lebanon than Syria.

Enter [Khalifa Haftar](#), a Gaddafi General who turned on [Muammar Gaddafi](#) after getting captured by [Chad](#) in the [Toyota War](#). He had been spirited out of Africa by the CIA who set him up in Virginia where he lived for the next 20 years and became an American citizen, but during the revolution he flew back to Libya to volunteer himself as a leader of the new Republic's Army. He then won popular acclaim in the East by chasing out the Islamist militias that had taken control of [Benghazi](#). When the country split up between its two governments Haftar sided with the House of Representatives. I say sided with, really he had taken over. He's the one with the Army after all. Now at this point the state department and the United Nations recognized the GNC and tried to start a Reconciliation process to get a ceasefire between the two sides, but the Saudis and the Emiratis had other ideas.

Now we have to go back to Saudi Arabia and their weird passive aggressive war on Qatar. While both sides in the Libyan conflict have Islamist militants, Haftar made a point of advertising himself as the real secularist who would basically return Libya to status quo ante-bellum including not just the suppression of radical Islamic militants but any political movement associated with the Muslim Brotherhood. So the Saudis and Emiratis, happy for another opportunity to roll back the Arab Spring, decided to arm Haftar to the teeth while Qatar on the other hand had thrown in their lot with the GNC, but it was only in 2019 that the situation broke out into a real war. Haftar, tired of negotiating, decided he wanted to take the whole country by force. The Saudis and Emiratis agreed. The Egyptians who wanted peace on their border also agreed to chip in.

Together they enlisted, you guessed it, Emmanuel Macron the president of France who was [looking for a way to get more favorable oil contracts](#) and a Libya that would do more to keep migrants from crossing the Mediterranean Sea. They then went to Vladimir Putin who had always believed that the Libyan Revolution was an American power play to take Libya out of the Russian sphere of influence so he jumped at an opportunity to roll back the revolution. To this end he enlisted a little known oligarch named [Dmitry Rogozin](#) and dispatched his new little mercenary company called [Wagner Group](#) to Libya to help Haftar. Haftar now had the combined forces of Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Egypt, France and Russia.

There was only one last question: how would the Americans respond? If they put their foot down the war couldn't work. Well knowing the state department would oppose any war, the president of Egypt through Jared Kushner and [Steve Bannon](#) organized a direct phone call

directly between Trump and Haftar in which Haftar would ask Donald Trump for his personal public support in his mission to defeat terrorism, probably without explaining what that would really mean. But it appears to reverse US policy on Libya. It confirms that President Donald Trump spoke with General Khalifa Haftar, that is the man in charge of the military force which is currently attacking the UN backed government in [Tripoli](#). That it recognized Haftar's significant role in fighting terrorism and securing Libya's oil resources. So the mission was now a go and civil war ensued.

For a while it seemed like Haftar would win but the GNC had allies of its own. Qatar wasn't the only country that had formed a relationship with the Muslim Brotherhood. After the revolution in Egypt in both the emergence of Egyptian democracy and its crushing by a military coup, Erdogan the president of Turkey saw echoes of his own country and so he was eager to step in to help the GNC. In addition to Turkey the Italians of all people also decided to step in for the GNC since Italy had signed a back room deal with the GNC affiliated warlords to help keep migrants away from their Islands. What I find most interesting about this war besides the degree to which it was ignored by the media is how unnecessary it was. Libya is not all that important to any of these countries. The reason they all decided to turn it into a game of Risk and kill 10,000 people in the process is because the state department was effectively decapitated. They just did it because they could because the mobs were asleep. It's just thousands of people died because the president of the United States was too much of a dipshit to read his briefing book and the country around him couldn't be bothered to give a shit about the damage that would do.

War Six: Afghanistan

The war in Afghanistan was the most enduring symbol of what was increasingly being called the Forever War, but actually withdrawing troops from Afghanistan presents a dilemma:

If you pull out troops the Afghan government will fall and the [Taliban](#) will take over which will be devastating politically to whoever is president at the time of the fall, but if you don't pull out troops you open yourself up to the accusation that you're a warmonger.

Obama as he was always inclined to do tried to make both sides happy by splitting the difference and withdrawing most of the troops but leaving enough in to keep the major cities unmolested and he was immediately accused of being no different than the neocons by the left and accused of sabotaging a plan that would have permanently made Afghanistan stable if he had only stuck to it for another 6 more months by the neoconservative right. Trump's solution to this dilemma was so bluntly cynical I almost admire it. Trump simply cut the Afghan government out of the loop, directly negotiated a surrender to the Taliban and set the date of withdrawal to take place right after the next presidential election. Then after the election but before Biden's inauguration he purged the Pentagon and put in a new class of loyalists with orders to sabotage the withdrawal by pulling out as many troops as precipitously as possible, thus saddling Joe Biden with a heightened version of the old Afghanistan dilemma: either pull out the unsustainably small deployment before Afghanistan is ready for the handover and trigger an immediate collapse, or redeploy more soldiers to

make it more sustainable for a more orderly handover but in doing so violate the agreement with the Taliban and bear the accusation that you escalated the war you promised to end. Biden made his choice and Trump got to become Schrodinger's peace candidate: the president who deserves all the credit for ending the war but none of the blame for the consequences of ending the war. You can't call it a stupid strategy, but the question is this: are we that stupid?

And to quote Trump again:

"I will end every single international crisis that the current Administration has created including the horrible war with Russia and Ukraine which would have never happened if I was President."

The convoluted nature of policy especially foreign policy means that causes and effects can be separated by years. The consequences of a bad policy, the benefits of a good policy are not usually reaped during the presidency of whoever made the policy. This is perhaps worse on the issue of climate change where the gap between policy and effect is so distant as to be unfalsifiable and maybe it's too much to ask for voters to do the work of going back and actually looking at real causes and effects and whoever wins an election is always ultimately not going to be about merit but about dumb luck of timing.

But Trump has introduced a new approach that may be more dangerous: knowingly implementing bad policies but in a way where the consequences only happen after you leave office. Previous presidents did not do this for the simple reason that they were afraid they would be called out on it. Trump has betting that the current climate of distrust for experts will protect him from anyone who points out his game and I'm worried about what will happen if such a transparently cynical strategy works. I mean assume all the dooming about how Trump will destroy democracy is wrong, every following presidential candidate is still going to look to Trump for lessons on how to win. You could already see this happen with how Trump corrupted the Democratic party after 2016. Candidates went from treating voters like they were 10 to treating voters like they were four and Biden has been terrified of making even the slightest challenge to special interests lest he end up getting shanked like Obama. In fact that's the reason his foreign policy has been so bad. Outside of Ukraine there's more continuity between him and Trump than between him and Obama. If Trump wins because voters are so bad at connecting cause and effect that you can engineer their blame like [Pavlov's dogs](#) by just timing things right, every president is going to start using the same tactics. Whatever constitutional Crisis comes and goes, that institutional rot will remain. It won't just be one president but a bipartisan dynasty of presidents like this. People sometimes like to dismiss criticism of Trump by saying that he is basically the same as any other president. The only real difference is how he says things, but in diplomacy what you say is policy. It turns out that when you are the president of the United States being a huge blundering dumbass who constantly says stupid shit really does in and of itself get people killed.

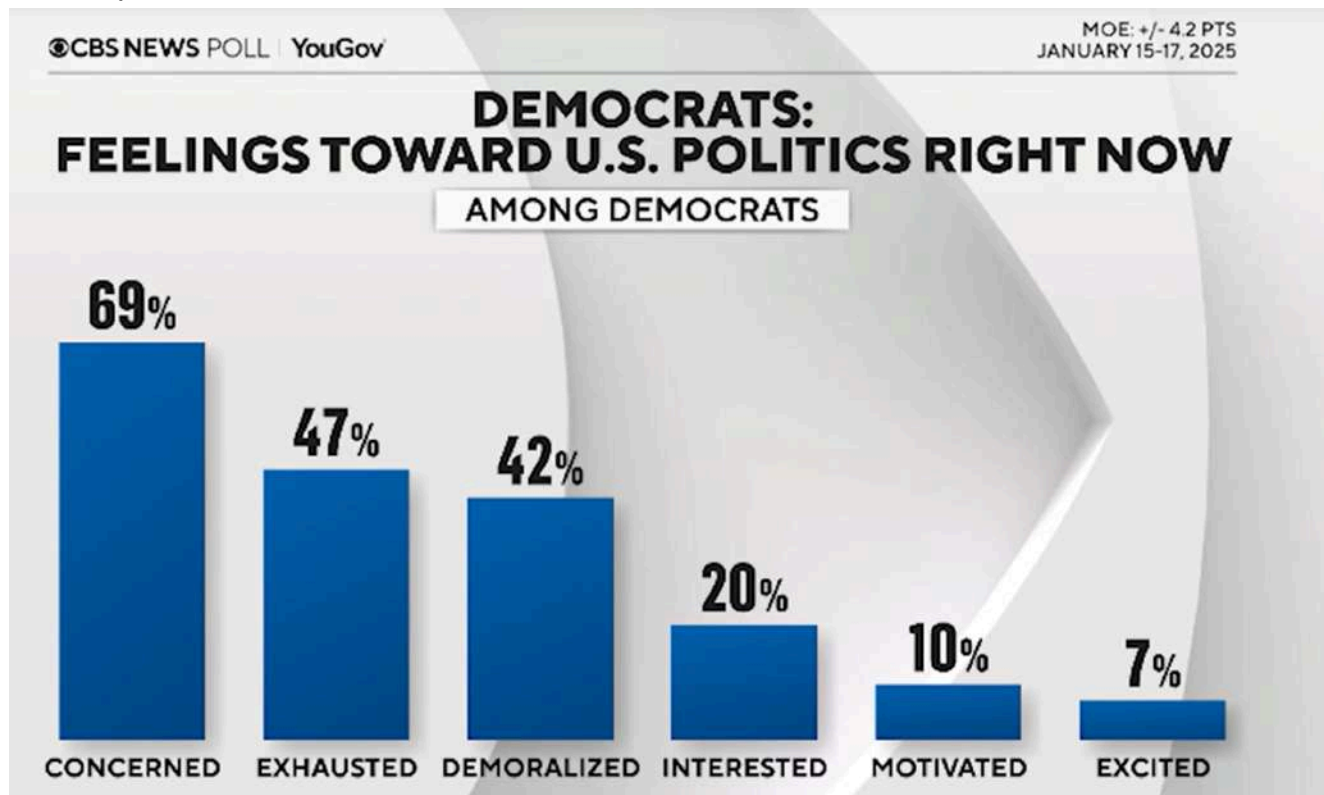
You can see it now in Ukraine. It's not just the Trump statements have had effects only for the past 4 years either. The time gap between policy communication and consequences can happen the other way. The anticipation of a new Trump term is already hurting Ukraine right now. The reason Putin is ramping up the violence and throwing so much armor at the wall in Donetsk despite a looming tank shortage is because he's gambling on Trump freezing the line in February so he's trying to grab as much land in the east as possible.

There's a precedent for Trump's style of doing foreign policy: constantly saying careless things, massive mood swings between over-the-top threats and going over the head of diplomats in favor of poorly thought out schemes. That precedent is the [Kaiser Wilhelm II](#) of Germany. I'll leave it to you to decide if Kaiser Wilhelm's policy was effective at preventing a World War.

Part III: Five Reasons Trump Will Fail

Okay, this is weird. At the time I'm writing this, Donald Trump has recently been sworn in as president and ... well... it's just bad. But this is what's weird: it feels like Trump's opponents have given up. So obviously Democrats lost, despite all their hopes and not only did they lose, they lost across the board. But this feels like more than just an election victory. We've also seen the tech leaders supporting Trump, Facebook appeasing him, media organizations caving to his lawsuits, and everyone from Walmart to McDonald's scrapping diversity programs. Commentators have described it all as "changes in the vibes" or "the Great Vibe shift" a "psychic landslide" with "American culture ... primed to turn decisively to the right."

The response to all this from Democrats and the Left has been weak.



Democrats describe themselves as "exhausted" and "demoralized", and it's all a big contrast to the "Resistance" and marches that followed Trump's first term victory in 2016. The feeling on the left seems to be that Trump's power, his agenda, his politics, is overwhelming, and that this is just a new almost permanent reality we're going to have to deal with. This, I think, is a mistaken point of view that over-estimates his power and chances of success, and in this part I want to explain why. In the news generally, and especially right now, there's so much noise and confusion.

Everything changes in politics

Something I've noticed in all the years I've been studying and covering politics and the news, is that there are moments when a person or party's power just feels overwhelming, and it just never lasts. Right now Donald Trump feels invincible, full of confidence and momentum. But this will change, because... as I say, everything changes in politics. In 1964 President [Lyndon B. Johnson](#) won a landslide victory. Four years later, he didn't even seek re-election

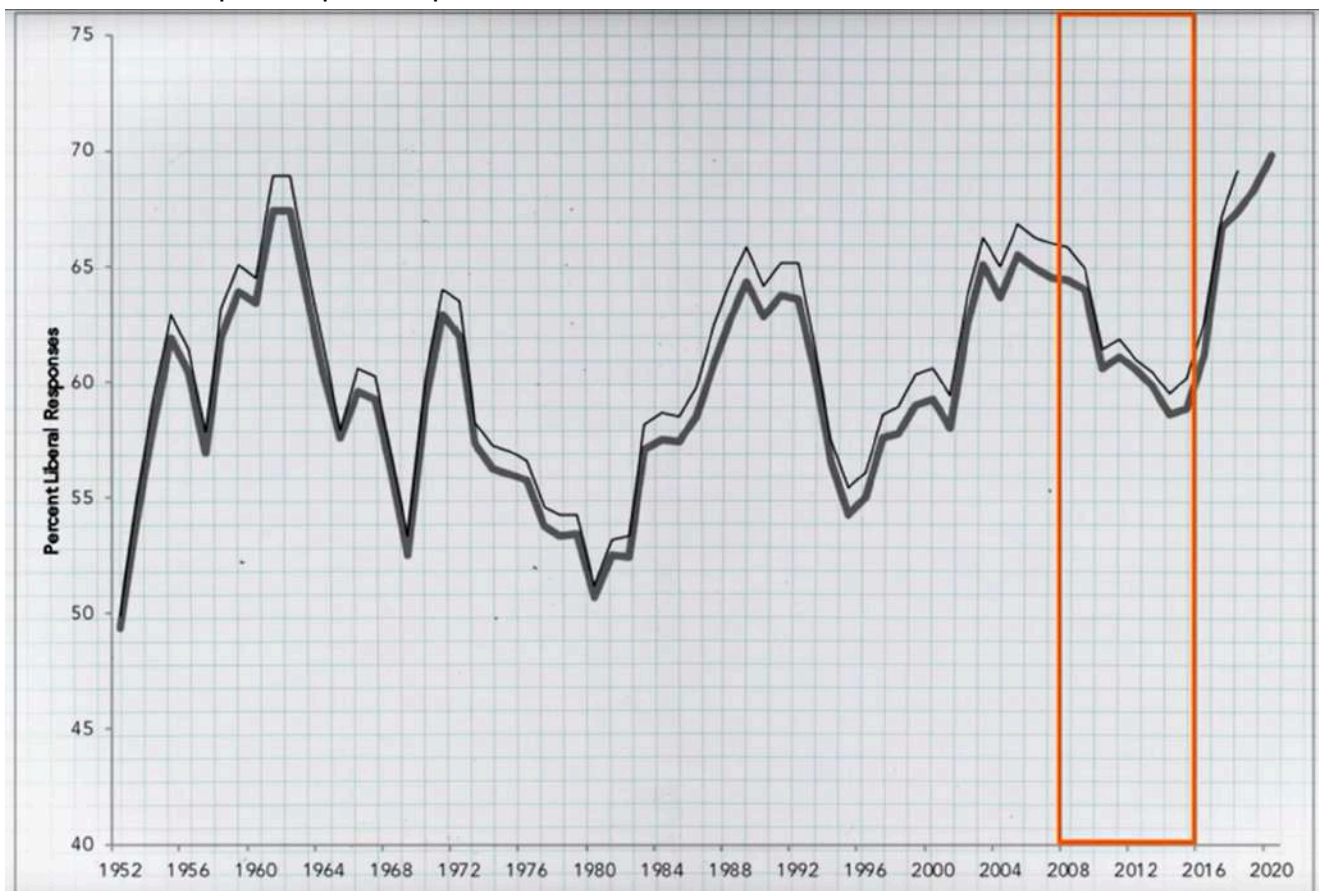
things had got so bad. In 1972 [Richard Nixon](#) won a landslide. Two years later he had resigned. [Jimmy Carter](#), [George Bush](#) ... there are many more examples of presidents losing support. In fact this is a well-established finding in presidential scholarship - and as this article explains, one factor that accelerates this process is when a president "says or implies he will do more than he can do" — something of course we've never seen from Donald Trump:

"That is a war that's dying to be settled. I will get it settled before I even become president."

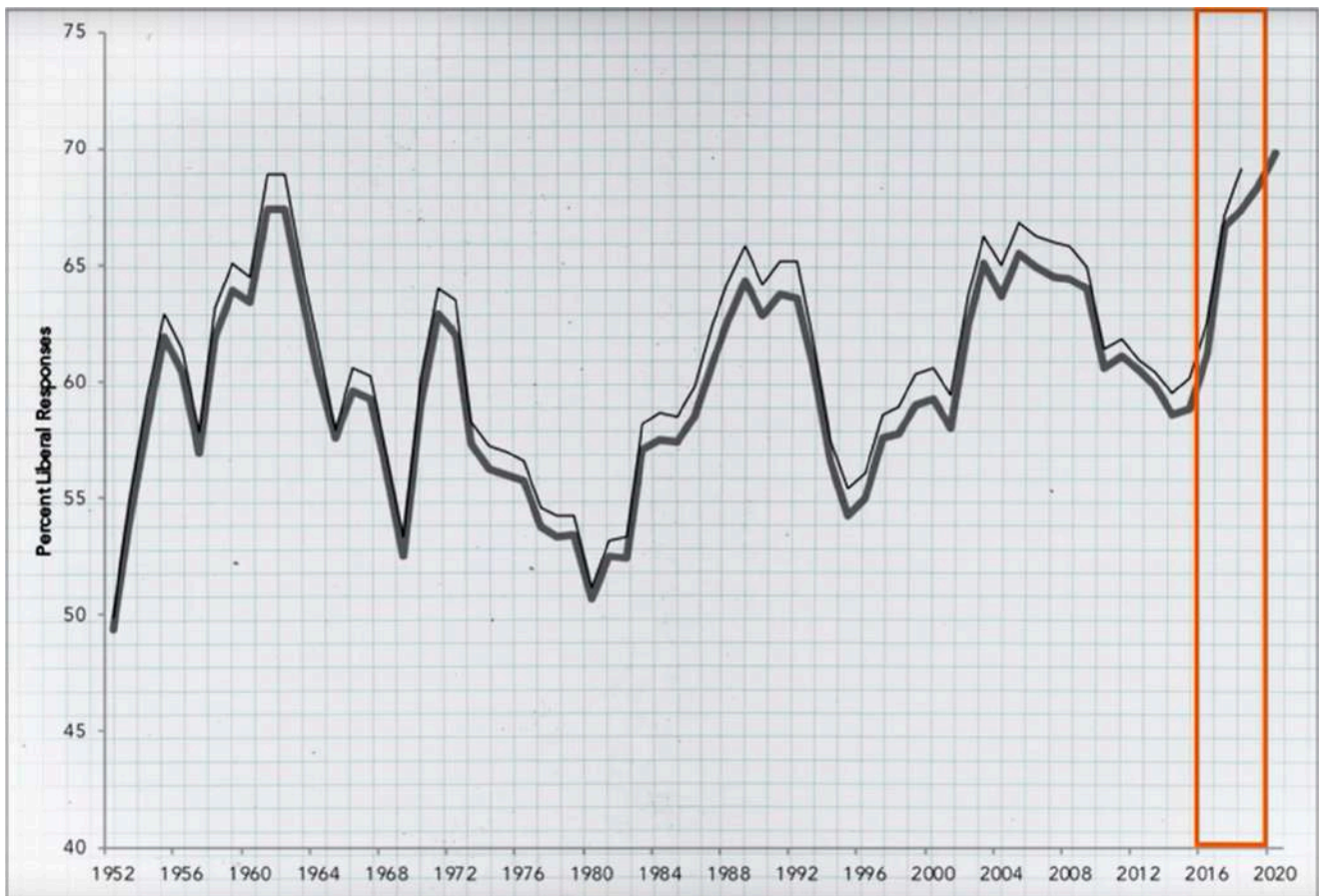
And there's another reason we should expect to see public opinion move against Trump's agenda, even if the public has just voted for that agenda.

Thermostatic politics

This phenomenon is called "thermostatic politics" and it describes the way public preferences naturally shift in the opposite direction of government action, a bit like a thermostat reacts to a change in temperature. So when left-of-centre President Barack Obama was in power, public opinion moved in a conservative direction;



and when conservative Trump won in 2016, [public opinion went leftwards](#).



So it's reasonable to expect support for Trump and his politics to fall. In fact people forget how Trump's approval ratings really tanked in his first year of office. But this is a wider point than just American presidents - it's about how power is always contested; and how it's easy to be overwhelmed by the present and forget that everything changes. I mean even dictators who don't have to worry about voters lose their power. Maybe the best symbol for my point here is the ancient idea of the wheel of fortune: the goddess Fate spins the wheel at random, those on the top fall to the bottom, and those at the bottom, move to the top. Nothing lasts forever, and that's especially true in politics.

You break it, you own it

In his first term Trump had many more limits on his power. In Congress, the Republican party, and in the people he appointed to his cabinet, he faced opposition; which is much less the case now. This is a disaster. But the silver lining is that it's much harder for Trump and his supporters to blame others when things go wrong.

Incumbency fatigue

A key idea here is "incumbency fatigue" whereby the governing power, the incumbent, is worn down by the political controversies, policy failures and scandals that are almost inevitably part of being in power. And let's be honest, there are going to be many of all of those. The argument against this of course is that Trump and his movement will lie, and voters — their brains addled by partisan media — will believe them. But propaganda has limits, and populists like Trump often struggle with voters, once they have a record that they have to defend. In Brazil, [Bolsonaro won 55% of the vote in 2018](#), but after [mismanaging COVID-19 killing 600,000 Brazilians](#) and [environmental issues](#), lost the 2022 election.

Another example of this of course is Trump - who couldn't win reelection in 2020. More generally we're seeing voters turning away from incumbents and voting for opposition parties. This was bad news for opponents of Trump in the last election but now he's in charge the phenomenon works in their favour.

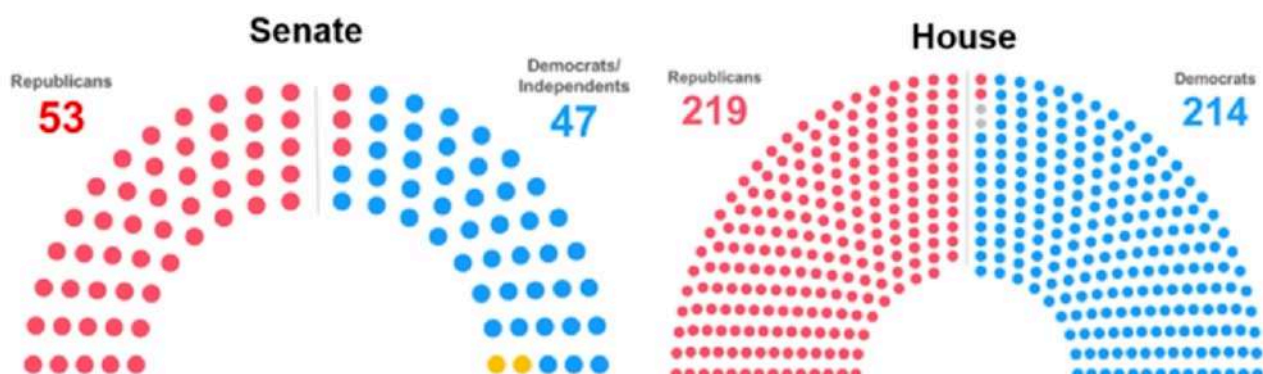
Overreach

In the 2024 election, Trump won all seven swing states as well as the popular vote, and it was a more emphatic win than many were predicting. But it's worth remembering it wasn't actually a landslide in terms of presidential election [history and the margin of Trump's popular vote victory](#) was smaller than Joe Biden's Hillary Clinton's or either of Barack Obama's victories.

Winner of popular vote			
Election Year	Winner of Popular Vote	Popular Vote Percentage	Margin of Victory (%)
2024	Donald Trump	49.8%	1.5%
2020	Joe Biden	51.3%	4.5%
2016	Hillary Clinton	48.2%	2.1%
2012	Barack Obama	51.1%	3.9%
2008	Barack Obama	52.9%	7.2%

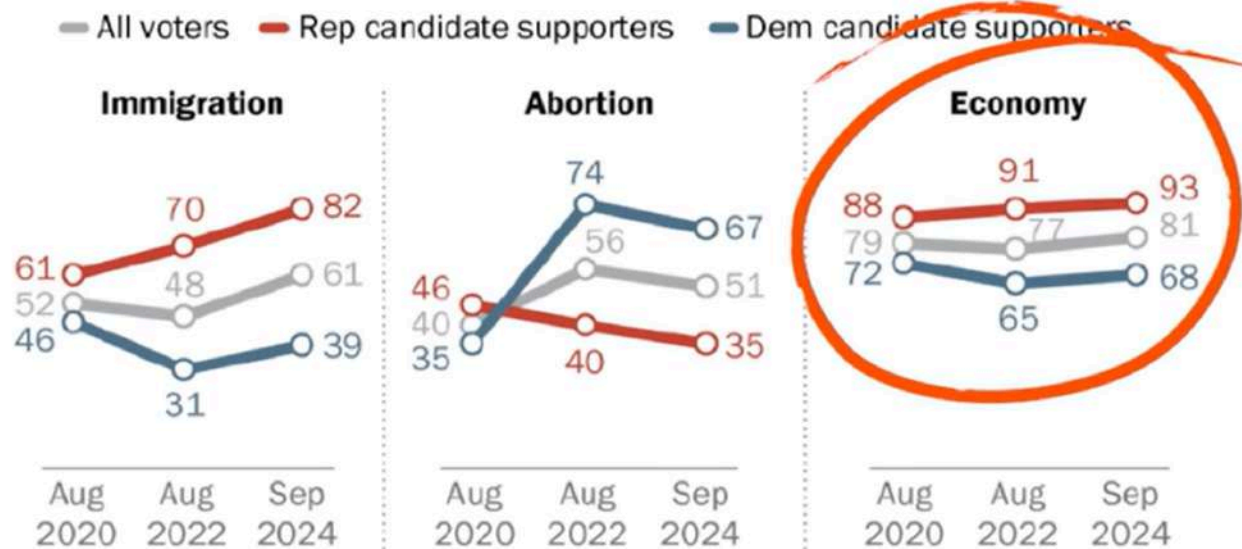
Also, his majority in the House is narrow, and his [Senate majority](#) can't survive the filibuster.

GOP Will Have Slim Majorities for 119th Congress



What's more Trump's win was about everyday issues, with resentment at inflation and concern about the economy being a key voter concern.

% of registered voters who say each issue is **very important** to their vote in that year's election



Note: Based on registered voters. In 2020 and 2024, candidate supporters are for the presidential election. In 2022, candidate supporters are for the congressional election.
Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted Aug. 26-Sept. 2, 2024.

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So it's not an overwhelming endorsement... but how does Trump see it? He stated after the assassination attempt on himself:

"My life was saved for a reason. I was saved by God to make America great again."

Trump and his movement are going to overreach. A mixture of over-confidence and a seemingly genuine belief in divine mission are going to make them go too far and alienate voters. Already we've had pardons for the January 6th rioters (like [Daniel Rodriguez](#) who attacked police with a stun gun), some of whom attacked police officers in the most horrific ways; tariffs that are likely to drive up prices for consumers; a chaotic freeze on federal grants and loans that then had to be reversed days later; and Elon Musk doing this.



MAGA extremists will no doubt love all this, but of course not all Trump supporters are MAGA extremists. Trump — like all politicians — has a coalition of support, made up of core voters and more moderate, less ideological swing voters; and much of this will go down badly with this less extreme group of voters. Even Trump knows his movement can be too extreme - look how he distanced himself from abortion bans in his campaign. In fact some Republicans have already joined the criticism of pardons and tariffs. What will make this overreach even worse, is that Trump cannot run again in four years time – though I admit we can't be sure he won't try – but that means, for the next four years, the others in the MAGA movement will be maneuvering to be Trump's successor.

Purity spiral

These are the perfect conditions for a purity spiral, when members of a political movement compete for leadership by becoming ever more extreme. And this will all be made worse by the echo chamber of conservative media, that will push MAGA ever further away from the concerns of ordinary voters. So expect to see overreach and ordinary voters turned off as a result.

Succession failure

Talking of leadership contest, let's get to the next point: Trump's successor will not have his charisma. The Dune stories illustrate how power works, I shared the idea that power is made up of both raw coercive force — how many soldiers, guns and weapons, you have – and legitimacy: the belief others have that your authority is right and justified. In the [Dune](#) stories the main character rises from refugee to leader of the Fremen and to do this he taps different sources of legitimacy from religious, traditional, ideological... all of which increases his supporters' belief in him.

Charisma

One of the key types of legitimacy he uses however is charisma. .. what sociologist [Max Weber](#) described as

"... the absolutely personal devotion and personal confidence in revelation, heroism, or other qualities of individual leadership".

Trump has this. Some weird mix of celebrity, personality, dark humour and cruelty that fascinates and attracts attention and loyalty in a way that is extraordinary. But that's the point, it's extraordinary. None of the other MAGA types have this. And when Trump-lite candidates, have tried to run on extreme MAGA ideas but without his charisma they've failed. And so while a lot depends on what Democrats do next time, it's reasonable to predict that if any of the current gang of Trump wannabes want to win, they will move more to the centre. My prediction is that Trump's politics without Trump's charisma are not a winning formula.

His ideas won't work

Okay, there's a lot we could say here. Trump says he wants America to be strong and respected abroad, but much of his foreign policy - freezing all American aid for example - is likely to strengthen China and America's adversaries. As we've seen, Trump voters care about the economy but tariffs are likely to increase prices and hurt growth. But I guess if I'd have to pick one self-defeating move, I'd pick the way Trump is breaking the rule of law; which defined basically, is the principle that you have to follow the rules, regardless of who you are.

Rule of Law

Some of Trump's actions, like the pardons, I might not like, but they were clearly part of Trump's presidential powers; but many of his other actions are not: freezing funds Congress has authorized; firing Inspector Generals without notice despite the law saying otherwise; shutting down USAID... .. it's a long and growing list of illegal actions that even some conservatives have been criticizing. The point here, is not that these actions are necessarily unpopular with voters, but that they chip away at part of what has made America strong and its businesses successful: in America you have to follow the rules, businesses and property can't just be stolen, governments have to follow the laws, and presidents can't just do what they like. Trump supporters — and lots of us — want America strong, but breaking the rule of law makes America weaker. Okay so there are the five arguments...

Conclusion

Of course this is all small comfort to those affected negatively by Trump's actions in the meantime; and of course predicting the future is always a foolish thing to do. But I hope this article can act as a kind of corrective to what feels like a moment of overwhelm. Encouragingly there are now maybe signs Democrats are starting to regain their mojo and oppose Trump's actions. But whatever happens, it's worth remembering that while Trump's

position may seem dominant now, power fades, opposition builds, and reality bites, so, ultimately, Trump will fail. Actually while we're talking Trump, one of his first executive orders was on "RESTORING FREEDOM OF SPEECH" but at the same time he pledged to cancel student visas of pro-Palestinian protesters, when of course protest is a basic democratic right. This is actually part of a recent pattern of attack against free speech by the Right, and in I'll be doing an article why both Right, and the Left should protect freedom of expression.

Part IV: Elon Musk is self-destructing (and Trump will pay)

We need to talk about Elon Musk. Why? Because, as Trump said:

"I have created the brand new Department of Government Efficiency: DOGE. Perhaps you've heard of it?"

Elon Musk's [Department of Government Efficiency](#) is sweeping through the federal workforce. ... what can only be described at this point as a purge across multiple government institutions... People getting fired, people getting furloughed – in droves. They are raiding the government. Since Trump took power, Musk has taken a central role in the administration: closing agencies, halting payments, and firing thousands of government workers. To Musk's supporters he is someone with a proven track record of innovation and success; whose bold and decisive actions are just what are needed to fix the US government.

But in the opinion of his detractors – well let's be honest, in my opinion – he is a disaster. Now hating on Musk isn't unusual - there are plenty of videos about everything from his hypocrisy on free speech to exposés revealing how often he lies about his video gaming achievements. But what I want to show in this article is that he is a disaster, not only for Americans but for Republicans, and the conservative causes they seek to promote. Well in this Part I want to do a deep dive on the ideas behind Elon Musk's radical approach to government, a set of ideas about technology and business that are becoming influential in politics, even outside America. And I will show how these ideas are already having disastrous results damaging Donald Trump, his agenda and ultimately, his presidency.

Let's start with Musk's fundamental mission, and in Elon Musk's own words:

"I'm a technologist and I try to make technologies that improve the world and make life better. And that's why my t-shirt says 'tech support' because I'm here to provide the president with technology support."

Musk believes he's here to save civilization using technology. He creates Tesla to solve climate change, SpaceX to make humanity multi-planetary and he buys Twitter to save free speech. Okay, look, I'm not saying I agree with his thinking - but I honestly think this is how it sticks together in his mind. Civilization needs to progress but he's here to help. In fact there's this one line in one of Musk's interviews, which I think is kind of revealing. in which he states:

"Really this is like taking the brakes off of an economy and of a civilization We need to snap those strings that are holding Gulliver down and preventing us from making progress as a civilization."

I think this metaphor of strings tying down [Gulliver](#) captures the essence of Musk's view of the world.



Next to the little people you have the giants: extraordinary, talented individuals that progress relies on. (I wonder who he could be thinking of?) And yet these people and businesses are tied down with regulations, unions and investigations about why their self-driving cars keep crashing (as per [Tesla faces NHTSA investigation of 'Full Self-Driving' after fatal collision](#)). But now, in this mission to protect civilization, he needs to help the US government.

Musk states on Fox News:

"America is the central pillar holding up Western Civilization. That pillar must be strong. If that pillar falls the whole roof comes crashing down... There's no place to hide. No place to run."

So that's point 1: **Use tech to save the world.**

Okay next: for Musk, once you have the problem, the solution starts with physics and what he calls "[first principles analysis](#)". First principles is kind of a physics way of looking at the world. And what that really means is... you kind of boil things down to the most fundamental truths and then reason up from there. For example, if you're trying to make a cheaper battery for an electric car. So that's the first principles would be to say, okay, what are the material constituents of the batteries? Okay it's got cobalt nickel aluminum carbon... so break that down. If we bought that on London Metal Exchange, what would each of those things cost like? It's like \$80, per kilowatt hour. If you want to solve problems forget convention or what the experts say, use your own reasoning and work from there.

So that's point 2: **Ignore rules and convention, and trust your own smarts.**

The next part of how to solve problems, is that you should move fast and accept the risk you'll make mistakes. For example, on a production line, you need to be bold if you want savings: and to quote Musk again:

"Attempt to delete the part or process step ... and if you aren't forced to put back at least 10% of what you deleted, then you're obviously being far too conservative in your deletions."

And he believes the same approach should be used in government:

Elon Musk:

"Here's the thing: if you delete departments and regulations, you can always put them back. If it turns out those were very important, you can always bring them back."

All this comes from a point of view on risk and failure that is common in business. In fact Musk is known for sharing videos celebrating failures. The most famous articulation of this idea is Facebook's old motto 'move fast and break things', and Musk is taking this approach into government: In the White House he states:

"Should say we will also... we will make mistakes. We won't be perfect. But when we make a mistake, we'll fix it very quickly."

So there's point 3: **Move fast, take risks and if you break things, it's a worthwhile trade-off.**

The next part of Musk's thinking is his view about government workers - who he believes do little work and have gone rogue. and in his words:

"If the bureaucracy is fighting the will of the people and preventing the President from implementing what the people want then what we live in is a bureaucracy and not a democracy."

This is partly the MAGA idea of the "deep state" but it also comes from Musk's experience at Twitter.

Interviewer:

How do you run the company with only 20% of the staff?

Musk:

Turns out, you don't need all that many people to run Twitter.

Interviewer:

But 80%—that's a lot.

Musk:

Yes. If you're not trying to run some sort of glorified activist organization, and you don't care that much about censorship, then you can really let go of a lot of people.

So not only do bureaucracies go rogue but they fill up with little people who stand in the way and the example of Twitter shows you can make big cuts without problems.

So Point 4: **Bureaucracies hold us back.**

The final element of Musk's approach is what we might call an attitude of "you don't have to like me". Elon Musk states in the New York Times

"I have no problem being hated by the way. Hate me away."

He loves to say false and offensive things - especially online and generally acts like his job is a chance to have fun.

Partly this is Musk being an entrepreneur - people who gain success by going counter to everyone else. And partly it's the 'screw you mentality' of someone who's made so much money they don't need to care. But besides all this, he's a troll: enjoying all the attention negativity can bring.



Okay, so there's the Musk worldview.

So how is this all going to go wrong and hurt Donald Trump? Elon Musk has repeatedly called his actions in government a "revolution", a word that sounds dynamic and impressive. But if you think of the history of actual political revolutions in China or Russia for example - they are often violent, destroy the economy and make their countries weaker.

The most famous person to make this argument was [Edmund Burke](#), who back in the 1700s predicted the French Revolution would end in disaster. At the heart of Burke's argument was a belief that making sudden radical changes based just on abstract reasoning was dangerous.

In other words, trusting only your own smarts with something as complex as politics is a mistake, exactly what Elon Musk is doing. Burke wrote:

☞ Men little think how immorally they act in rashly meddling with what they do not understand"

This idea is a key part of the conservative tradition. For example the economist [Friedrich Hayek](#), often revered by conservatives, once gave a famous lecture, where he cautioned about how hard it was to understand complex systems like the economy, and explicitly warned about trying to imitate the procedures of the physical sciences (in his white paper: [The Pretence of Knowledge](#)). And Musk does just that to quote him again:

"First principles is kind of a physics way of looking at the world."

The lesson here is that if you're someone like Musk, trying to enact big change, then you should do it cautiously, mindful of how little you know. But is this the approach Elon Musk is taking? No of course not, which is why Musk keeps doing things in a dumb way. First there's all the waste - dozens of clinical trials frozen and abandoned mid-way through, with millions of dollars of U.S. taxpayer funds already spent to start those trials are now wasted. food aid in warehouses that's already been paid for but now can't be delivered to those that need it; even the pointless deletion of all the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's. But there's lots more that's dumb. For example, [Musk's "fork in the road" email offering federal workers 8 months pay for no work if they agreed to resign](#). Even if you agree with the aim of reducing the federal workforce this is a bad way to do it, because those most likely to take the offer are not the useless left-wing activists Musk believes fill the workforce, but those most-able to get private sector jobs. In other words, probably the best and most effective workers. [Musk has even fired over 6000 IRS](#) workers who help collect taxes when he's meant to be cutting the deficit. I mean, I run a business, and if I was in financial trouble I wouldn't fire the person who collects payments. Musk's actions also indiscriminately affect military families and veterans.

Even if you support Musk's aims, and even if you don't care about military veterans, needlessly gifting your opponents sympathetic stories like this is not exactly smart.

The point isn't that Musk is dumb. I think Elon Musk has a track record of impressive achievement, though I'm not sure we're getting the most aware or capable version of Musk at the moment by any means. The main point is that politics isn't physics. when you just 'reason from first principles' and arrogantly reject expertise and knowledge, you'll do dumb things, waste money and make mistakes. And in fact, "mistakes" takes us to our next point.

Government is not a start-up

Musk is carrying out a revolution and in revolutions you can make mistakes. However, as we saw at the start, taking risks and making mistakes are part of how you succeed in business, a philosophy of '*move fast and break things*'. Besides, when mistakes are made, they're fixed quickly. ... we'll fix it very quickly. Foolishly Musk said in the White House:

"So, for example, with USAID, one of the things [we accidentally canceled very briefly was Ebola](#). Ebola prevention. I think we all want Ebola prevention. So we restored the Ebola prevention immediately, and there was no interruption."

But let's see how this worldview does when it comes to the things government does. Let just look at Sudan. And what you will find is deeply distressing: a country in the grip of the largest [humanitarian crisis in the world](#). In the tainted camps where families have fled war every newly arrived child is critically starving. Sudan is in the middle of a civil war, and the US has been funding a large food aid program. But [in January, a stop-work order was issued without warning](#) meaning "staffers at a half dozen U.S.-funded medical facilities... who care for severely malnourished children had a choice to make: [Defy President Donald Trump's](#) order to immediately stop their operations or let up to 100 babies and toddlers die."

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On Friday morning, **the staffers at a half dozen U.S.-funded medical facilities in Sudan who care for severely malnourished children had a choice to make: Defy President Donald Trump's order to immediately stop their operations or let up to 100 babies and toddlers die.**

They chose the children.

In spite of the order, they will keep their facilities open for as long as they can,

In the end the staff ignored the order and continued their care. Finally, four days later, the administration in effect admitted it had made a mistake, and said lifesaving humanitarian

efforts would be given waivers and allowed to continue.



There's been countless other mistakes: women with medical devices left inside them, and at least one woman died after her oxygen supply was cut off following the sudden freeze. Plus, over a month after humanitarian projects were apparently exempted from cuts, money is apparently still not flowing. In fact even the cancelling of Ebola prevention, the mistake Musk promised was fixed quickly, hasn't actually been fixed yet. Of course there are problems with waste and corruption in overseas aid, but even if you agree the policy of reducing it, why not put the waivers in place first? Why not give local health services warning so they could take over programs? Because that's not the philosophy. Because Musk thinks:

"If you delete departments or regulations, you can always put them back."

Musk says you can just reverse mistakes but in government if you move too fast, it's not things you break, but people. And what happened as a result: [The FDA is looking to rehire around 300 people...](#) [The Trump Administration will reverse staffing cuts to the 911 health fund...](#) [Hundreds of workers at the national nuclear security administration fired then nearly all rehired days later.](#) the [Veterans Affairs Department reinstated terminated employees and the USDA is rescinding termination letters sent to people working on the response to bird flu.](#) USAID is not the only area where there have been many mistakes and it's likely we'll see more in future as Elon Musk takes big risks with everything from IRS data to the treasury payments system.

At the heart of all this what we might call the "government is a business" fallacy, the mistaken idea that what works in business should necessarily work in government. Elon Musk has created some really important and valuable businesses. But if one of Musk's risk-taking ventures goes wrong, and ends up crashing the value of the company, the damage is contained. Whereas in government where you're dealing with things like humanitarian aid, Ebola prevention, and nuclear security, the cost of things going bad are so much higher.

Extreme risks are fine in business, but governments aren't businesses, and it's a mistake to think they're the same.

A war on yourself

Next let's look at Musk's war on the bureaucracy who he believes have gone rogue and who he knows from his experience at Twitter, can be cut drastically without impact. Well the first thing to say is there's going to be impact. I've saved lives dangling off of cliffs in the North Cascades.

[Over 4000 workers from the US Forest Service and Park Service have been fired](#), where, according to reports, cuts will mean fewer people to clean bathrooms, collect fees and rescue lost hikers.

sounding the alarm that parks will be short-staffed during the summer season, when more than 100 million Americans and international tourists typically visit.

“There will be nobody to **clean the bathrooms**, nobody to manage parking, nobody to **collect fees**, nobody to issue permits, nobody to ensure mountaineers entering into steep glaciated terrain have the requisite skills and equipment ... nobody to go **rescue injured or lost hikers**,” one wilderness ranger said. “People will die from incidents that would otherwise be just another Tuesday for us.”

At the Environmental Protection Agency, meanwhile, leaders of the agency's largest union said 388 members were terminated Friday

That's not "waste" where you cut costs but maintain the same product or service - that's just reducing your service, making the thing worse. Similarly if you fire a thousands from the VA; hundreds of staff from [NOAA](#), the agency that helps with weather forecasts; or half the Social Security Administration's workforce – this isn't going to be impact-free.

Second, Musk's actions are self-defeating because the way he's doing it is destroying what is often known as "state capacity": the ability of the government to execute on what it's directed to do. Think about it. Donald Trump and his people have things they actually want to do with state power: deport migrants, grow the economy, invade Greenland... whatever. But Musk's mad revolution is disrupting everything - even the agencies Trump values. Just while I was writing this, [Musk had a bright idea to send an email to all federal employees asking them to report on what they'd done that week](#). There was little warning, confusion over the email's purpose and worries about national security with [one agency warning employees to assume the email will be read by 'malign foreign actors'](#). The disruption affected everyone...

the State Department, Defense and the National Security Agency. parts of government which aren't exactly unbusy at the moment. As a result, even Trump's own cabinet have started pushing back against Musk, sick of the way his chaos is disrupting their ability to get things done.

Musk believes that bureaucracy holds us back, Okay, Musk is doing dumb things, making mistakes, and causing needless damage and harm. but you might be thinking: will this really affect Donald Trump? After all, Trump screwed up his first term and people still elected him in 2024... and he certainly doesn't seem to care about Musk's recklessness. Will any of Musk's madness actually damage Donald Trump?

You can't ignore gravity

To answer this question I want to start here. let me hear this quote:

"But I now have \$80,000 worth of material and signed contracts for labour that are going to install the water lines in an upcoming few weeks and months. And with that being said, they call me today and said, hey, I know we have a signed contract. We're reneging on it."

This is a farmer called [Skylar Holden](#) who is now \$80,000 out of pocket because of one of the sudden stops on government payments. Holden isn't a Democrat - he voted for Trump and is from a state that supported Trump. I spent money based on a contract that we signed.

Holden's situation isn't unique. There are thousands in a similar position as federal grants and funds have been suddenly stopped, often in red states. Republican-voting states have been impacted in other ways too: the cuts to USAID have hit farmers that supply the programs, the cuts to research funding have hurt places like Alabama where universities are the state's largest employers. And it turns out there are a lot of federal workers in Republican states - [Texas for example has the second highest number in the country amounting to 129,738](#). So the answer to whether Musk's actions will affect Trump, is yes, because – and I know this sounds simplistic – if you keep doing stupid or unpopular things, voters will notice, and you will lose political support.

From Georgia to Oregon to Kansas, Americans angry with President Trump's sweeping layoffs and Elon Musk's drive to slash government spending, packing raucous town halls. Elon Musk has contracts with the federal government. Conflict of interest!

And while American democracy is on the decline, we're not yet at the point where support doesn't matter. Unlike in business where you have complete control, in politics, you need to stay popular, at least with your own side. Already, we're seeing rowdy town-hall meetings in Republican districts and increasing signs Republican lawmakers are becoming unhappy. Musk's approach of course is "you don't have to like me" happily clashing with other Trump

supporters, even agreeing that, quote,

of course. But **we hope, that when it's all said and done, ALL politicians, Democrat AND Republican, are furious with DOGE.** Then we will know that it was a job well done for the American people.

6 PM · Feb 10, 2025 · 6.1M Views

"we hope that when it's all said and done, ALL politicians, Democrat AND Republican, are furious with DOGE."

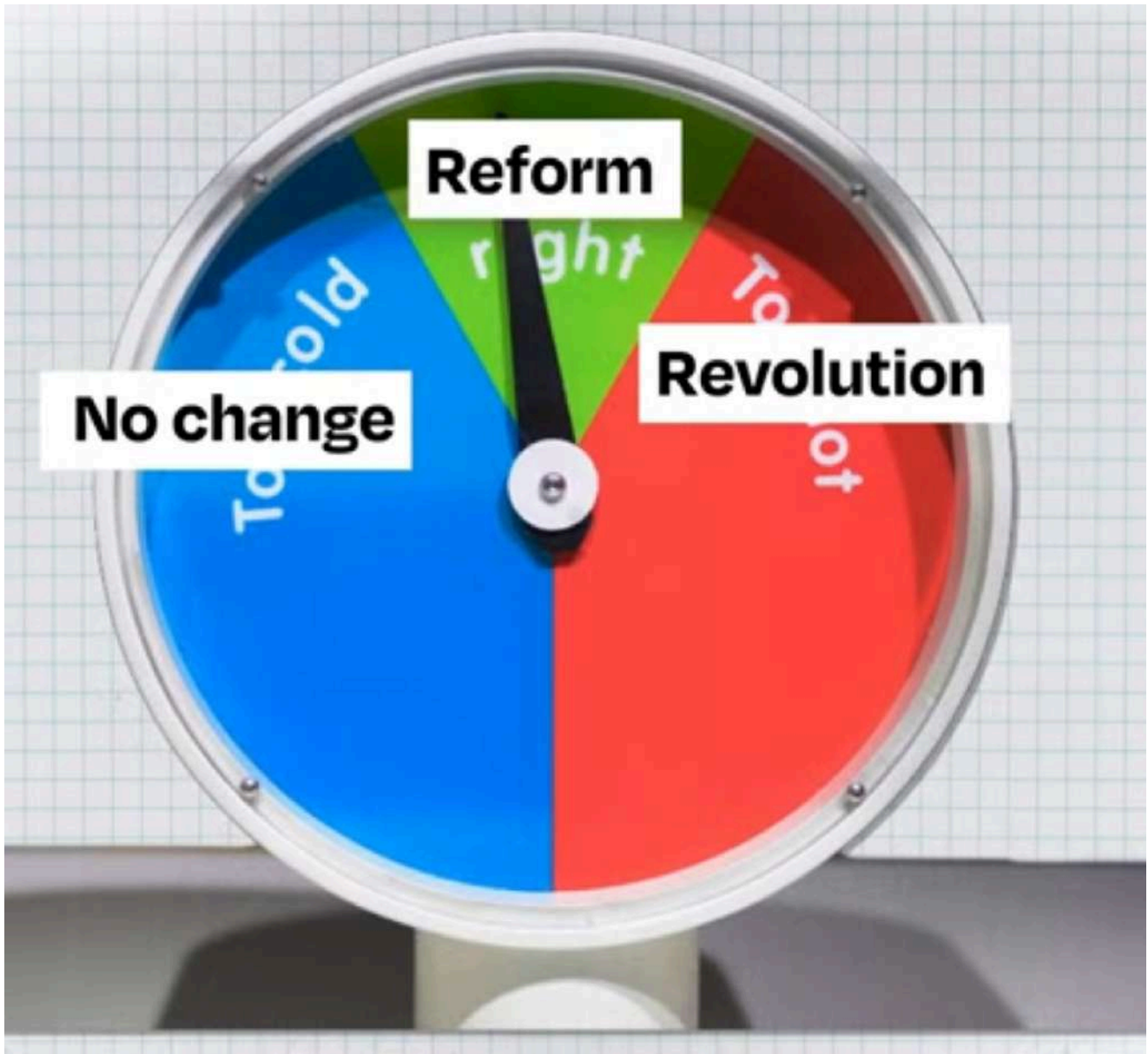
But Musk will find you can't ignore politics, it's like the law of gravity - you can pretend it's not important but in the end it will make itself felt. There's another way Musk's 'you don't have to like me' style is going to go wrong. Musk is addicted to attention. But his unceasing desire to offend people – calling workers who are losing their jobs "evil", "criminal", a "ball of worms" for example; his constant stream of lies and falsehoods; and the general way he's treating the whole thing as a game – – not only means he's unpopular – actually a drag on Trump – but it's creating a kind of accountability trap for the whole administration. Trump, like all populists, likes to blame things on people when things go wrong. For example, [after the midair collision in Washington that killed 67 people](#), Trump speculated it could have been caused by DEI policies. But the next time there's a plane crash, critics will be able to point to the fact Musk fired hundreds of technicians and engineers who maintain critical air traffic control infrastructure. And voters are more likely to buy this argument, because (1) the cuts may well be to blame but also (2) Musk's attention-grabbing style will mean they remember these cuts happening - after all, it was all over the news. Or consider the next time there's a weak response to a natural disaster, and you realize critics can point to the [cuts to Federal Emergency Management Agency \(FEMA\)](#). If there's a hazardous accident and the clean-up is poor, the spotlight will be on the [cuts to the # Environmental Protection Agency \(EPA\)](#). If there's a disease outbreak, people might remember how [Musk cut over 1200 staff from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention \(CDC\)](#). I mean as I'm writing this two people have died in a measles outbreak and just two months ago, a lethal strain of bird flu claimed its first victim in the United States. Elon Musk might be having fun but "you don't have to like me" is bad politics and politics still matters.

Not a "tech support" problem

I guess some people listening to this might be thinking, but don't we need change in government? I agree we need change and in fact even our old friend, Edmund Burke in his book "[Reflections on the Revolutions in France](#)" wasn't against reform saying:

“a state without the means of some change is without the means of its conservation.”

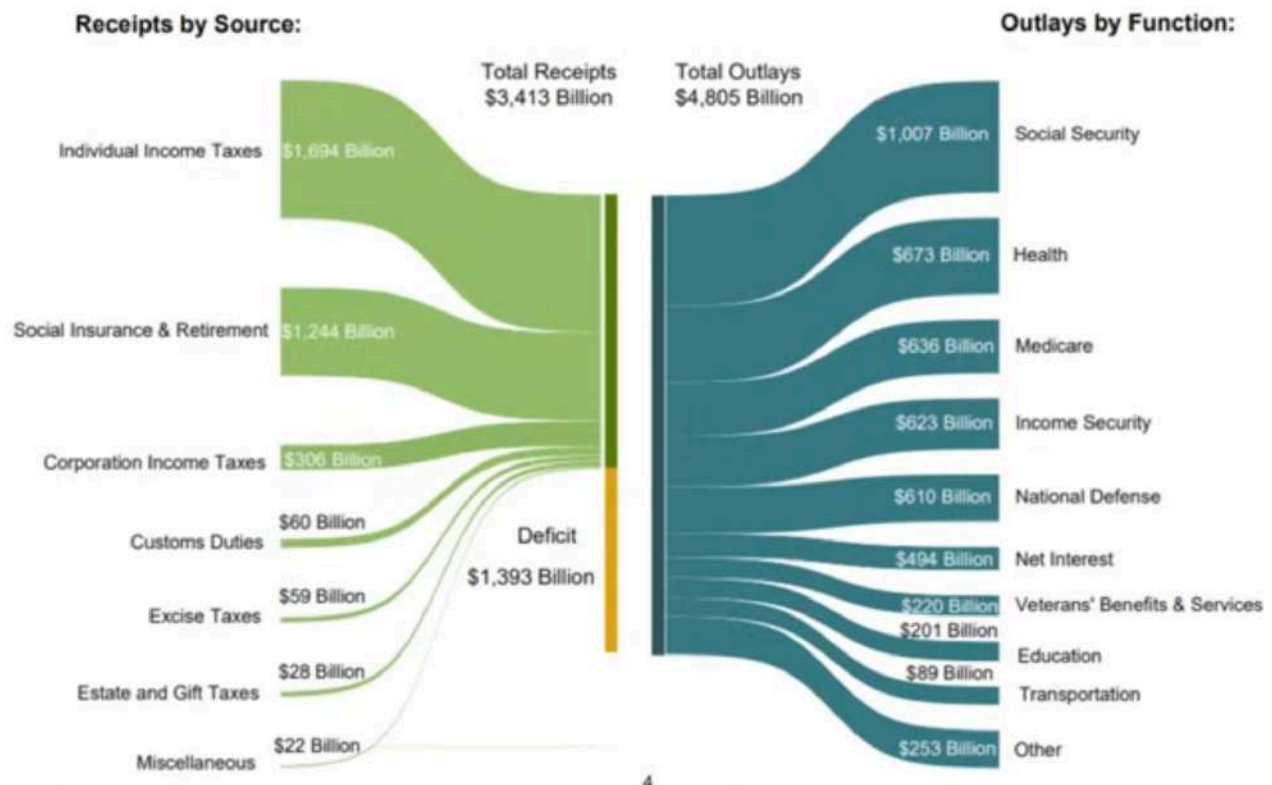
But rejecting mad revolution doesn't mean sticking with the status quo. Instead we have boring old 'reform' that aims to achieve change without the unnecessary mistakes and damage of Musk-style chaos.



And in fact Trump and his administration have a way to reform government, a mechanism designed for it in fact: called politics. You know, writing legislation, negotiating with Congress... After all Trump has power in Congress, a conservative court and a mandate from voters. But Musk represents a move away from that - disregarding politics, and opting for tech revolution - in a way that will ... well not work. First, there's the way the judiciary has repeatedly stopped and delayed Musk's actions. Ignoring the political process doesn't make it go away it seems. But second, using the political process is the only real way to achieve real results. [DOGE has boasted of some \\$65bn savings so far](#), and though journalists have found many errors in their maths, the bigger problem is that [government over-spending was \\$1.8 trillion](#) last year. So all the apparent DOGE savings don't even add to 4% of what's needed. Fundamentally over-spending will be solved only when tax revenue increases, or

voters can be convinced to be happy with less spending and the things the taxes provide.

Figure 2. Cumulative Receipts, Outlays, and Surplus/Deficit through Fiscal Year 2023



That's a political project not a technology project. And even if you're a Trump supporter that doesn't care about the deficit particularly, consider what a waste of political capital it's been. So much noise, so much burnt political support, spent on a project that hasn't really achieved anything. During the French revolution there emerged the phrase "you can't make an omelette without breaking a few eggs" as a way of saying some people get hurt by change but it's worth it. but Musk is a failing revolutionary: the equivalent of breaking the eggs, but not actually making the omelette. Not everything is a tech issue, and while it might sound boring, the truth is some problems can't be solved without politics. There is nothing wrong with using technology to improve government and nothing wrong in a good-faith effort to cut government spending or improve the bureaucracy. But this reckless, arrogant, lethal chaos is not that; There's so much I haven't talked about in this article, the damage to the rule of law, the conflicts of interest, the risk of corruption, and why so much of this agenda is bad for America, but I wanted to make the case that, even if someone admires much of what Musk has done in business, In fact, even if they support Donald Trump and the whole agenda, this is clearly a disaster. And while it's little comfort to the everyday people caught up in all this, I do really think this "revolution" will come back to haunt Elon Musk and Donald Trump. After all, as another saying from 1700s France goes:

☞ evolutions devour their children, and that's true, even if they do a lot of damage first.

Part V: Trump Just Broke the Populist Right

When Donald Trump won the US election in 2024, it was something of a shock to the system. As I've explored before, [commentators described it as the 'great vibe shift'](#), a sense that Trump's populist vision was now victorious in America. But his victory also had an effect in other countries. In the UK, it was another boost to [Nigel Farage](#) and his party, Reform, with speculation (not least by him) that he could even become the next prime minister. In [Germany, with elections approaching, the momentum was with the far-right AfD](#); In Canada, [Pierre Poilievre seemed on course to become the next prime minister](#); and generally the news was full of commentary about the inevitable "rise of the far right". But since then things have changed a bit. To quote some:

"We are likely just days away from a federal election campaign and the winds in Canada's political sails are changing course " "I cannot think of a swing that happened as quickly" "Europeans are in shock just days before the German federal elections..." "... sparked anti-US demonstrations..." "Farage's run of good news seriously stalled this weekend..."

From Canada to the UK and other European countries, the seemingly inevitable rise of the populist right seems to be faltering. Some are even speculating about whether this is the "twilight of the populists". when Trump won I used some of these concepts to argue Trump's presidency would soon falter. But what I didn't consider is that his actions would also damage populist right-wing movements around the world. In this part I want to explain what's going on, and share three ideas that will explain not only why this is happening, but that will also be useful to you in understanding the news long after today's headlines have been forgotten.

Populists of the World, unite!

We should start by recognizing that for a movement that was against globalism, the populist right has been a very global movement. On [Conservative Political Action Conference \(CPAC\)](#) conference the speaker proclaimed:

"I don't know how CPAC became a global brand fighting the globalists with people here from like every country all over the world, but let's go with it."

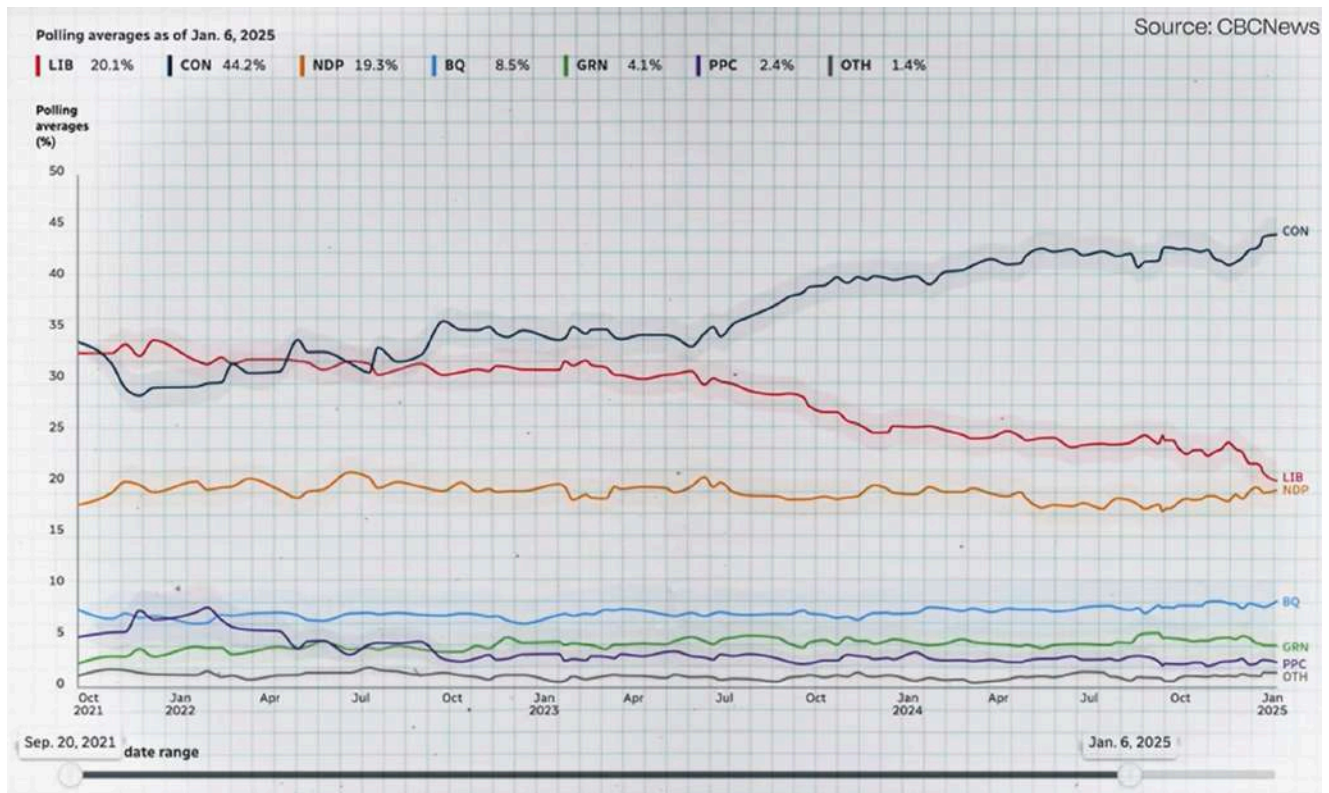
In the US, the annual CPAC conference is often addressed by populists from other countries; Steve Bannon has toured Europe in efforts to spread MAGA ideas; Elon Musk has addressed rallies of the AfD, and various populist voices like [Jordan B Peterson](#) of North America have regularly visited European conservative conferences. Across the world populists on the right have found common cause over many things, including a dislike of "the woke agenda", establishment elites and the media.

But another key idea that brought this movement together was a belief in national sovereignty: strong borders; anti-immigration, and opposing globalist institutions. But once in

power, the way Donald Trump has pursued his America First agenda has destroyed this international solidarity, and the best example of this is Canada. Trump says:

"I do like the Oh Canada... It's a beautiful thing, I think we're going to have to keep it for the 51st state. I call him Governor Trudeau."

After Trump's victory the Liberals, Canada's main left-of-centre party led by Justin Trudeau, were unpopular - with only 20% support in the polls.



And Conservative leader, Pierre Poilievre was certain to become the next prime minister. But since then Donald Trump's aggressive tariffs, and insults towards Canada, have led to a patriotic backlash...

For some time Poilievre has been described in the press as a populist, a kind of Canadian Trump. But now this association with Trump has left him vulnerable.

The result, as I writing this, is that the Liberals have gone from being over 20 points behind to actually being ahead, and could actually win in the election - which would have been unthinkable not long ago. Now it's worth saying that the change in polls is not all about Trump. But it isn't only in Canada where we've seen populists getting frustrated.

The AfD came second as expected in the German elections, but have been locked out of power by the other parties; Marine Le Pen, the leader of French populist party National Rally, has had to distance herself from Trump, condemning the "brutality" of his policy on Ukraine; and Giorgia Meloni, populist prime minister of Italy, is also having to walk a fine line because of Trump's actions. And there are similar pressures everywhere from the Netherlands, to Denmark - who Trump is threatening to take Greenland from. And as Anders Vistisen the Danish member of the European Parliament said:

"It is not for sale... let me put it in words you might understand: Mr Trump, fuck off."

Now the news and polls will change, but I think what we're seeing right now is deeper than this particular moment: it's about a problem at the level of ideas. You see, however warm this international populist movement, there was, hidden under the surface, a contradiction. I've wrote before about how there are different types of nationalism. For along with ethnocultural nationalism, often associated with persecuting minorities and war, this isn't the only option. I, for example, feel something closer to a civic idea of nationalism - a love and attachment to the country I live in, without that meaning I want to insult or attack other countries.

Ethnocultural nationalism	Civic nationalism
Closed	Open
Based on ethnicity	Based on citizenship
Superior	Equal
Hostile to diversity	Embraces diversity
Exclusive	Inclusive

A reason why I'm drawn to this kind of nationalism is reciprocity - an idea at the heart of philosophical liberalism. If we want freedom of religion we have to give that freedom to others. if we want freedom of speech we can't restrict that freedom to ourselves. And if we want respect for our country's sovereignty and borders, then we have to respect it in others. But of course Donald Trump is no liberal, he has no principled respect for the ideas of sovereignty and borders. If he believed in these principles he wouldn't insult Canadian national identity at its most basic level, he wouldn't talk about taking over Greenland, and he'd be angry about Putin's invasion of Ukraine. I mean if you think the World Economic Forum is an attack on national sovereignty, consider an invasion that's trying to wipe your country off the map. Populists around the world famously disdain liberalism, but at the same time it seems they had a liberal expectation that Trump would respect their countries as they respected the US. Instead they got an ego-centric power trip, which quite understandably voters have rejected, with populist ideas tarnished as a result.

So that's reason 1: **nationalism without liberal reciprocity falls apart and becomes just aggression which, unsurprisingly, voters reject.**

MAGA madness

The second way Trump has caused problems for populists in other countries can best be explained by looking at the UK. Nigel Farage, the leader of right-wing party Reform UK, loves Donald Trump. and Trump's election victory gave his party extra momentum. Farage states:

"They had an election on November 5th and they've got a new president chap who's a friend of mine Donald J Trump is now their president."

Nigel Farage, leader of the right-wing party Reform UK, loves Donald Trump. And Trump's election victory gave his party extra momentum. But listen to Nigel Farage more recently: Farage:

"I'm not a populist..."

Interviewer:

"I've heard you call yourself a populist"

Farage:

"I've realized I'm not, I've realized..."

Interviewer:

"Just last week you called yourself a populist"

Farage:

"I am not, I am not a populist. If you think about the issues that I... "

Interviewer:

"Are you rebranding in front of our eyes?"

Farage:

"If you think about the issues that I've championed they've nearly all been small minority issues."

The reason for this change is similar to what's been happening elsewhere: Trump's actions have been unpopular. As well as talk of tariffs, there was the attack on Zelensky and Ukraine who most in the UK see as a war hero; [And JD Vance's dismissal of the UK as "a random country that hasn't fought a war in 30 or 40 years"](#) also went down badly - with many pointing out UK soldiers fought in Iraq and Afghanistan. This would have been bad for Farage at any time... but it's worse because Farage is trying to move his party away from the extremes in order to increase its support. I mean, I know this might seem hard to believe that Farage is worried about seeming extreme, after all he has a long history of controversy, and has often been accused of dog-whistle racist politics, but Farage knows being too extreme is a losing position. That's why he has repeatedly ejected members or candidates who say racist things, (and you can compare that with the Trump administration who ask them to stay), and kept [Tommy Robinson](#), an anti-Islam campaigner popular in MAGA circles, out of the party. In fact he's promoted a Muslim to be new chairman of the party. However, just as Farage is trying to do this... [Rupert Lowe](#) on TV:

"I want deportations. Not just for the rapists but also the family members who were aware of their heinous crimes. If that results in tens of thousands of deportations then that is what must happen."

Rupert Lowe who [said it](#), who was one of the few people to be elected as part of Farage's new party in 2024, talking about deporting family members of criminals, later adding on Twitter he supported deporting "entire communities".

Such language might not be fine for American right-wingers, but in the context of UK politics it's toxic - and one person who knows that is Nigel Farage.

"It's a political impossibility for us to deport hundreds of thousands of people. We simply can't do it."

Interviewer to Farage:

"But is it your ambition?"

Farage:

"No. I'm not going to get dragged down the route of mass deportations or anything like that."

And it was for this reason Farage asked his MP to remove talk of mass deportations from a speech - calling it "a very grave, dark and dangerous use of language". Now there's nothing that unusual about party members being more extreme or radical than the leadership, but Reform's supporters have become more troublesome for Farage because they have been encouraged by Trump's victory, and radicalized by Elon [Musk's Twitter; which is, incidentally, paying over £3000 a month to Rupert Lowe as revenue share for his punchy tweets](#). In fact Musk kind of started this whole thing, when, upset by Farage's rejection of Tommy Robinson, he called for Farage to be ousted as leader, and suggested as his replacement: Rupert Lowe. Now it's true the fight between Rupert Lowe and Nigel Farage isn't just about political positioning - it's also about a clash of egos, but the end result is that the party has lost an MP and Farage has a new enemy who will now be trying to undermine him. If you zoom out, It seems the international nature of the populist movement, and the outsized influence of Trump, is making it harder for populists in other countries to actually win power.

So there's the second reason - Trump's movement has made populist supporters more extreme in a way that is undermining their electoral chances.

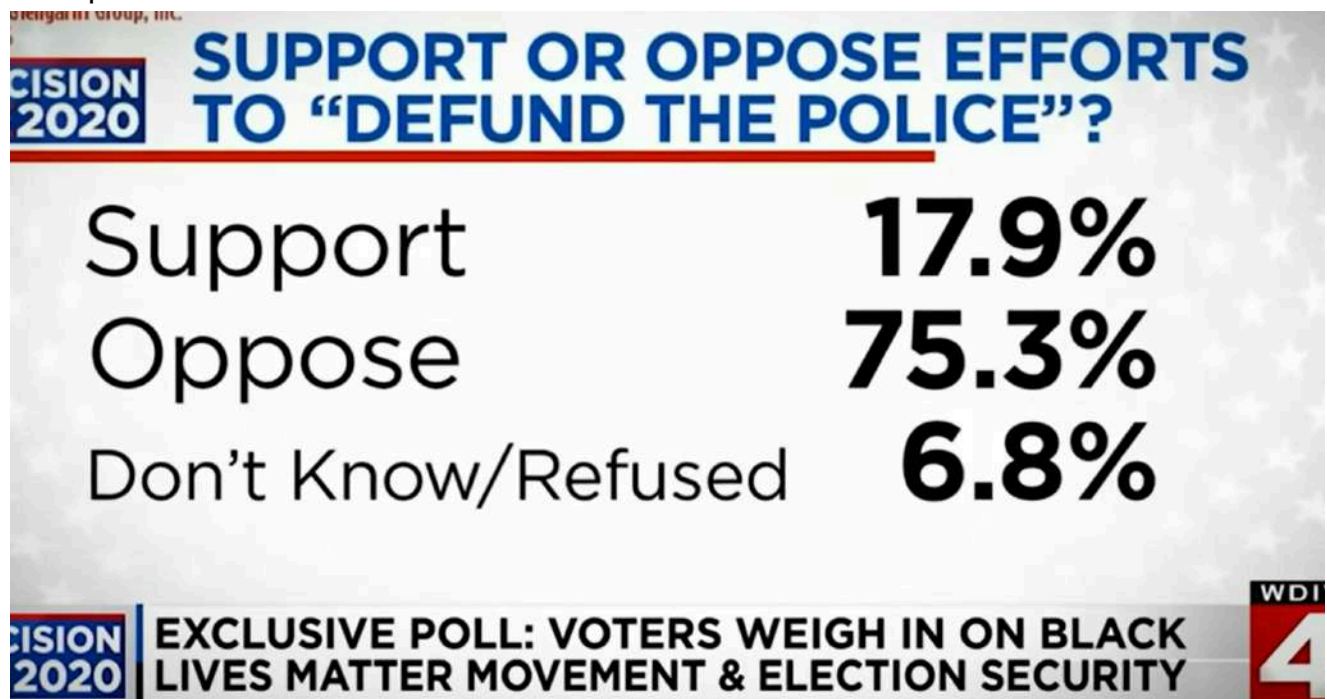
So much winning

To explain the final way in which Trump is ruining populism, we need to consider the different ways ideas can affect politics. You see, when we think about ideas we often think about their merits - whether they are convincing or not, But ideas can also have impact by just being popular or giving the sense that they are winning.

In other words, an idea's power can come not just from its merits, because it is convincing, but also because of its prestige, the sense that it is an influential winning idea. When Trump won, populism seemed to be what [Hegel](#) called the Geist der Zeiten, the "spirit of the times" or [Zeitgeist](#); And this had political consequences. For example, look at all the business leaders that switched to Trump and conservative positions when he won. Some of this may have been genuine but it was also driven by a sense that Trump's ideas were in the ascendancy and if they didn't get on board they'd lose out. But Trump's actions since winning power have started to undo this sense of dominance - by being well... incompetent and unrealistic.

To explain what I mean, let's compare Trump's Ukraine policy to some of his other actions.

Since taking power Trump has gradually withdrawn support for Ukraine and given ground to Putin and Russia. But while this is - in my opinion at least - this is not in the US' best interests; It has a kind of consistency and logic to it – It's wrong but it doesn't seem weak. But when Trump lets Musk blow up his own government's ability to do things; or goes back and forth on trade policies - at one point switching rates twice in a single day; or suggests nonsense ideas about America taking over Gaza without any soldiers; all while presiding over an economy starting to crash; The whole thing looks less like the winning thing, it looks like a movement that's going to blow up under its own contradictions, incompetence and unwillingness to understand reality. One parallel might be the Black Lives Matter movement of 2020, that went from being at the heart of the zeitgeist, an idea that everyone - from normies on social media to business interests - rushed to accommodate themselves to; and then developed into a set of ideas that were rejected even by many of the people they aimed to help.



Putting aside the rights and wrongs of ideas like this, you can see how ideas have a kind of prestige that rises or falls, and this has consequences for their impact. And that's what I think we will see increasingly with Trump: chaos and incompetence that will damage the prestige and impact of populism around the world. Now of course there's about a million things we

could say at this point. Trump is still in power, the Canadian conservatives might still win, and UK voters largely didn't notice the infighting within Reform; and of course the decline of populism has been predicted before. But while I don't expect populism and its ideas to disappear, I think we are seeing some of the shine come off them, as these ideas make contact – as all political ideas do – with the messiness of reality.

Part VI: Why the Tariff Chaos is so Fatal for Trump

"My fellow Americans, this is Liberation Day."

On April 2nd, Donald Trump announced widespread tariffs on imports to the USA. What followed was economic chaos. With Media reporting:

"U.S. markets plunge today in the wake of President Trump's announcement of new tariffs." and that: "Nasdaq is getting crushed. Small caps are getting crushed." "This is a shock to the system." Continuing with: "Even worse than it was during the 2008 financial crisis."

Despite the crashing markets, Trump's team promised to stay firm.

"I don't think there's any chance that President Trump is going to back off his tariffs." "The president made it clear yesterday this is not a negotiation." "Trump posted this morning: 'My policies will never change.'"

Then a week after the tariffs were announced:

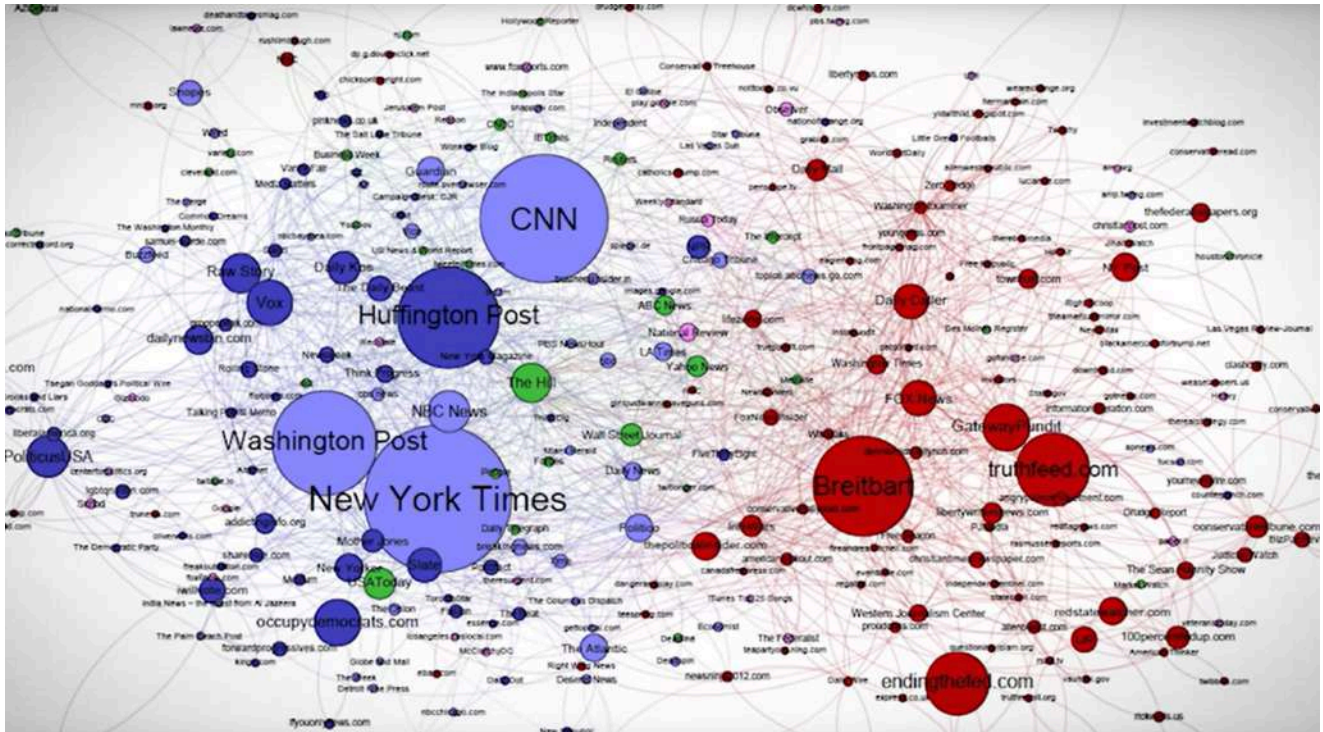
"This is a CBS news special report. President Trump making big news this afternoon. He's just announced a 90-day pause on tariffs."

On the day of the reversal, the stock market bounced back, but is still dramatically down from the time Trump came to power, as businesses are still hugely uncertain about what happens next. ["Yippy. People were getting a yippy. A bit afraid." Trump said](#), responding to the criticisms.

There are many ways Donald Trump's chaotic approach will be awful for America economically. But in this part I want to focus on how it will be a disaster for Donald Trump politically. Now this shouldn't be surprising - voters don't like politicians who do stupid things that hurt the country. And yet Trump has done and said many things that critics would call stupid, with no seeming impact on his support. Why would it be different this time?

Well in this part I want to answer that question, and share three reasons why Trump's chaotic tariffs policy will cause him big problems in a way his previous blunders haven't.

Doing so also gives us the chance to observe a new aspect of US politics



So join me for the story of Donald Trump's self-destructive tariff chaos.

Trump's tariffs are meant to stop America being "ripped off," make it independent and bring manufacturing back to the US, and there are many reasons to think they're stupid. Putting a tax on every import will mean higher prices; the tariffs are happening too quickly and with too much uncertainty for manufacturers to adjust; - after all, it takes years to build new factories and few want to make those investments if they're worried about a recession - as well as the fact that there are many things from coffee to bananas the US can never be "independent" in. Also, Trump seems to believe other countries are imposing tariffs on America when often it's just that the US has a trade deficit with that country. I mean, as many commentators have pointed out, I have a "trade deficit" with my local supermarket, but just because I buy things there and they don't buy things from me, doesn't mean I'm getting ripped off.

Anyway, unsurprisingly for everyone but Donald Trump, the economic results following his announcement were awful, and even after this pause things look difficult.

So the economics are not looking good, but how will this be a political disaster for Donald Trump?

Why the Chaos Matters Politically

"Next Tuesday is Election Day. Next Tuesday, all of you will go to the polls. You'll stand there in the polling place and make a decision. I think, when you make that decision, it might be well if you would ask yourself: Are you better off than you were four years ago?"

That was the Reagan speech before he was elected, before voting day. He went on to win the 1980 election against Jimmy Carter after this debate.

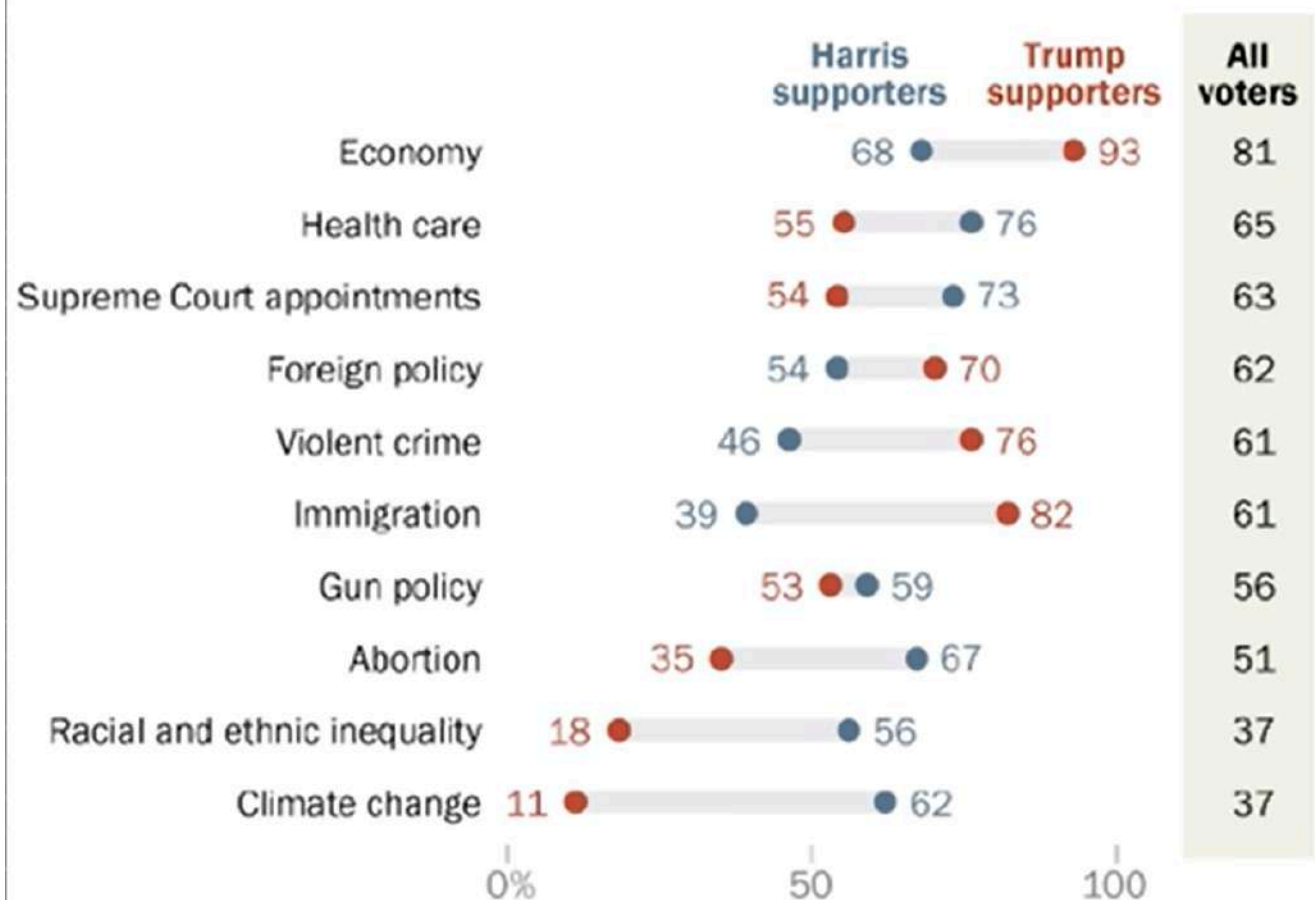
The first reason a sinking economy is bad for Trump is fairly obvious: voters care about the economy. This was what Ronald Reagan knew when he famously asked voters to consider if they were better off than they were four years ago. Later Bill Clinton strategist, [James Carville](#), would become famous for the phrase 'it's the economy stupid' that captured the same idea. In fact Donald Trump himself has acknowledged how important the economy was in his victory. Saying at the Press Release:

"And I won on groceries. It's very simple word: 'groceries'. Like almost... you know who uses the word? I started using the word. The 'groceries' - when you buy apples, when you buy bacon."

Yes, the price of 'groceries', a word Trump seems to believe he invented, was important for voters in 2024. And while this was true for all voters, it was especially true for Trump voters.

The economy is the top issue for voters in the 2024 election

*% of registered voters who say each is **very** important to their vote in the 2024 presidential election*



Note: Based on registered voters.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted Aug. 26-Sept. 2, 2024.

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Many voters supported Trump because they believed he was good with money, and would be good with the economy, but his reputation on that topic is now damaged. It all reminds me

of the situation in the UK [when Liz Truss' government announced £45bn of unfunded tax cuts in a mini-budget](#). The result was economic disaster - borrowing rates went up, the value of the pound dropped, and after insisting for weeks there would be no reversal, Truss fired her Chancellor and reversed all the tax cuts. Despite this, confidence in her was shattered and she soon resigned, the shortest serving prime minister in UK history, with the [Conservative party, its reputation for economic competence destroyed, later having its worst defeat since its formation in the 1830s](#). So that's the first reason: the economy is voters' number one issue and so losing your reputation for economic competence is fatal.

The second reason all this is especially bad for Trump is that the Democrats have been out of the picture. In March, the Democratic leadership were widely criticized by others on the left for their decision to help pass a Republican spending bill that prevented a government shutdown. But while I could see the arguments on either side of that debate, it does happen to have worked out well for the Democrats. If the Democrats had shut down the government in March, they would have inserted themselves into the story, which is usually what you want an opposition to do. But the way things have turned out, their absence means it's hard for Trump to blame them and a government shutdown for the economic chaos. And if you want evidence of this just look at the way Donald Trump is talking about the economic problems. One morning after the announcement of Liberation Day and its tariffs, the president doubled down, posting, quote, "Don't be weak. Don't be stupid. Don't be a Panican." A term the president said represented a, quote, new party based on weak and stupid people.

Instead of blaming others - the Democrats or whoever — which is something Trump is very talented at — he has had to resort to telling people off for being 'weak' and panicky. What's more, after Trump had done his thing, the Democrats became more visible with nation-wide protests.

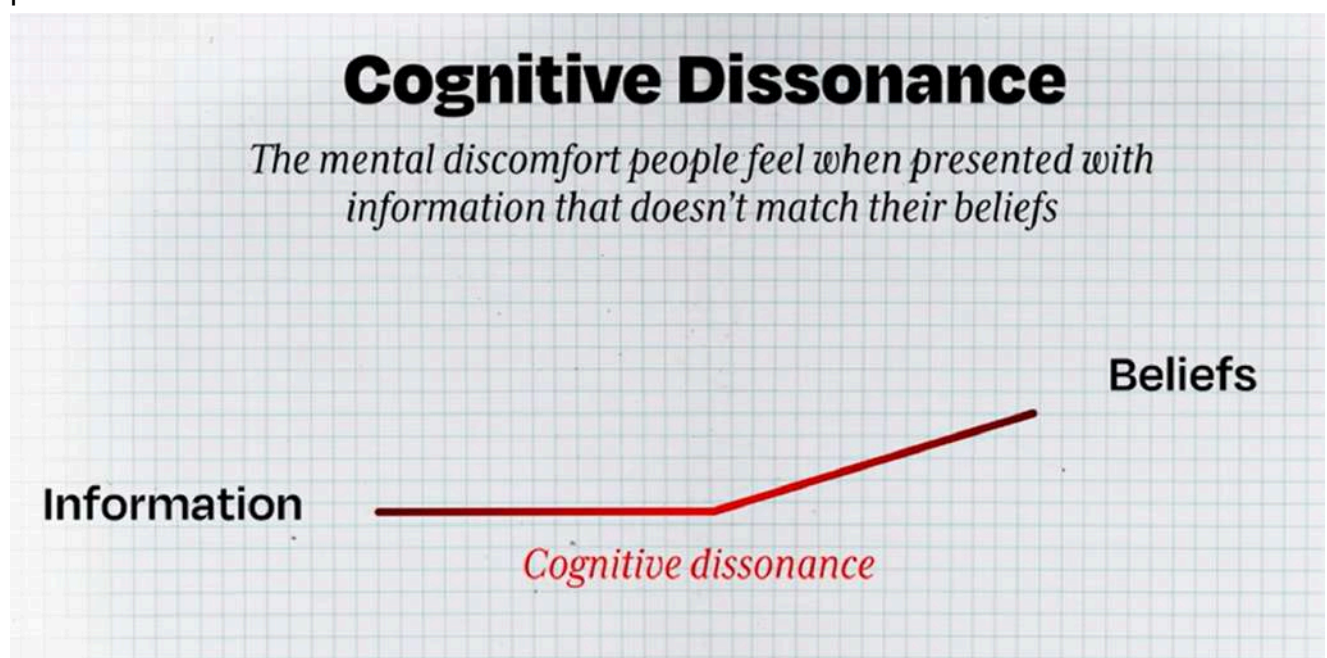
Just 5 months ago, as Biden left office, the US economy was taking off - the "envy of the world," and now it's in chaotic decline; and Trump, because the Democrats have not been part of the story, will find it hard to blame anyone but himself.

The final reason this is bad for Trump is to do with the information environment US politics operates in. You know - [echo chambers, filter bubbles, the "fragmentation of the public sphere,"](#) whatever you call it - the United States has two partisan media ecosystems. And

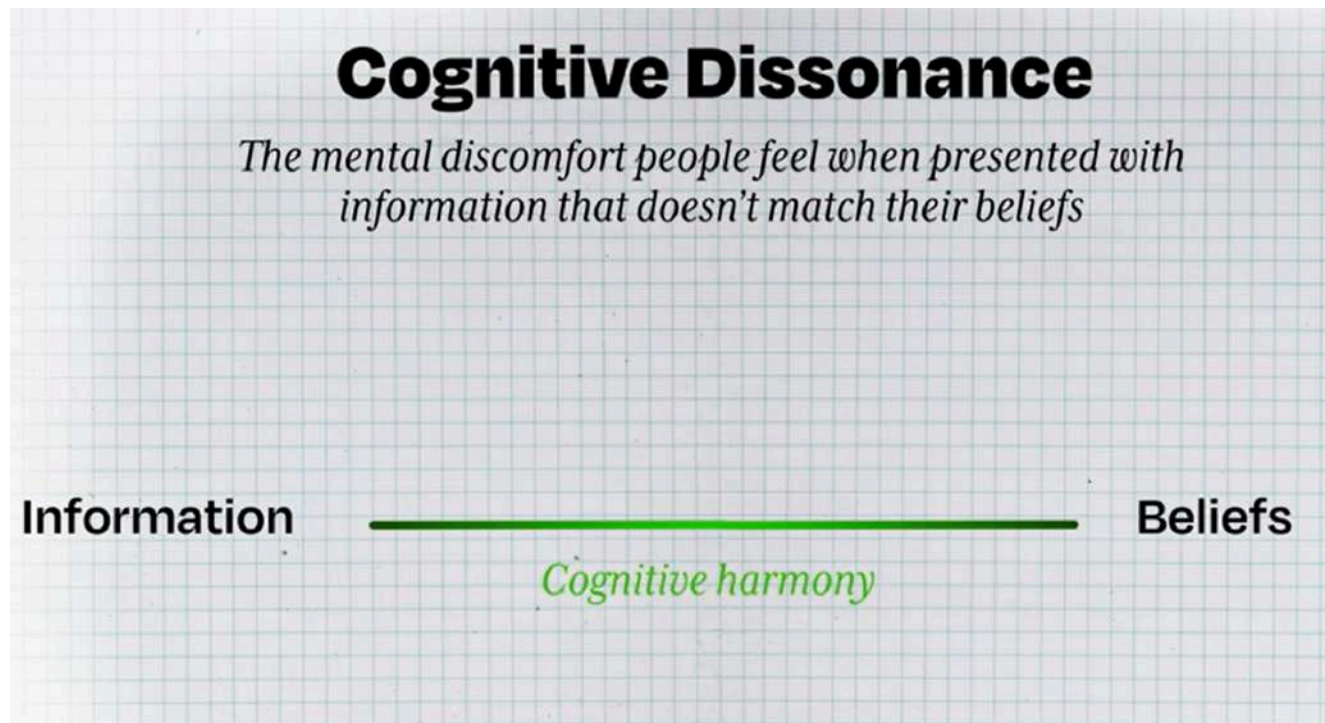
The visualization is a network graph where nodes represent media entities and edges represent relationships or interactions between them. The nodes are colored in shades of blue, red, and green. The size of each node is proportional to its influence or reach. The graph is highly interconnected, with a dense central core and many smaller clusters branching out. Key nodes include CNN, Huffington Post, Washington Post, New York Times, Breitbart, Fox News, and many others. The edges are thin lines connecting the nodes, forming a complex web of relationships.

Cognitive Dissonance & Monetary Disillusionment

The most famous explanation for why this happens is from Leon Festinger's theory of cognitive dissonance. This theory argues that people experience mental discomfort when presented with information that doesn't match their beliefs.

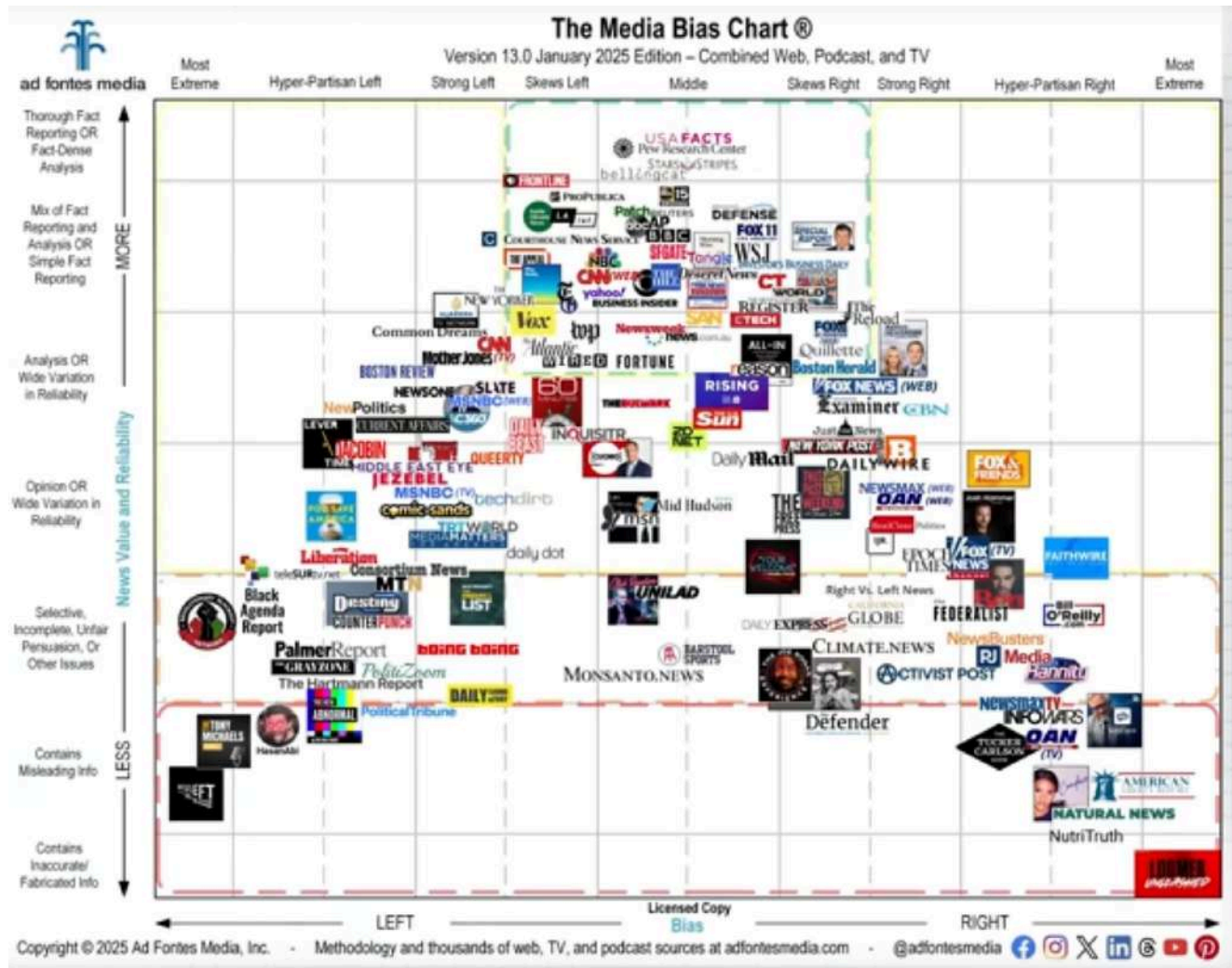


In order to create what we might call "cognitive harmony," people can change their beliefs, and if the evidence is overwhelming, then this is sometimes the response. But this tends to be rare.



What happens more normally is people eliminate the discomfort, not by changing their beliefs, but through selective exposure - changing the information they're looking at. Whatever the exact psychological cause, it's been clear for a long time that people prefer media that matches their own beliefs, and with the choice voters now have when it comes to media, as well as social media algorithms that learn what you want to see, [voters have](#)

increasingly split into two separate media eco-systems.



Okay so the information environment has changed. But what has this got to do with tariffs? Well since Trump came to power, we've seen how many of Trump's actions have been reframed or explained away by the right-wing media eco-system. The cuts at DOGE are genuinely just about cutting fraud and waste; threatening to take over Greenland is really about "world peace," and the Signal messaging scandal was actually deliberate "media strategy."

Okay, so Trump announces the tariffs, the market crashes, and then unsurprisingly the right-wing media eco-system does its thing. And the denials of reality in right-wing media started:

"Don't panic. Calm down. Everything's going to be okay." "You know, the uncertainty in the stock market isn't necessarily a negative." "Trump's trade war is high risk, high reward. But he's not biting his fingernails staring at the Dow. Today he actually played golf."

Others were arguing we don't need new iPads or video game consoles, and really, money is just like [Benny Johnson](#) claiming: "digital ones and zeroes."



Benny Johnson  
@bennyjohnson

Subscribe



Losing money means nothing. Digital ones and zeroes. In the end, you won't miss any of it.

Losing your country costs you everything. You will never get that back. Your kids will be slaves to foreign powers who hate us.

Without America First policies, we become slaves. Fight...



Thus by his logic: ["Losing money costs you nothing. Nothing. In fact, it builds quite a lot of character."](#)

[Some supporters even started to attack Wall Street traders](#) - not normally seen as a bastion of anti-Trump resistance.

There's also lots of efforts to argue it was all part of a master plan. Trump himself reposted this TikTok on his Truth Social account, that states:

"Trump is crushing the stock market by 20% this month, but he's doing it on purpose. So why is he doing this? To push cash into treasuries. Which forces the fed to slash interest rates in May. And those lower rates give the fed the ability to refinance trillions of debt very inexpensively.... Now it's a wild chess move, but it's working."

But despite those efforts of the media eco-system, the brutal reality of Trump's tariff madness was able to cut through to ordinary voters. [After all, more than 60% of Americans own stocks](#), with any who had retirement plans able to see the damage to their portfolios, and millions of small businesses were seeing first hand price increases and problems sourcing imports. Even on YouTube you could see people (like [Patrick Hall](#) from [Fstoppers](#) or [Lee Morris](#)), not normally political, speaking up about this.

And even many of the streamers and podcasters who've supported Trump in the past started expressing doubts, like [Dave Portnoy](#), known as "[Davey Day Trader](#)," a well-known figure in the world of day trading, who states:

"Trump has put his tariffs all over the place. I've been trying to understand them. I don't. And everything's in the shitter because of it."

As a result of all this, Republicans came under pressure. [Senator Ron Johnson](#) said:

"What's also indisputable is the markets are down about 8% in just two days and I'm getting all kinds of reaction from businesses, farmers in Wisconsin that are highly concerned about what's happening."

A situation made worse by the fact that most Republicans, whatever they might say now, don't really support tariffs. Like even [Marco Rubio](#), the Secretary of State:

"The tariff is a tax on Americans. A tariff is not paid by the exporter. China is not going to pay the tariff. The buyer is going to pay the tariff."

Even in Trump's administration we have been seeing splits on the issue.

All this contributed to Trump's decision a week after "liberation day" to reverse some of the tariffs. But I don't think that means Trump and the Republicans won't pay a cost for this. First, as mentioned earlier, the US economy is still in trouble and people are noticing. [Just look at this graph](#)



it shows how 50% of people have heard unfavorable business news coverage of the government. It's way higher than at any point in the last 40 years. And while Trump's more hardline supporters have stayed positive, support amongst others who voted for him [in 2024 has plummeted, especially on jobs, the economy and inflation](#).

In leaning into **Maga**, Trump is losing **the rest of his 2024 coalition**

Net approval ratings for Trump among different groups of voters, overall and on specific issues



Source: [Economist/YouGov](#)

FT graphic: John Burn-Murdoch / @jburnmurdoch

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And these surveys were taken before the most recent chaos. Remember while it's normal to select information that suits your beliefs, when reality is overwhelming, the other way to remove cognitive dissonance is to change your beliefs. One thing that is compounding this damage is that, while for years Trump has criticized government institutions, scientific reports, and the "mainstream media," he hasn't done the same thing with the stock market.

This meant that when the graphs and numbers were all pointed downward so dramatically, they retained a credibility that made them extra powerful. Another damaging aspect of this are all the small ridiculous details in the story. The [TDS](#) news reported on their comedy show:

"... Remote places like the Heard and McDonald Islands. They are near Antarctica and covered in glaciers, home to many penguins, but no people."

"—Yeah, yeah, we put a 10% tariff... We put a 10% tariff on an island that only has penguins?"

Details like this make the stupidity of the policy easier to grasp, and the humor of it makes it fun to talk about.

"We buy all their skins to make tuxedos, but have they ever. But have they ever bought any fish from us?"

Now I should say, despite all this, the media ecosystem on the right is resilient. And the fever dream continues:

"This is an absolutely brilliant move." "Brilliant, not only economically, but politically. And it was good for the American worker." "A huge win for the president. A huge win for the country."

The blind followers of Trump claim.

In fact, while in the spirit of balance, it would be nice to say left and right are equally bad, research on this area argues the right-wing media ecosystem does in fact show greater insularity than that on the left. But with a story this big it's hard for those outlets to do business as usual.

With a story this big, it's harder for right-wing media to rationalize and deflect. For while the desire to avoid information that clashes with your beliefs is powerful, when the economic disruption is this strong, the usual defenses start to falter.

Part VII: Why JD Vance Will Lose His Culture War

We need to talk about JD Vance. Because everybody is talkin about him:

"Republican veep candidate JD Vance is igniting a firestorm for once calling citizens without children 'childless cat ladies.'" "... accused Europe of restricting free speech and endangering democracy." "... Calling the Chinese peasants, and many of them are not pleased." "Who is Vice President JD Vance?" "He's a marine. He's a dad. He's incredibly smart." "JD Vance is the future. Period." "He comes wholly from this very, very obscure eccentric right-wing subculture of tech billionaires." "He's a very dangerous fake."

JD Vance is one of the most high-profile and controversial vice presidents in American history. He's become known for his dislike of Ukraine; for being the target of online memes and accusations about eyeliner, and for having a slightly odd vibe.

Vance is also known for being a person who went from being anti-Trump, as he himself [said 10 years ago: "I'm a 'Never Trump' guy... I never liked him."](#) ... to being a big supporter. ["He's the best president of my lifetime and he revealed the corruption in this country."](#)

One result of this is that many have argued Vance is just a grifter without any real ideas, but I think this is a mistake. Certainly Vance is opportunistic and is hungry for power -- he is a politician after all -- but I think seeing Vance as merely a grifter underestimates how ideological he is. He claims:

"We have to honestly and aggressively attack the universities in this country."

and that:

"Fire every single mid-level bureaucrat, every civil servant in the administrative state. Replace them with our people."

Vance has ideas — an ideology; it's why calling him "weird" struck a chord. These ideas have grown out of a type of conservatism, often called the New Right; one that will, with Vance the frontrunner to succeed Trump, only become more important. But these ideas are also built on several contradictions, and so in this part I don't just want to explain JD Vance's ideology but also identify three problems that will lead these ideas, and the man himself, straight into a disaster.

JD Vance first appeared on the scene in 2016 with the publication of [Hillbilly Elegy](#). But Vance also attracted attention because he seemed to be able to help explain the white working class voters that had been attracted to Donald Trump.

As Trump's presidency progressed Vance continued to appear a bit on TV but kind of faded from the scene. Asking question: "Are you a racist?" to the viewer.

Then in 2021 he was back, running for a senate seat in Ohio. And stated: "You have elites in the ruling class that have plundered this country, that have made it harder for middle-class Americans to live a normal life." It was quite the change. Vance had gone from being this polite, softly-spoken literary writer, to being a Trump-supporting populist. Now with a beard. [New Vance won his Senate race, and in July 2024](#) he was picked as Trump's VP.

By now he had a wide agenda: an economic policy based on tariffs and an isolationist foreign policy. But here I want to focus on a different aspect of his thinking, something that connects Old Vance and New Vance, and that explains a lot about his beliefs and actions. I'm talking about culture. As he himself thinks:

"We've lost big business. We've lost finance. We've lost the culture. We've lost the Academy. But to be honest with you, the culture war that we fight in this country, I worry that many conservatives... under-appreciate the challenge that we face. The American political culture was like, deeply diseased."

You can actually trace Vance's interest in culture back to his book, the full title of which is: [A Memoir of a Family and Culture in Crisis](#).

It was culture that was also key to Vance's explanation of Trump's victory in 2016. He stated on Fresh Air podcast on NPR in 2016:

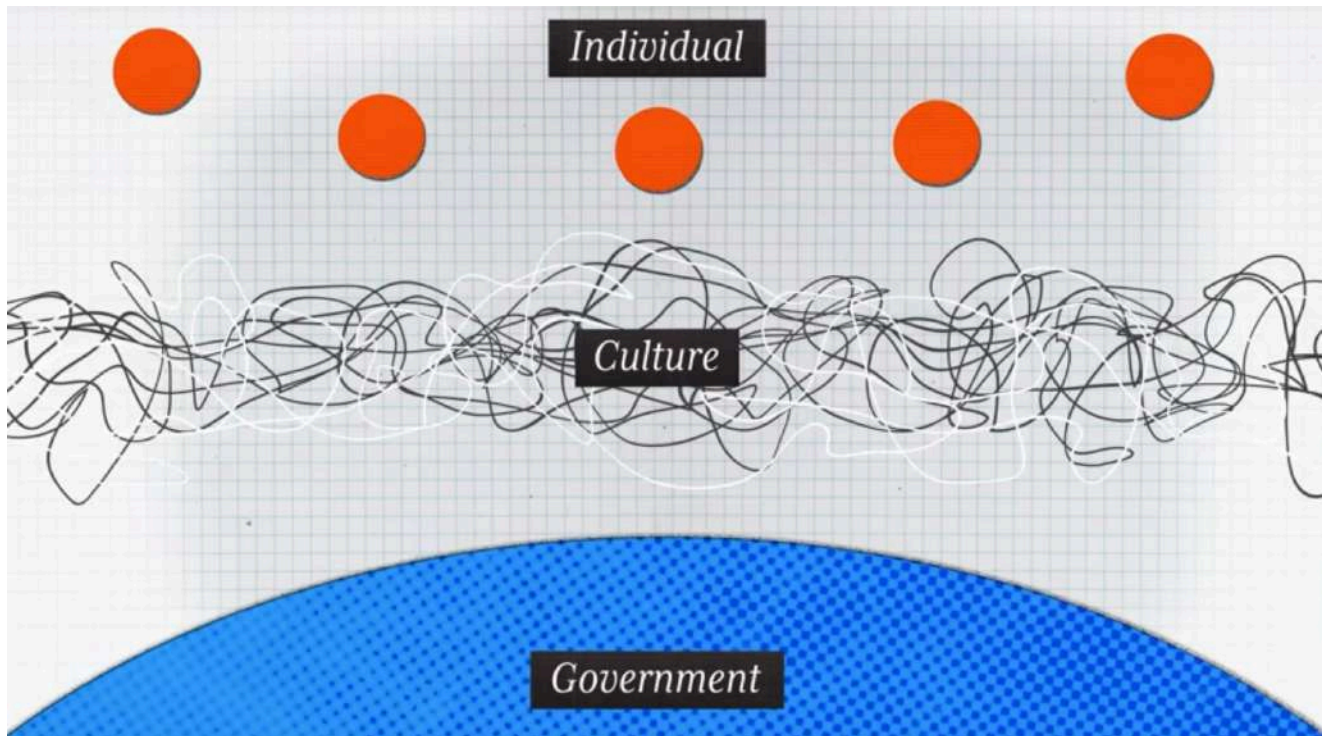
"folks that aren't necessarily economically destitute but in some ways feel very culturally isolated and very pessimistic about the future."

Many heard Vance's focus on culture as just another conservative, unsympathetic appeal to 'individual responsibility'. But in fact Vance came to argue against this idea. At Brookings Conference he said 6 years ago:

"The way that conservatives — and I'm a conservative — talk about culture is in some ways an excuse to end a conversation instead of starting a much more important conversation. It's: 'Look at their bad culture, look at their deficient culture — we can't do anything to help them.'"

While the right just focused on individuals, the left also had a limited view — focusing just on government and structural solutions like economic opportunity; with culture — the norms,

ideas and values that permeate everything — getting missed by both sides.



He states on 2020 at his YouTube channel The Road Home Podcast:

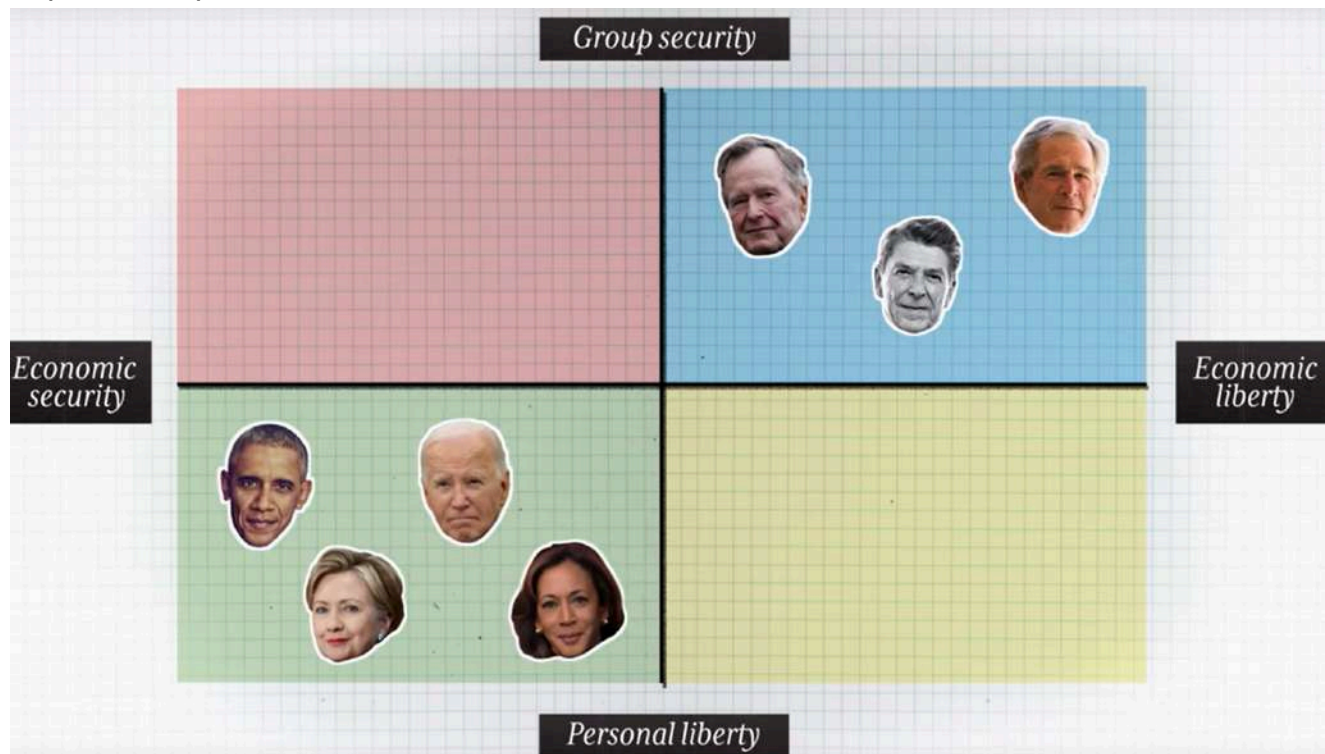
"The lefties think that the structure matters, and consequently you've got to focus on public policy. The righties think that personal agency matters, and you've got to focus only on the individual choices that people make... I just think that most normal people recognize that the environment, the culture that you grow up in, the things that you see, the examples that you're exposed to, the sense of possibility that you acquire from observing the world around you — that's very important."

Now all this isn't that unusual. There is a long history in American conservatism of worrying about culture as per books like: [The Quest for Community](#) by [Robert A. Nisbet](#), [The Conservative Mind: from Burke to Santayana](#) by [Russell Kirk](#), and [The Culture of Narcissism: American Life in an Age of Diminishing Expectations](#) by [Christopher Lasch](#).

But as we'll see, it's where Vance goes with these worries that is such a radical and dangerous break with past conservative positions. To explain, we need to start with liberalism, the political ideology that centers around ideas of liberty and freedom. I'm not talking about liberals, as in the Democrats, left-wingers... I'm talking about philosophical liberalism that you can find supporters of on both the left and right. (Which is why, by the way, you can find "liberals" used as a name for both conservative and left-wing parties like [Liberal Party \(Canadian left-wing party\)](#) and [Liberal Party \(Australian right-wing party\)](#))

One way to think about liberalism is to think of two types of "liberty": economic liberty and personal liberty. First there's those who want what they call economic liberty - lower taxes, less regulation and so on. Voters those who want a bigger role for the state in the economy, taxing, and maybe even owning businesses. This is the traditional left-right divide. Then there's those who support personal liberty — whether that's religion, drugs, gender whatever — against social conservatives who are more opposed. Here is where you'll find most

Democrats - supporting personal liberty but wanting the state intervening in the economy. Up here would be people who are also left on economic policy but more socially conservative. Historically this is quite a rare type of politics — but we'll come back to that. Here is where you traditionally found Republicans and conservatives and here, also on the right, you have libertarians or 'classical liberals', who are against the state intervening in either the economic or personal sphere.



An example of a libertarian would be [Peter Thiel](#) (about who I'll do an article soon), a tech entrepreneur and investor who has been a key figure in JD Vance's life, with Vance working for him after law school and Thiel donating huge amounts to his campaign for Senate. Tech-libertarians like Thiel make up one of the intellectual influences on the New Right, and people like Elon Musk have been influential in Trump's administration; but what's interesting about Vance is that, despite his past links, his rise to power involved separating himself from libertarians — in fact giving a speech in 2019 titled "[Beyond libertarianism](#)", in which he states:

"Libertarians are not heartless, and I don't mean to suggest that they are. But they are so uncomfortable with political power, or so skeptical of whether political power can accomplish anything, that they don't want to actually use it to solve, or even to try to help address, some of these problems."

His argument is that conservatives have been too influenced by economic liberalism which has stopped them taking action on cultural problems. Stating:

"...if people are spending too much time addicted to devices that are designed to addict them, we can't just blame consumer choice. We live in an environment, and in a culture, that's shaped by our laws and public policy—and we can't hide from that fact anymore."

So Vance's worries about culture mean he has moved away from economic liberalism. But there's another way Vance has argued liberalism is damaging to culture. On his The Road Home Podcast he states:

"I think one of the things that the hyper-liberal, hyper-atomized, hyper-libertarian approach has done is that it's led people to think of themselves as buyers and sellers, as economic agents, as purely individuals."

Vance argues that people need connection and solidarity, but that liberalism doesn't give people this. He continues:

"People need to feel they're members of families, they need to feel that they're members of communities, they need to feel they're members of nation-states... And what this hyper-atomized approach to living has done is, I think it's denied people a sense of solidarity."

This skepticism of liberalism has become a key part of New Right thinking, with thinkers known as the '[Post Liberals](#)' leading the way. The "Post-liberal" thinker [Patrick Deneen](#), says:

"There are many people who are anticipating my book as a call to have a constant and unceasing January 6th"

Deneen favors regime change, as he said:

"I don't want to violently overthrow the government. I want something far more revolutionary than that: I want to overthrow the party of progress."

Patrick Deneen who came to prominence in 2018 with a book attacking liberalism (in his book "[Why Liberalism Failed](#)") that he followed up with the provocatively named, "[Regime Change: Towards a Postliberal Future](#)" in 2024, with JD Vance attending the book launch.

Part of Deneen's argument is that what liberals on the left call "progress", many ordinary people see as disorder, a never-ending attack on the traditional ideas like family and marriage, that give people their sense of meaning and security, and now finally those people are saying 'enough'.

Patrick says:

"What seems to be a sudden outburst of inexplicable populism, now we understand is, in fact, an inchoate and somewhat inarticulate demand by those who are, at least residually, of the party of order — saying, 'We need order in our lives. We need stability. We need balance.'"

In other words, people need connection and purpose, but liberalism is just everyone just doing their own thing. This is bad in itself but also — and here's the next step — it leaves a vacuum into which enters a new harmful ideology. JD Vance considered it rather unambiguously with words:

"Call it critical race theory, critical theory, call it wokeism or social progressivism — I don't care what word you put on it — but at the end of the day, the most powerful ideology among the leadership of this country is not Christianity or American political theology or Abraham Lincoln's political religion. It is wokeism, it is social progressivism, it's globalism."

Vance's dislike of wokeism isn't that surprising — he's a conservative after all — but what's interesting is that again and again his criticisms come back to culture, and the desire for meaning and unity.

He continues:

"If you don't have some shared historical symbol, some sense of a shared past, I think it's very impossible to have any shared future. And so I really do think that we have to stop this non-stop assault on American history: you know, tearing down statues of people from the past."

In fact it's the lack of real meaning that leads progressives to focus on race and gender.

He furthermore adds:

"What it is, is sort of a value system to replace the fact that they're all fundamentally atheist or agnostic. They have no real value system. Their only value system is: achieve in a very conventional way. And so the idea that somehow they're pursuing racial or gender equity is like the value system that gives their life meaning."

For Vance, this new value system is all-pervasive, and in that way it reflects another idea on the [New Right: the idea of the "Cathedral"](#). And to quote the proponent of this view:

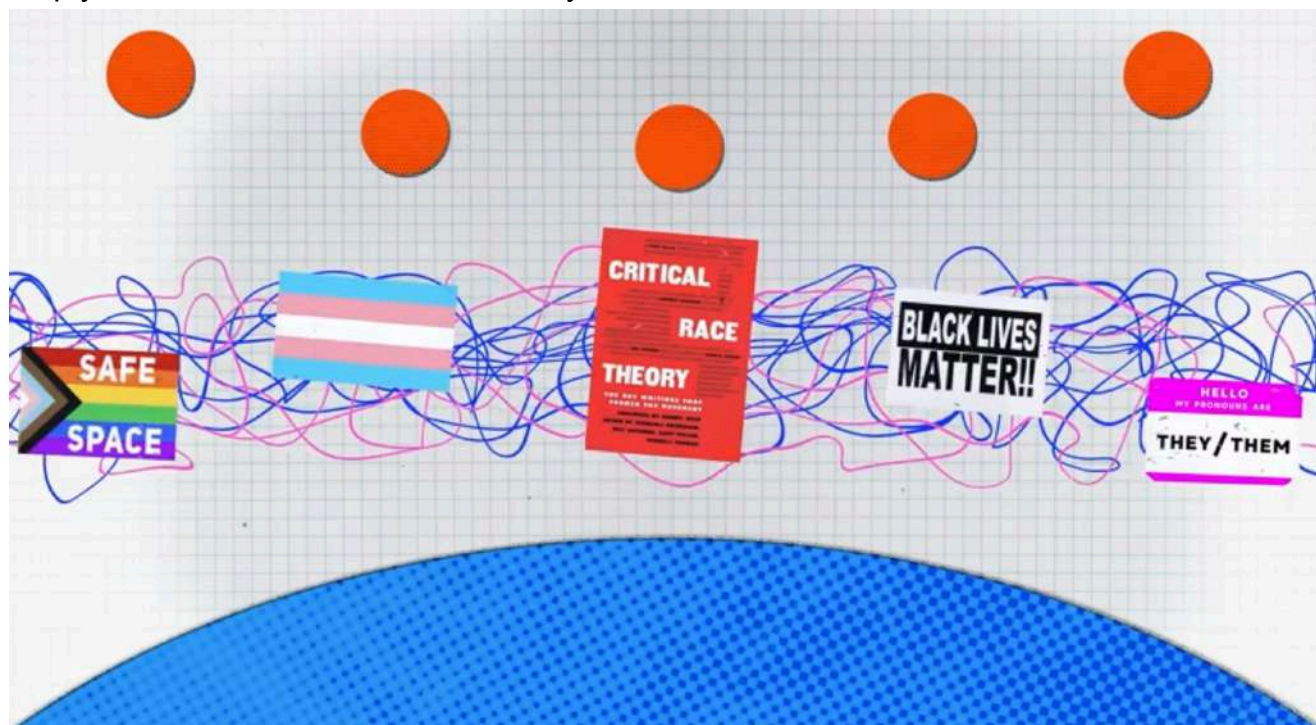
"The Cathedral is just a short way to say journalism plus academia --- the intellectual institutions at the center of modern society, just as the Church was the intellectual institution at the center of medieval society. The mystery of the Cathedral is that all the modern world's legitimate and prestigious intellectual institutions — even though they have no central organizational connection — behave in many ways as if they were a single organizational structure.... It always agrees with itself."

This idea comes from thinker, [Curtis Yarvin](#), someone often identified as part of the very online "neo-reactionary movement", and who are another element of the New Right. Because this "Cathedral" with its woke ideology, has such a grip on culture, Vance believes radical action is needed.

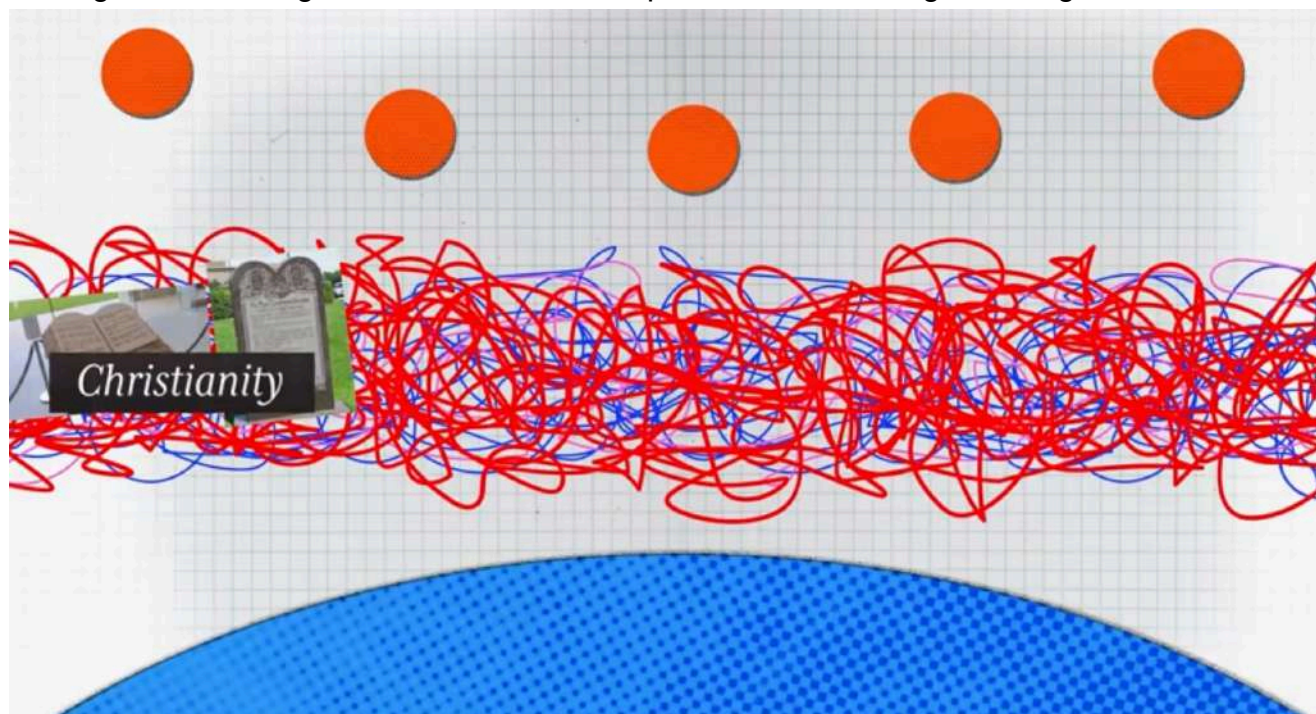
Thus he adds:

"So almost the thing that you need to do, step one in the process, is to totally replace — like, rip out, like a tumor — the current American leadership class, and then reinstall some sense of American, you know, political religion, some sense of shared values ... replacing garbage elite culture with traditional American culture."

So here's where we've got to: Vance believes America has a "garbage elite culture", in which empty liberalism has been taken over by wokeness.



And this means conservatives have to step up and replace it with something of substance. As we've seen, Vance's interest in culture came from his own personal experiences, and when it comes to questions of what elements should be part of this new healthier culture, it's striking that Vance again leans on his own experiences — starting with religion.



On another podcast he claims:

"I was thinking about the big questions... 2017 to 2019, when I was thinking about re-engaging with my faith.... I had a lot more money than I ever thought I would have. I had my own venture-capital firm, and there was this weird way where I felt like I had succeeded at climbing the ladder of meritocracy, but I had also found the values of the meritocracy, frankly, deeply wanting."

Vance is describing the time after he'd had success with his book but before he turned full populist Trump supporter. In the middle of this period he converts to Catholicism.

In the podcast he continues:

"I wanted to be a virtuous human being, in other words. That was sort of the thing that I kept on coming back to was how to be virtuous. And I thought the Christianity that I had discarded as a young man answered the questions about being a virtuous person better than the logic of the American meritocracy."

Interestingly, many of those influential in the New Right are Catholic, including Patrick Deneen we met earlier. In fact part of Deneen's "post liberalism" is a desire for Christianity to have a more muscular role in American life. As Deneen states:

"Things like Sabbath laws, um, and the reintroduction of Scripture in public schools --- these are ideals that we should not be politically indifferent to."

Vance is sympathetic to these ideas because he believes Christianity or some public religion will help bring a sense of solidarity and connection to the culture.

Quoting JD Vance:

"What is that creed in America today? You know, it used to be, certainly in the 18th and 19th centuries, it was a very robust Christian tradition in this country. ... It's hard to have a country when people don't believe some common set of values."

To explain what's radical about the idea of scripture in schools or sabbath laws, we need to go back to liberalism, which along with economic and personal liberty argues for making the basic institutions of the system — the law, schools, bureaucracy — neutral. Just as a referee in a football match doesn't pick sides but just looks after the rules of the game, these systems are not meant to take sides when it comes to political beliefs, religion and so on. For example, Vance talks a lot about free speech which is meant to be protected regardless of the political content of the speech. America also has the idea of separation between church and state. Based on this principle, the courts have, for example, ruled against displaying the ten commandments in public buildings like courts or schools, because such public buildings should be neutral and not endorsing particular religions.

However one of the strands of New Right thinking is to reject this with groups such as [Catholic Integralists](#) arguing the state should follow the church's moral teaching, and Christian nationalists arguing the state should be explicitly Christian in nature.

PBS News Hour reports:

"Louisiana will now require the 10 commandments to be displayed in every public school classroom."

At the law's introduction the Mayor of Louisiana said:

"If you want to respect the rule of law, you got to start from the original law giver, which was Moses."

This effort from Republicans in Louisiana was later struck down by the courts, but moves like this are part of a wider effort to make public spaces less neutral and more explicitly Christian. One of the arguments these groups make is that this is just a fiction, and is just another way in which liberalism leaves a vacuum into which comes wokeness, neo-Marxism and everything else.

[Yoram Hazony](#), the National Conservatism philosopher says:

"The liberal democracy that America was is what gave birth to woke neo-Marxism. You can't say that's going to solve the problem. What we need to look for —and what I'm proposing — is a countervailing force that can be strong enough to stand up to that. And that means defeating one proposed public philosophy, or public religion, with another."

Yoram Hazony who is also a key figure in the national conservatives or "nat-cons", another intellectual element of the New Right. As well as believing in a more prominent role for Christianity this group argues the positive (as per his book [The Virtue of Nationalism](#)), even virtuous case for nationalism. Vance has often spoken at the national conservatism conferences run by Hazony but he has his own long-standing interest in nationalism, based by his desire for a culture that brings connection and solidarity.

Going back to the 2020's The Road Home Podcast of JD Vance, he states:

"The nation-state is a way to create some sense of identity across people who come from different backgrounds and different ethnicities.... For all of its faults, one of the great geniuses of the United States of America: it has cultivated this sense of shared national identity across many different groups of people."

America is particularly good at bringing together different people because its national identity is based not on one particular ethnicity but a set of ideas.

¶¶ We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness."

- as per Lincoln's Speech.

This is what is often described as civic nationalism — an open, more inclusive form of national identity. But by 2024, JD Vance, apparently influenced by the national conservatives has come to think that American culture needs something stronger, thicker, more powerful than this.

He argues:

"You know, one of the things that you hear people say sometimes is that America is an idea. ... But America is not just an idea. It is a group of people with a shared history and a common future. It is, in short, a nation."

Vance goes on to talk about a cemetery plot owned by his family.

He continues:

"there will be seven generations just in that small mountain cemetery plot in eastern Kentucky. Seven generations of people who have fought for this country. ... Now that's not just an idea, my friends. That's not just a set of principles. Even though the ideas and the principles are great, that is a homeland. That is our homeland. People will not fight for abstractions, but they will fight for their home."

Vance does say in this speech that newcomers are welcome, as long as they assimilate to American culture and values, but it's clear he's moved to a more ethno-cultural form of nationalism, that centers those whose heritage in the country goes back longest — "legacy Americans," to use the phrase MAGA types sometimes favor.

So Vance wants a culture with Christianity and nationalism, but probably the thing Vance talks about most in this area is family.

On [Intercollegiate Studies Institute](#) he claims in his Speech to Intercollegiate Studies Institute:

"Kids are the ultimate way that we find healthy people — at least, I think — self-meaning in life. Whether you're in children, your grandchildren, your nieces and nephews... I'm going to go back to my two beautiful boys, my wife who loves me, and recognize that the most important thing in my life is going to be them. It will always be them."

If family is a source of meaning in Vance's life now, the lack of family stability was a source of pain growing up, and family was also part of his wider analysis of the white working class. [During the interview Face the Nation in 2017 he says:](#)

"That migration took them away from the families that had made them who they were. So, yeah, they improved a bit economically -- they were able to get better jobs -- but they were also really disconnected from the communities that gave them social support and a sense of belonging in the world."

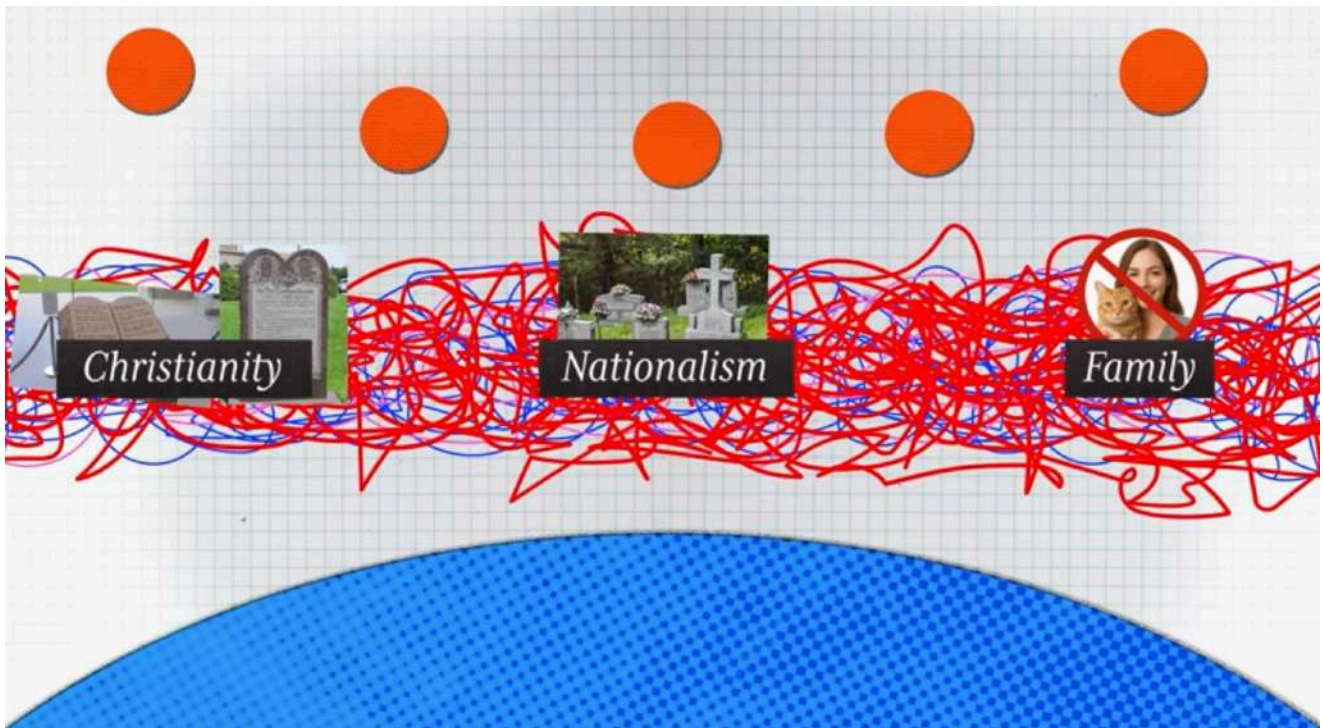
But since then as with all his beliefs, Vance has become more extreme, questioning the commitment... almost the moral worth of people who don't have children. This is apparent if we again examine the Intercollegiate Studies Institute speech, in which he later says:

"Kamala Harris; [Mayor Pete Buttigieg](#), who's now the Secretary of Transportation; [Cory Booker](#); [Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez](#). I think all these people, they're different---they come from different walks of life, different parts of the country. What is the one thing that unites every single one of them? Not a single one of them has any children.... But it's something

else to build a political movement invested theoretically in the future of this country when not a single one of them actually has any physical commitment to the future of this country."

This was the idea that became his line about "childless cat ladies" - and that attracted such backlash in the election campaign.

So Vance wants a culture of Christianity, nationalism and family to replace what he sees as America's existing liberal woke garbage culture.



But here is what is dangerously different about Vance and the New Right from previous conservatives: it is their desire to use government power to effect that cultural change. If a private foundation spreads ideas that are harmful, use government power.

When being interviewed by [Tucker Carlson](#) on Fox News Vance says:

"Why don't we seize the assets of the Ford Foundation, tax their assets, and give it to the people who've had their lives destroyed by their radical open borders agenda?"

If universities teach woke ideas, use government power. Thus he continues:

"They are taught -- the children who go through this university system -- that this country built by our fathers and grandfathers is an evil and terrible place. Ladies and gentlemen we are giving our children over to our enemies and it's time we stop doing it."

And when in control of the woke-infested bureaucracy, use government power — even if it violates the law.

Vance on other podcast:

"Fire every single mid-level bureaucrat, every civil servant in the administrative state, replace them with our people. And when the courts -- because you will get taken to court

— and when the courts stop you, stand before the country like [Andrew Jackson](#) did, and say, 'The Chief Justice has made his ruling; now let him enforce it,'"

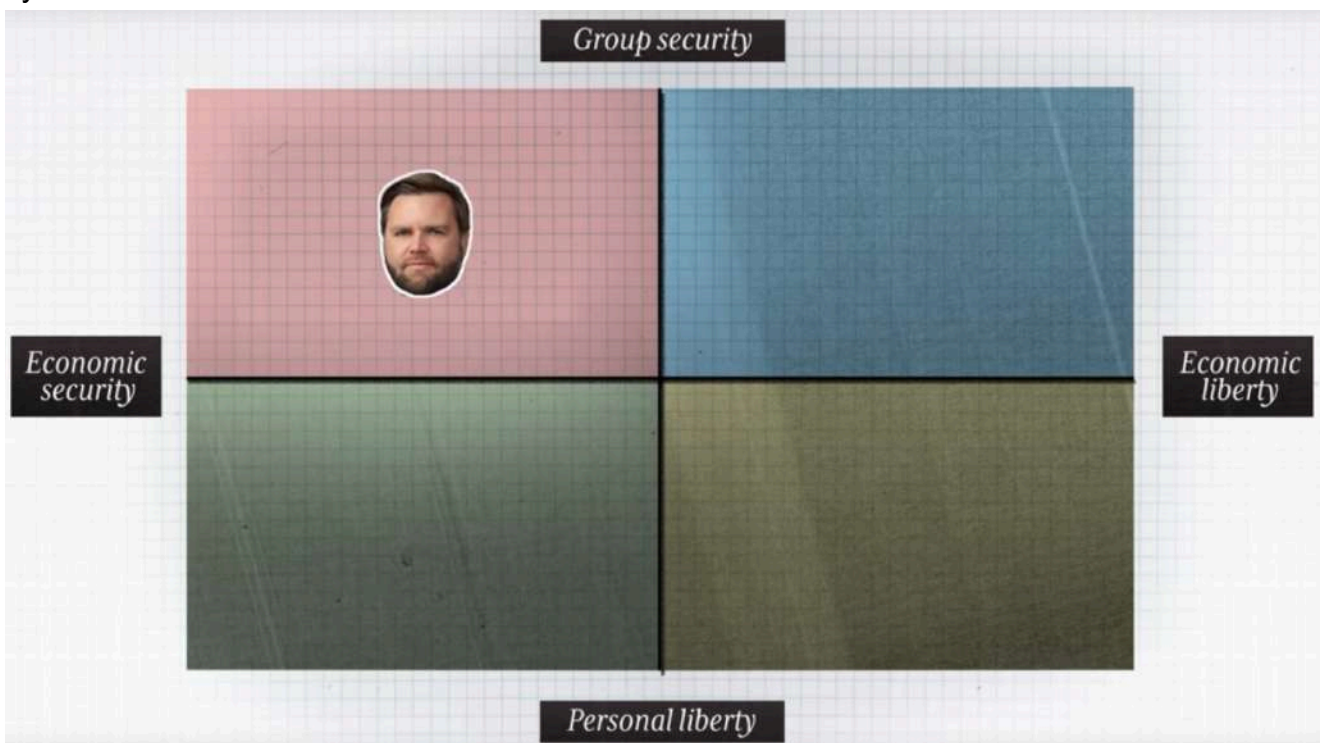
Using the state to fight the culture war is justified for Vance because, as he sees it, the left are the ones who started it, using the weapons of cancellation, DEI policies, and so on.

Vance sees it as:

"This is a raw fact of cynical politics. If we're not willing to use the power given to us in the American constitutional republic, we're going to lose this country."

Okay we've covered a lot. We have met the different elements that make up the New Right and we've looked at the culture war that Vance believes must be fought with all the power of the state. And I guess before we go any further, I have to admit I have kind of mixed feelings. So first of all, when he talks about the lack of solidarity, connection, emptiness, we're all doing our own thing... I have a lot of sympathy for that. And, And also Vance himself. I find him quite likable often, especially in those sort of longer form interviews. Not when he's doing Fox News or whatever. But he's smart. He's got sense of humor. He's interested in ideas. He's quite good as a politician in terms of dealing with combative interviews. There is something there is something creepy... there is something weird about him. And, Yeah, I'll come back to later ... who he reminds me of.

But let's start with something that brings many of his ideas together: their anti-liberalism. As we've seen, Vance is against libertarians and economic liberalism, and he's skeptical of personal liberty, with a socially conservative agenda of religion and family; all of which he's happy to use state power to promote, even if that means compromising the neutrality of the system.



Now, few these days are proud to be called 'liberal' -- it's a low status word on both the political left and right, but I want to explain why this is a mistake;

Liberalism is good actually

"And what this hyper-atomized approach to living has done is, I think it's denied people a sense of solidarity."

Vance's criticism of liberalism being empty of meaning isn't new. In fact there's a long history, even amongst liberals and those on the left, worrying about isolation, community and noting the importance of culture for a strong society, think of [Jürgen Habermas](#) saying: "Loneliness is the Seedbed of Totalitarianism," [Michel Sandel](#) who wrote "[A Just Society Requires a Strong Sense of Community](#)," but also of [Hannah Arendt](#), [Alexis de Tocqueville](#), and [Karl Marx](#) championing the idea that Alienation is the cost of capitalist Production.

But actually the emptiness of liberalism isn't a mistake, it's part of the design. The starting point for this argument is that we live in what is often called a "pluralist society", with lots of different ideas about what is good and bad: different religions, different politics, different belief systems. Now there are many who find all this vibrant and exciting, but let's say for argument's sake that it's a bad thing: a recipe for disorder, division and conflict. The point is that whether you like it or not, this conflict and division is just how society is like, and that's been true for ages. I mean, Europe had huge wars of religion back when pretty much everyone was a Christian, and the US saw deep divisions over the nation's future long before recent waves of immigration.

You can try to use state power to get everyone to sign up for one set of cultural beliefs with the aim of bringing unity and everyone together, but the risk is you just get conflict and backlash. I mean let's say Vance is correct that the left imposed its woke ideology on everyone, consider: was it successful in getting everyone into agreement? It certainly didn't lead to unity. People are different and will always clash -- that is one of liberalism's central insights - and given that, it's better to have a system lets everyone do their own thing as much as possible.

Also how is Vance so sure he knows what's best for everyone. The values of religion, nation, and family, have a long history of being important to people, and personally they're important to me also, but I don't think that will be true for everyone. This is actually the bit that nags me about Vance and that I find kind of creepy: it's how certain he is.

For example, Vance is certain that nothing gives life meaning except for children. And as someone who has kids, and who partly changed the kind of work they do so that they could put family more centrally in my life, I'm sympathetic to that. But to go from knowing what's true for you, to being certain that everyone must have kids otherwise they must be unhappy, and to extrapolate further from that to say people without kids don't have a stake in the country — I mean it's offensive, but it's also just stupid.

People are different, they vary enormously. By all means give your point of view, that's kind of the whole idea of free speech, but to go further than that, just doesn't make any sense. Besides, people without children still have families — cousins, nephews, nieces. And think of

all the doctors, soldiers, emergency workers... many of whom won't have children, but all demonstrating more "physical commitment to the future of the country" than JD Vance.

I've been thinking about this and the type of person that Vance reminds me of is the evangelical new believer. So I grew up around Christianity as a child, and new believers are often like this. They've got lots of clever thoughts and lots of certainty. And it's a bit of a contrast with people who have longstanding faith. I was thinking of this when Vance was using the concept of '[Ordo amoris](#)', which is this medieval concept from, [Thomas Aquinas](#), a theologian from the past. And he was using it to justify slashing America's aid budget. And he was called out by the Pope, who reminded him of the [story of the Good Samaritan](#), which is a story that comes direct from Jesus and that even children know about.

That's classic new believer. And we know that Vance had this traumatic upbringing, and we also know from his own account that he went through a period where he was looking for virtue, looking for meaning, looking for purpose. And he came to Catholicism. But I think this is also in a sense, he came to MAGA. I mean, I know there's also this desire for political power, he had to adjust and all that sort of business. I know that's true, but that... other politicians have done that like Marco Rubio has changed politically, but he doesn't have this slight kind of crazy thing that Vance has. And that's that's what Vance reminds me of. That's what I think you see, when he's gone, when he's called weird, or it's that craziness of the new believer.

The other thing that is foolish about Vance's anti-liberalism is his belief it won't backfire on conservatives. After all, if modern culture is a Cathedral-indoctrinated woke garbage tumor, how is he so confident his side will win all the time? In fact, there is a long history of America's liberal institutions giving protection to religious organizations — something these organizations need precisely because they do not have majority power. It's also a striking position for a Catholic to take, considering the history of Catholicism being oppressed as a minority religion.

So once you understand all this, it's kind of odd to complain about liberalism of being empty or lacking a moral vision. The referee isn't like that. They're meant to be somewhat empty of identity and allegiance so they can better do their job: protecting the ability of people and groups to pursue those projects that do give meaning: whether that's family, church and religion, or evil pride marches and DEI conferences.

The story that's often told about American conservatism is that after the Second World War it became a mix, "or fusion" of liberalism and conservatism, united against the common enemy of communism that abolished personal and economic liberty. But what we're seeing with the New Right is a rejection of liberalism by conservatives. In many ways it mirrors the move away from liberalism on the left, which is why some have called MAGA the "woke right" - a movement that "places identity grievance, ethnic consciousness, and tribal striving at the center of its behavior and thought."

But while I have my own criticisms of liberalism on the left, I don't think it's unfair to say what we're seeing at the moment ... is much worse. In some ways it's not surprising. If you move

away from a philosophy based on ideas of liberty and freedom, should you wonder if you end up with authoritarianism? It's true liberalism might not bring unity, but neither will getting rid of it.

Making America Less Exceptional

My second problem with Vance's culture war is his move from civic nationalism towards something more ethno-cultural. Let me remind ourselves what [he said: "People will not fight for abstractions, but they will fight for their home."](#)

Let's put aside the racist direction this ethno-cultural nationalism is heading towards... and consider that even if you're a conservative worried about culture and unity, this idea is bad. First, consider all the soldiers who MAGA might not describe as "legacy Americans", who have fought in every American conflict from the Civil War to Afghanistan (see [List of Hispanic Medal of Honor recipients](#))

Evidently, the "abstractions" and "ideas" of America have actually done a pretty good job of motivating people to fight for it. The bigger point is civic nationalism can better bring people together which is something [Vance used to recognize, as he states in 2020:](#)

"One of the great geniuses of the United States of America: it has cultivated this sense of shared national identity across many different groups of people."

Also, just because civic nationalism is open and not based on one particular ethnicity, that doesn't mean it lacks substance. Like, for me, my love of country is based on many things. It's my experience living here. It's the food, the landscape, the friends and family that live here. All of that is very real. But the good thing about this, the different thing about this to a nationalism that focuses on seven generations and cemetery somewhere, is that that kind of nationalism, the open nationalism, is available to everyone living here. We all have that, those kinds of experiences that we can draw on. And so it's better for unity and connection if you care about those things as yeah, I do too.

So I don't understand why you'd shift from that, which America has had a long, powerful tradition of, and people have kind of admired it and seen it as part of American exceptionalism. To go from that to something which is just kind of more ordinary, I mean, it's kind of normal for countries to fight and defend their own homeland. But to inspire people from lots of different ethnicities to fight for you and fight for your ideals, that's much more impressive. And Vance seems to want to just throw it all away.

Okay, so Vance is wrong to chuck away liberalism and the civic nationalism that has made the US unique. But now we come to the biggest problem for Vance's desire to find unity and moral vision: Donald Trump.

And there is the crux, Trump being once asked on Bloomberg Politics episode:

"I'm wondering: what one or two of your most favoured Bible verses are?"

Trump responded:

"I wouldn't want to get into it, because to me that's very personal. You know, when I talk about the Bible, it's very personal. So I don't want to get into it. The Bible means a lot to me, but I don't want to get into specifics. Even to cite a verse, they don't like. I don't want to do that."

The interviewer asked then Trump:

"Are you Old Testament guy or New Testament guy?"

Trump responded:

"Probably equal..."

I mean Trump... Trump, is not someone who has a strong (if any) connection to Christianity.

And if Vance is casting doubt on the theoretical willingness of newcomers to fight for America, how does he square that with a leader who actually refused to fight for America?

Vance is worried about a garbage elite who lack a value system, but Trump is a man who has few values apart from money. And then we have "family". Trump on Access Hollywood Video leaked to the Washington Post that dates back to 2005, where Trump stands before an Actress-film Bus and says to the camera:

"I just start kissing them... I don't even wait."

There have been at least 25 credible accusations of sexual abuse against Trump... including those proved in court. At the very least, this is not someone who centers their values on family. As Trump continues in the video tape:

"I moved on her like a bitch but I couldn't get there and she was married."

I mean Vance, you want a "moral vision" and this is your guy? And then there's the wider MAGA movement, even the official parts of which delight in cruelty in a way that certainly doesn't feel Christian. And this is also where the real moral tragedy of JD Vance because he hasn't just gone along with all this, he's accelerated it. From calling people "vile" or "mouth breathing imbeciles" to "creating stories" — his own words — about Haitian immigrants that led to bomb threats and harassment by extremists.

Trump and MAGA are not creating a virtuous culture, built around the values of religion and family. They are not a force for solidarity and connection. It's a movement only held together by hate for wokeness and progressives and it all orbits around a man who is a black hole of morality.

JD Vance knows all this. In fact we know he knows all this because he's said it all before:

"At a fundamental level, this is sort of a he-said-she-said, right? And at the end of the day, do you believe Donald Trump --- who always tells the truth (just kidding) --- or do you believe that woman on that tape?"

(yes the video tape where we heard Trump saying the words above) JD Vance continues about Trump in 2016:

"He's also leading people to a very dark place." "What it's doing is it's giving people an excuse to point the finger at someone else. It's point the finger at Mexican immigrants, or Chinese trade, or the Democratic elites, or whatever else."

People know Vance was anti-Trump but it's actually more devastating than that. He was anti-Trump for very good conservative reasons. He was anti-Trump because he could see the man wasn't repairing the fabric of American culture -- the thing he's long apparently cared about; he's shredding it to pieces. After the tape of Trump talking about groping women was released Vance wrote on Twitter:



Vance has a line now that the reason he's changed his mind about Trump is that he now thinks Trump's coarseness was a necessary part of destroying the corrupt elite culture. But to that I'd say, no JD Vance, you were right the first time.

Growing up poor, Vance learned the importance of culture, community and meaning -- and I think the project of trying to find ways to make culture stronger and healthier is a good one. But if he cares about the culture of America then he should recognize the contradictions of where he's ended up.

Undermining the liberal systems America was founded on; running down the civic nationalism that has been part of what's made the country exceptional; and supporting a man who's done more than any other to degrade and corrupt its virtue, doesn't restore American culture. It makes it worse.

Part VIII: Why Trump's Immigration Trap Is Failing

"Los Angeles bracing tonight, after sweeping immigration raids sparked protests and clashes." "... past 72 hours, pockets of L.A. descending into chaos." "I have declared a local emergency."

In early June, demonstrators took to the streets in Los Angeles and across the US to protest a wave of immigration raids. Donald Trump labeled the protests an invasion, saying:

"We will not allow an American city to be invaded and conquered by a foreign enemy,"

while Democrats have argued Trump has provoked disorder on purpose. As one California mayor states:

"He doubled down on his dangerous National Guard deployment by fanning the flames even harder."

I want to look at this situation—one that, even if these protests die down, is bound to continue as Trump's administration pursues mass deportations. When the news is noisy I think it's useful to go a bit deeper and understand the ideas that explain what's going on at a deeper level—it's what this article is all about. And so I want to use this issue as a way to look at the politics of protests and riots, a politics that can be a trap for the left and which the right often uses to their advantage; but in this Part I also want to look at how, this time, the left may well escape this trap with Donald Trump being the one who ends up losing out.

I want to start this part somewhere a bit different: in 1968 when Richard Nixon was running for president. At that time a young political analyst named [Kevin Phillips](#) wanted a job on the campaign and so he went to see Nixon aide, [Pat Buchanan](#). However, instead of a résumé, Phillips handed over a book manuscript, full of insightful charts, graphs and analysis. Buchanan was impressed, hired Phillips and the campaign used his analysis to help win Nixon the presidency. The next year Phillips published the manuscript as [The Emerging Republican Majority](#). The book became a bestseller, with Phillips gaining a reputation as a controversial strategist. One of the things the book argued was that the Republican party had an opportunity to win votes in the South, even though that area had traditionally voted Democrat, a legacy of the Civil War and Reconstruction. And the Republicans could do so by exploiting white voter resentment of desegregation and civil rights. This would become known as the Southern Strategy and would help the Republicans go on to win many later elections. The lesson is such negativity is powerful in politics. Later, political scientists would coin the term "[Negative Partisanship](#)" to capture the way voters are driven more by hatred of the opposing side than loyalty to their own. As Phillips told one journalist,

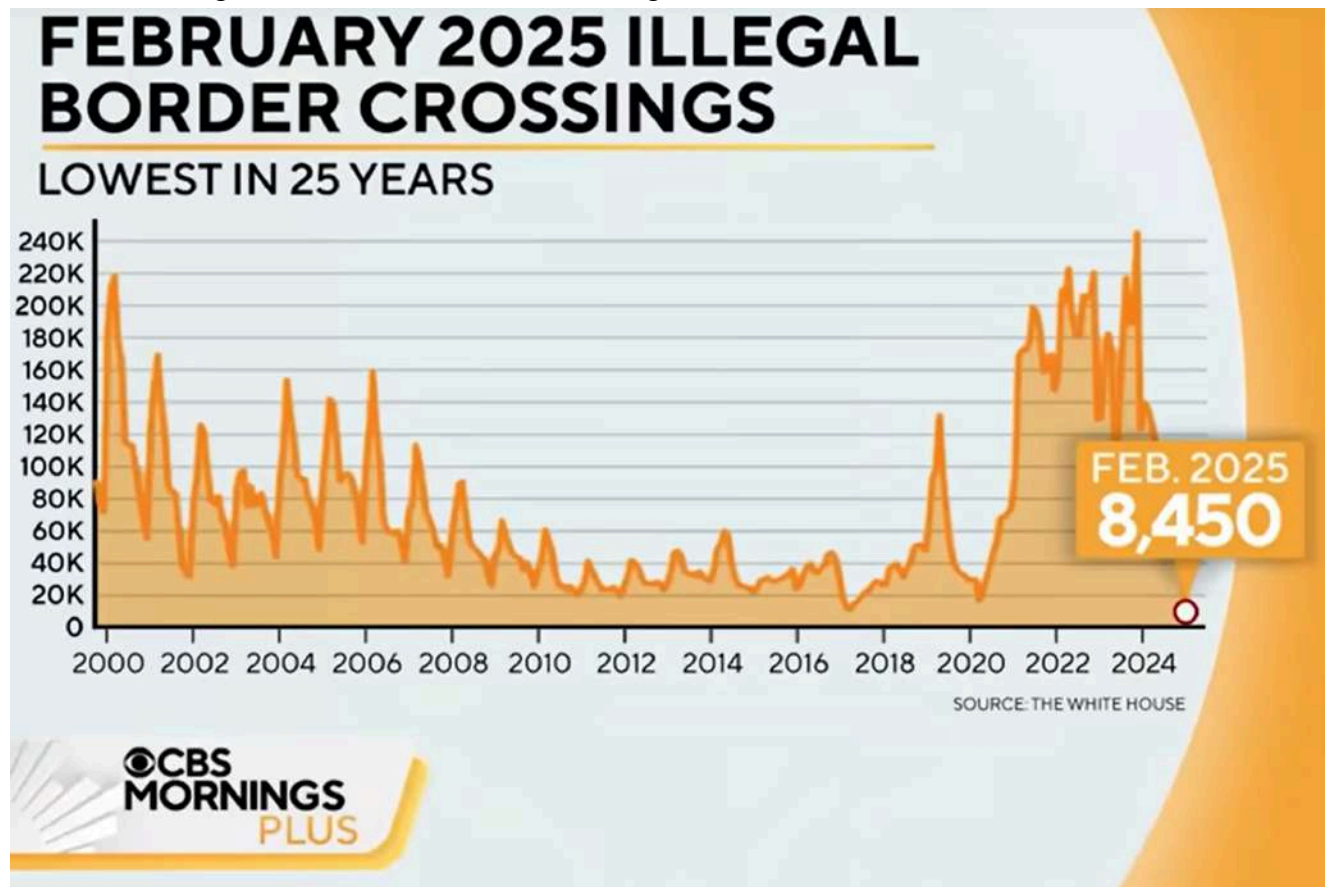
☞ "The whole secret of politics is knowing who hates who."

Immigration

Trump declared.

"First, I will declare a national emergency at our southern border."

Since Trump took power, his efforts on immigration have been an odd mix of success and failure. The success part is what has happened on the border with Mexico where illegal border crossings have fallen to almost nothing.



There had been a genuine problem in the Biden years with high numbers of illegal crossings, and although numbers started to drop at the end of Biden's term, the sense things were "out

of control" played an important role in [Democrats losing the 2024 election](#).

Reasons Voters Did Not Choose Harris: All Voters, Swing Voters, Black Voters, Latino Voters, And Swing Voters Who Chose Trump					
The colors represent a voting group's top reasons in sets of three. With the darkest green representing the top three reasons and the darkest red representing the bottom three reasons.					
Reason To Not Choose Kamala Harris	All Voters	All Swing Voters	Black Voters	Swing Voters Chose Trump	Latino Voters
Relative Importance Score - Sorted By Color In Threes					
Inflation was too high under the Biden-Harris administration	+24	+24	+27	+23	+25
Too many immigrants illegally crossed the border under the Biden-Harris administration	+23	+23	+19	+22	+19
Kamala Harris is focused more on cultural issues like transgender issues rather than helping the middle class	+17	+25	+15	+28	+9
The debt rose too much under the Biden-Harris administration	+13	+17	+12	+13	+18
Kamala Harris is too similar to Joe Biden	+12	+9	+15	+6	+16
Kamala Harris would let in too many immigrants	+10	+17	+8	+17	+11
Kamala Harris never should have been the Democratic nominee	+9	+7	-1	+11	+5

Stopping illegal immigration is popular with Americans, as is deporting those who've committed serious crimes. But the Trump administration is going much further than that, he states:

"We will begin and we have no choice, the largest deportation operation in American history."

The US administration is aiming to deport all undocumented immigrants, regardless of whether they've committed serious crimes, how long they've lived in the US, whether they have children who are US citizens, or any other factors. Motivating all this are extreme ideologies like the [Great Replacement Conspiracy Theory](#) which holds that liberals are importing immigrants in order to demographically drown and disempower the white race and the Republican party; It's also driven by extreme people like [Stephen Miller](#), a man who just increasingly unhinged every time I see him, stating:

"And we can't take the risk of letting these Biden illegals roam around freely. So the next American daughter can get raped, the next American kid can get murdered, the next American family can get splintered and torn—"

And it's driven by Trump's own... well, fascist instincts, as he spews:

"We got a lot of work to do. They're poisoning the blood of our country. That's what they've done."

To remove these millions of people, ICE—the agency responsible for immigration enforcement—has targeted sensitive locations that had previously been avoided, including courthouses, schools, and hospitals. They've removed families, sometimes in heart-breaking

circumstances. Like the removal of two American citizen children of an undocumented woman from Honduras, including her four-year-old son. A migrant rights group says he was sent to Honduras without his medication for stage four cancer.

And they've targeted tax-paying workers, even those embedded in Republican-voting communities.

As part of this hardline approach, in March, Trump invoked the [1798 Alien Enemies Act](#), meant for times of war or invasion, declaring that a Venezuelan gang was "invading" America. ICE then rounded up a whole number of Central Americans based on pretty flimsy reasons—what tattoos they had or whether someone in ICE suspected them of being in a gang. These people were mostly sent to [notorious prisons in El Salvador](#), usually without due process. This approach alarmed even Trump supporters, like Joe Rogan:

"You've got to be scared that people who are not criminals are getting, like, lassoed up and deported. ... And that's, again, that's bad for the cause. Like, the cause is: let's get the gang members out. Everybody agrees. But let's not let innocent gay hairdressers get lumped in with the gangs. And then, like, how long before that guy can get out? Like, can we figure out how to get him out? Is there any plan in place to alert the authorities that they've made a horrible mistake?"

The best known case was that of [Kilmar Abrego Garcia](#), who was deported because of an "administrative error", and in defiance of a court order. What's more, when the Supreme Court ordered the Trump administration to "facilitate" his return to the U.S. the government resisted. All leading to a high profile visit from a senator, a lot of negative media attention, and even voters in red states becoming unhappy.

Making mistakes and ignoring due process, defying the Supreme Court, and deporting kids with stage 4 cancer; all added up to a position that actually started losing public support and by May Trump's ratings on this issue were actually in negative territory.



In fact, under pressure, the authorities recently u-turned somewhat on Garcia, returning him to the US, and Carol, the waitress from Missouri, was released. But what's happened since then could change all this.

Protests

On the first Friday and Saturday of June, ICE raided multiple sites in Los Angeles, including a Home Depot and a clothing warehouse. Protests and clashes with law enforcement followed and by the end of the weekend the media was full of images of protesters throwing rocks, closing highways, throwing fireworks and firecrackers, breaking into shops and looting, and summoning Waymo robo-taxis which they then set on fire. In the middle of this, Trump deployed—against the wishes of California governor, [Gavin Newsom](#)—thousands of [National Guard troops and even 700 active-duty Marines to the city](#). The Trump administration is apparently very happy with this. [According to reporting in the Atlantic](#), the White House is "delighted" with what's happened, one aide saying, "We couldn't have scripted this better."

You can see their thinking. While Trump had been losing support on this issue these images fit the distorting narrative Trump is telling. He and his administration have been talking about an invasion and here the protesters waving the flags of foreign countries. He says the left don't respect law and order and here are protesters throwing rocks.

These are the perfect conditions for negative partisanship. When those opposing Trump were judges or women upset that the waitress from the waffle restaurant had been taken away, leaving her children behind,—well that's not a great look for Trump. But if Trump's opposition is this guy



then more voters are likely to think, well I know I'm definitely not on his side, so I guess I'm with Trump. As Kevin Phillips said,

☞ "The whole secret of politics is knowing who hates who."

The problem for Democrats and the left in general is that protests that involve violence or damage to property are always hard to defend. Leaders can condemn violence and looting and call for peaceful protest; they can insist the protests are small and limited to a small part of the city, and argue the media aren't accurately reporting how peaceful most protests are; but the media and basic human psychology are always drawn to the most dramatic visuals, and these easily outweigh everything else. Just watch the way MAGA supporters on social media were able to respond to [Maxine Waters](#) when she was trying to make these defensive arguments.

"Don't think that somehow because they called out the National Guard, there was violence. There was no violence.... Get it straight. And don't just rely on what you've been told or the few incidents that you saw."

This however was just ridiculed over by the right, as they were shown livestream and videos from violence and vandalism on the streets of the Los Angeles riots.

As well as this attention issue, leaders have little control over a movement like this. These aren't just protests, in many cases they're acts of self-defense. People fighting to protect their family and colleagues are not going to listen to political concerns about the next midterms. Also, in any protest, as anyone who's been to one will know, there are always some people on both sides who'd like a fight. It's very hard to stop them. More generally, one of the weaknesses of widespread political movements is you can't control who joins your

side and what they do, whether that's waving Mexican flags or using the opportunity to start looting, even when you have protesters trying to stop them.

And when you do have actions like this it's very hard to avoid these being associated with the wider movement. These are all the reasons why the [Black Lives Matter protests of 2020](#) were so difficult for the Democrats. [While an analysis of the protests found 93% of BLM-associated demonstrations had no violence or property damage](#), the image in many voters' minds was of Antifa, clashes with police, riots and looting.

U.S. • PROTESTS

93% of Black Lives Matter Protests Have Been Peaceful, New Report Finds

3 MINUTE READ

The vast majority of **Black Lives Matter protests**—more than 93%—have been peaceful, according to a new **report** published Thursday by a nonprofit that researches political violence and protests across the world.

The Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (ACLED) analyzed more than 7,750 Black Lives Matter demonstrations in all 50 states and Washington D.C. that took place in the wake of **George Floyd's death** between May 26 and August 22.

It's an association with radicalism and disorder that still haunts the Democrat brand to this day. Another way all this could work in Trump's favor is that it causes his opponents to radicalize. Moderate positions that could win widespread support start to sound like betrayal, and the movement gets captured by the most extreme ideas. But I think there are a couple of reasons to think this might not end the way Trump hopes.

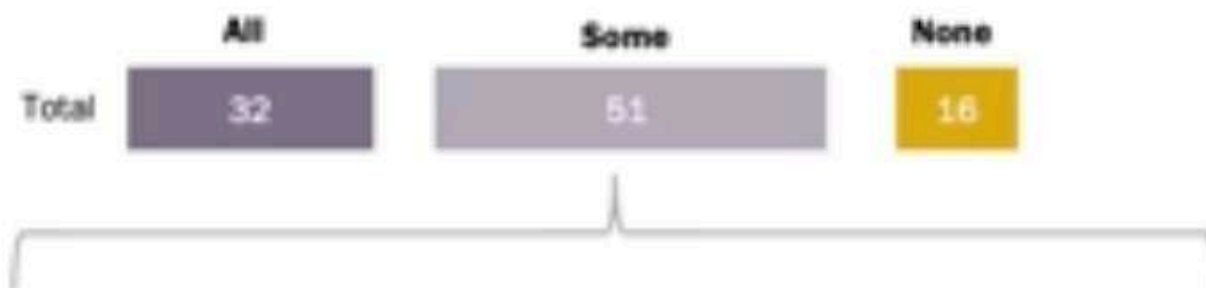
First, rather than the defensive argument of 'actually things are quite peaceful really' we're now hearing another argument from Democrats California Mayor:

"Look, this isn't just about protests here in Los Angeles. When Donald Trump sought blanket authority to commandeer the National Guard, he made that order apply to every state in this nation. California may be first, but it clearly will not end here. Other states are next. Democracy is next."

This isn't a defensive narrative but an alternative narrative, one that has the virtue of being well... in many ways true, and that fits the images Trump is putting out. As defense lawyers sometimes say, what really convinces a jury, isn't raising doubts about the defendant but proving the guilt of someone else. I also think there's a chance Trump's approach will backfire. [Polling](#) shows strongest support for deporting illegal immigrants that have committed violent crimes, much less for people working and paying taxes, with children born in America.

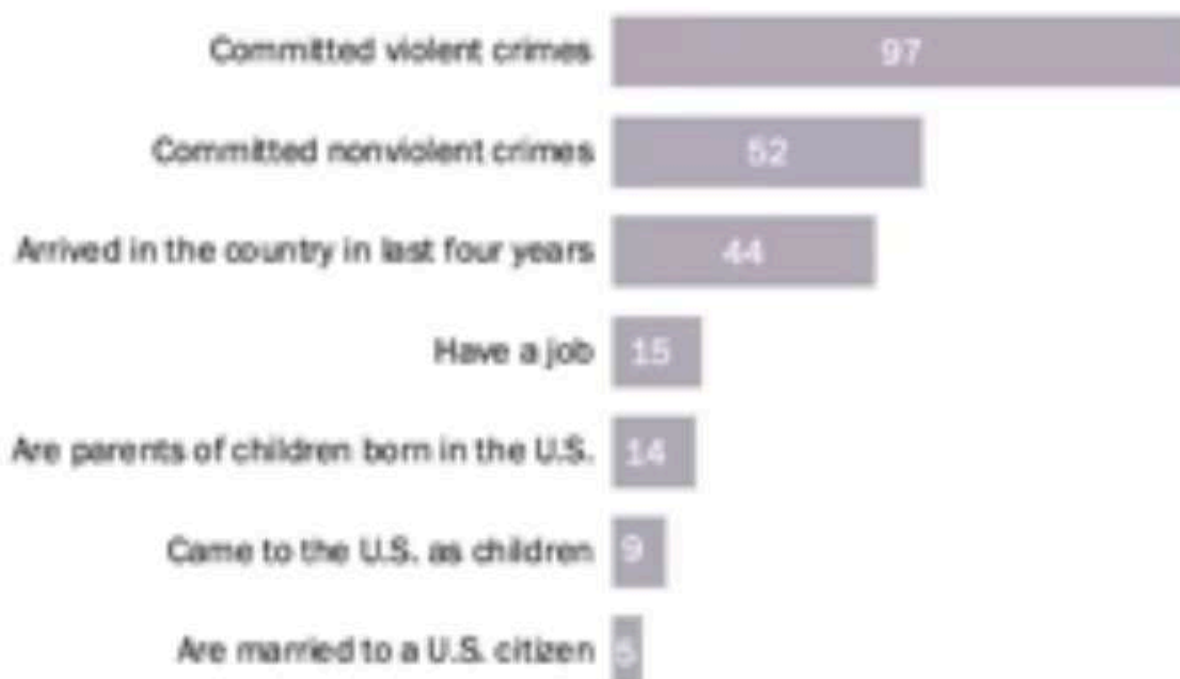
About a third of U.S. adults say all immigrants in the U.S. illegally should be deported; half say some

% who say ___ immigrants living in the U.S. illegally should be deported



Nearly all who favor deporting 'some' immigrants living in the country illegally say that committing violent crime is grounds for deportation

Among those who support some deportations, % who say immigrants in the U.S. illegally should be deported if they ...



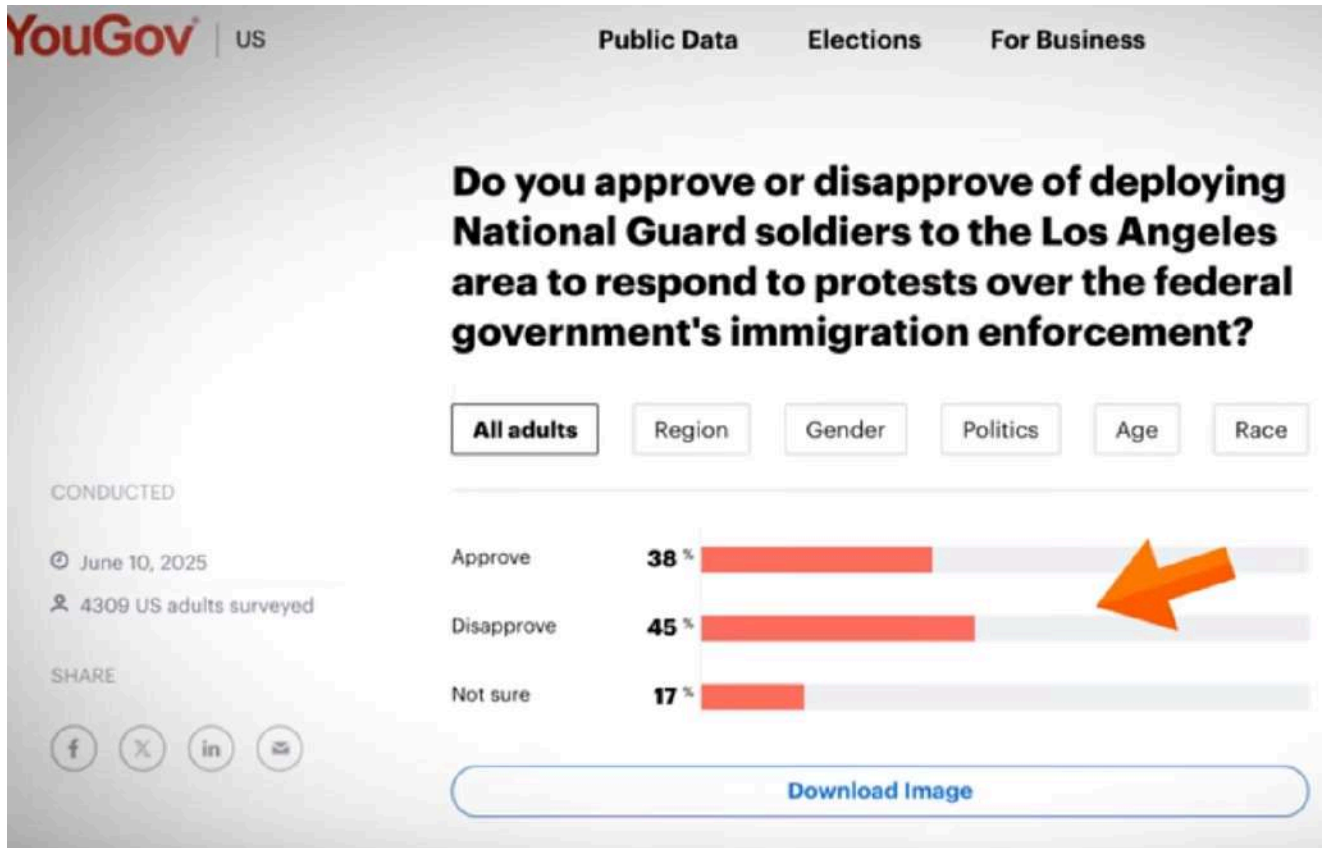
Note: Refer to topline for full question wording. Respondents who did not offer an answer are not shown.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted Feb. 24-March 2, 2025.

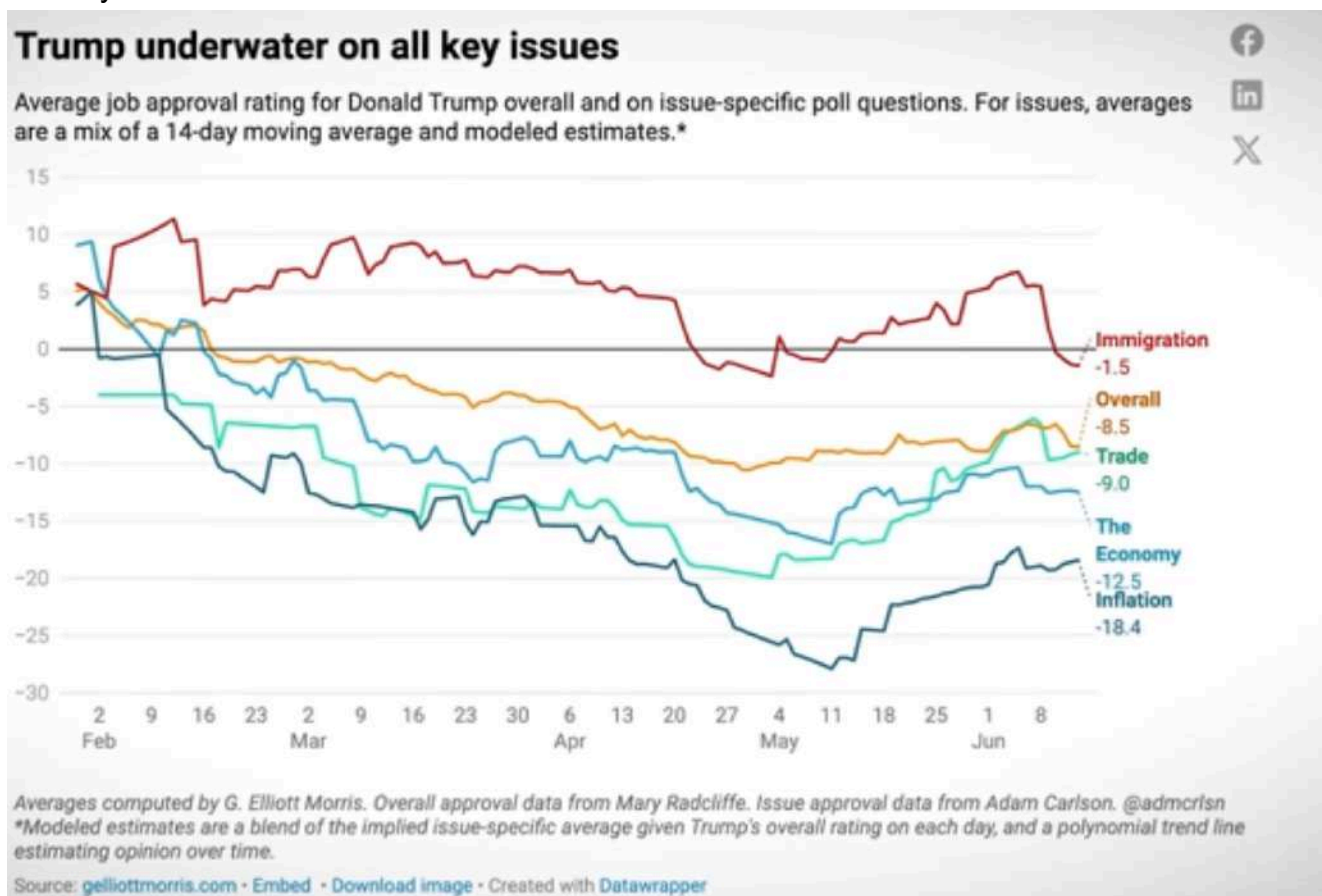
"Americans' Views of Deportations"

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

[Polling](#) already shows voters oppose his moves to deploy the National Guard and marines,

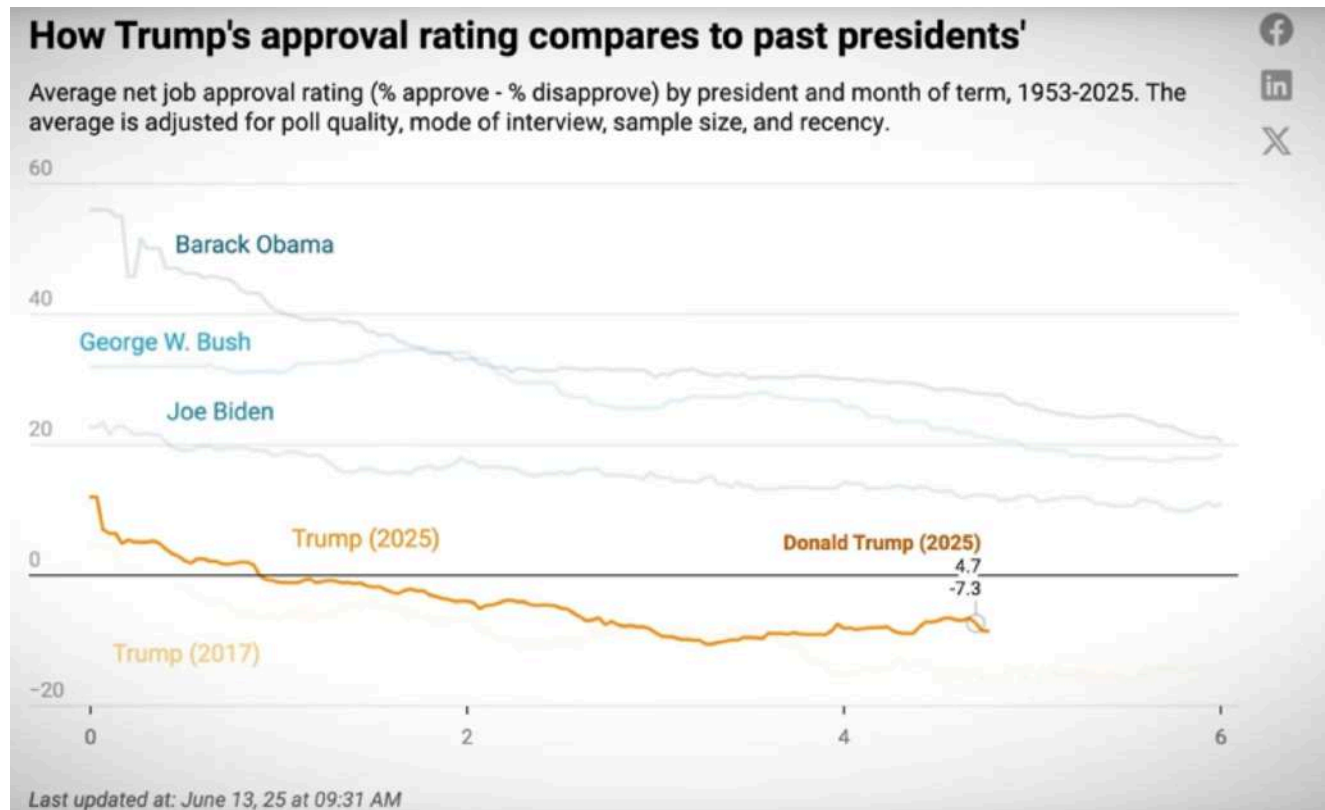


and now his numbers on immigration—his strongest issue—have returned to negative territory.



There's also the chance the Marines or National Guard end up killing or hurting citizens in a way that turns public opinion against Trump. And amidst increasing evidence Trump's economic policies are causing problems, these ICE raids will hurt the economy further. Not to mention the economic damage to farming and other sectors this crackdown will result in.

In fact a week after the protests began Trump was forced to instruct ICE to stop raiding farms and hotels. As I argued in the third part about How Trump Will Fail this administration is over-confident, interpreting a narrow win on economic issues, as a mandate to implement an extreme agenda. This overreach, combined with Trump's incompetence, has already meant his administration is hugely unpopular generally.



At the time of writing, how this will all turn out is uncertain. Certainly the administration and its extremists will continue to provoke unrest if they can, But while the outcome of the current situation is still uncertain, it might be worth remembering that Nixon's southern strategy struggled initially. In fact, in the 1970 midterm elections, the first test of Nixon's new presidency, the Democrats picked up twelve seats at the expense of the Republican Party. Despite the recent riots and unrest, Nixon's rhetoric about "*law and order*" and the "*silent majority*" failed to pay off with voters. A heavy handed response to protests by National Guard members galvanized public opposition (like the [Kent State Massacre of 1970](#) where four students were killed by National Guardsmen); Some of those in his administration were seen as extreme and off-putting like [Spiro Agnew](#), then Nixon's Vice President.; while many voters were more concerned about economic issues than the culture war agenda. Trump believes that he's set a trap that his opposition is walking into, but it might hurt him that it ends up hurt by it.

Part IX: He's Lied to MAGA before. Why Is Epstein Different?

For years now, Trump and many in the MAGA movement have speculated that Jeffrey Epstein was murdered to protect rich and powerful men he was blackmailing. But on July 7th, Trump's administration released a two-page memo concluding there was no secret "client list" and no evidence he was murdered. The result of this was uproar in MAGA world.

Even on populist right echo-chambers:

"Where did that whole case go? Where did all the files go?" "They just went nowhere. No one even believes that." "This stinks. This... This just reeks." "Something is horribly wrong here." "How many of you are not satisfied with the results of the investigation?"

In reaction, Donald Trump tried to get everyone—including his supporters—to move on from the story.

Trump after being asked about the Epstein files etc: he responds to the journalist that asked the question:

"Could I just interrupt for one second? Are you still talking about Jeffrey Epstein? I don't understand why the Jeffrey Epstein case would be of interest to anybody. It's pretty boring stuff."

But then something odd happened: his supporters ignored him. Like [Candace Owens](#) puts it:

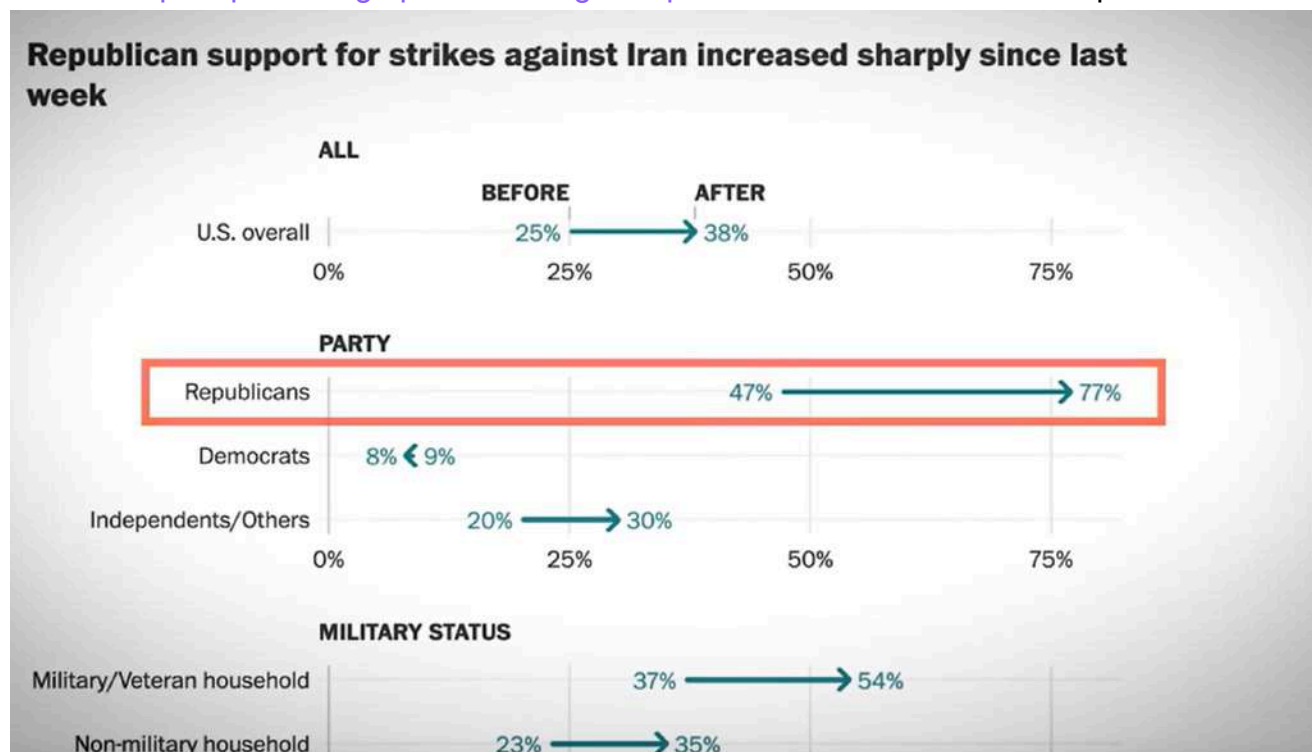
"I can't reconcile this Donald Trump with the Trump that we're seeing right now, the Trump that is gaslighting the public right now."

Or on the [Benny show](#):

"This is the number one motivating issue for the base." and that: "There is something there. And it's being covered up and the president blessed it."

This was odd. For years Trump has broken promises and lied—to everyone, but also to his base. Apparently he'd get Mexico to pay for the wall, bring back the coal industry, and he wouldn't cut medicaid. And yet Trump has always seemed able to keep the support of his people. Even when he [bombed Iran in the face of MAGA opposition, support for action](#)

[rocketed up 30 percentage points amongst Republicans](#) once he'd made his position clear.



Often it has seemed like MAGA is less of a political movement than a personality cult. Thus we have to remember the previous quotes from Trump on CNN:

"They say I have the most loyal people. Did you ever see that? Where I could stand in the middle of Fifth Avenue and shoot somebody, and I wouldn't lose any voters, okay? It's like incredible."

But now Trump seems to have lost some of his control. This is strange. What is it about this issue which is so different to all the other things he's done that might lose him support? What is so different about Epstein? In this part I want to explore that question and share three reasons why Trump is having trouble. Doing so also lets us look at the internal contradictions of Trump's politics, and understand what the future holds for MAGA's political power.

I guess we need to start by figuring out what's really happened here. One scenario is that the Trump administration came in thinking there might be something going on but found out there wasn't. Epstein wasn't blackmailing, wasn't murdered, and there's nothing more that can be released without hurting the victims or ruining a future trial. They've looked into it and there's nothing to see. If this is the case though, then there's been some incredible stupidity going on. First [Pam Bondi](#), the attorney general, has spent months hyping up what was going to be revealed. Fox News: the moderator asked Bondi:

"The DOJ may be releasing the list of Jeffrey Epstein's clients. Will that really happen?"

She responded:

"It's sitting on my desk right now to review." She continued later on: "There are tens of thousands of videos" adding: "I think tomorrow, Jesse... Breaking news right now: you're going to see some Epstein information being released."

In February she even invited MAGA influencers to pose with pictures saying "Epstein Files Phase 1" with a promise of more to come later. But now the story is she was mistaken about there being a list and the tens of thousands of videos had nothing useful in them. In other words, she's not covering up anything—she was just a bit bad at her job and not really understanding what was on her desk or not. While this might sound suspicious, I actually think this is very plausible if you consider that Trump has hired people mainly for their loyalty rather than their competence.

Another example of stupidity is Trump's efforts to call it all a hoax, he states:

"I would say, you know, that these files were made up by [Comey](#). They were made up by Obama. They were made up by the Biden..."

So let me get this straight. According to Trump, all the top Democrats got together and said, let's create some fake files that destroy Trump's political career. They don't ever use them. They let Trump get elected. Don't use them. Let Trump get elected again. Still don't use them. And then once he's the president, hope he releases the files without ever looking at them.

Of course his staff could have told him this defense was never going to work as presumably they're so nervous of seeming disloyal, so no-one said anything. Just like they were slow to tell Trump, Elon Musk's Doge was a stupid idea and would backfire and his approach to tariffs would hurt the economy. It's all an example of what we might call "Authoritarian brainrot" where government competence is sidelined in favor of loyalty to the leader. Another factor in this brainrot is MAGA's media eco-system: so full of propaganda and half-truths, administration people don't really understand what's going on—think of Fox News, Joe Rogan, Ben Shapiro and X platform.

One particular example of this is Pam Bondi not realizing her boss had long not been keen on the Epstein files being released. [Coffeezilla](#) following the spectacle says:

"The reason it's sort of a Mandela effect is that he campaigned on the idea of releasing the Epstein files is because Fox News released a deceptively edited clip..."

And when Trump was asked before his second inauguration:

"Would you declassify the Epstein files?"

he responded:

"Yeah, yeah, I would. I guess I would. I think that less so because, you know, you don't know... You don't want to affect people's lives if it's phony stuff in there, because it's a lot of phony stuff with that whole world."

Critical media might be annoying for governments, but replacing it with propaganda, makes those same governments more stupid. Trump is an authoritarian so doesn't care about this of course, more interested in ending criticism—even phoning people like [Charlie Kirk](#),

making them go from this: "The DOJ should immediately move to unseal all the Epstein documents in the Southern District of New York" To this:

"Honestly, I'm done talking about Epstein for the time being. I'm going to trust my friends, the administration."

And by Tuesday Fox News had ceased all mentions of Epstein altogether. While this effort to kill the story failed, you can still see differences in the way left and right are covering the story.

So that's reason one: **Authoritarian Brainrot.**

There is also a deeper reason why Trump is struggling with his supporters on this story and it's to do with the way conspiracy theories have been fundamental to Trump's politics from the beginning.

In a few short weeks, Donald Trump's stance on where President Obama was born has well evolved from this:

"The reason I have a little doubt, just a little. Just a little. It's because he grew up and nobody knew him." Trump claimed.

To this:

"I want him to show his birth certificate!"

only to end with:

"I'm saying it's a real possibility, much greater than I thought 2 or 3 weeks ago, that he has pulled one of the great cons in the history of politics."

In those same three weeks, [Trump's poll numbers have gone from 10% to this 17%](#), nearly doubling in less than a month.

Over time Trump has supported or flirted with everything from vaccines causing autism, Pizzagate and QAnon, a "genocide" against white South African farmers, Biden's autopen, and many, many others.

And Epstein conspiracies were another favorite for Trump and others in the MAGA movement. When Trump was asked about Bill Clinton, he responded:

"Bill Clinton got a lot of problems coming up, in my opinion, with the famous island. That island was really a cesspool. There's no question about it. Just ask Prince Andrew."

Even the JD Vance on one of the podcast in which he took part before Elections stated:

"We need to release the Epstein list. That is an important thing."

Some like [Kash Patel](#), now the FBI Director and his deputy, [Dan Bongino](#), built their profiles within the MAGA movement by stoking questions about Epstein.

And it's not surprising this story has taken off as it's got many of the key themes of other conspiracies—rich elites, film stars, royalty, harm to children—but is much more grounded in reality than those others. I mean if you think that in 2016, nearly 50 percent of Trump voters thought the [Pizzagate Conspiracy Theory](#) was either true or could be true, a conspiracy that included children kept in a basement of a pizza restaurant, when the restaurant in question had no basement, you can see how the Epstein story was always going to take off.

And of course one thing everyone knows about conspiracy theories is that they are impossible to disprove. Every attempt to deny a conspiracy theory, can be turned into evidence of the conspirators' genius and power. So of course when Trump says "there's nothing to see here", that doesn't work. But it's not just that Trump has used conspiracy theories to gain attention and support, it's that they are, at a fundamental level, the model for his whole politics. This isn't unique to Trump, research looking at many countries, has found a link between populism and conspiracy theories, I have read papers from [BMC Populist attitudes and beliefs in conspiracy theories](#), or [Three-step rhetoric of Conspiracy](#) by [Eirikur Berg](#) or [The Elites Is Up to Something: exploring the Relations Between Populism and Belief in Conspiracy Theories](#).

It's partly to do with the type of person attracted to both these phenomena, and looking through the research you can see the same traits and themes coming up again and again. There's something called "[generalized dispositional distrust](#)" as per [ISPP by Isabel Thielmann](#) and [Benjamin E. Hilbig](#)—in other words, not trusting experts, academics, the government, media, anything that's a mainstream source of authority. There's a desire for "cognitive closure"—that is simple narratives rather than ambiguity, and a "[Manichaeian, good vs evil worldview](#)" that sees everything in black and white terms that the Research paper on [Frontiers in Psychology](#) present with title [Beliefs in Conspiracy Theories and the need for cognitive closure](#) by [Patrick J Leman](#) and [Marco Cinnirella](#).

Also, both populism and many conspiracy theories share a basic narrative structure: both framing the world as divided into a small, oppressive and powerful group on top, and the innocent, exploited people at the bottom. As [Jan-Werner Müller](#) explains:

"Conspiracy theories are thus not a curious addition to populist rhetoric; they are rooted in and emerge from the very logic of populism itself."

For the full dive into the origins of the Populist thought and how it evolved throughout the history, please give a read to my other article ([The Rise & Roots of Global Populism - Tracing Democracy's Inextricable Shadow](#))

Althought, I want to be clear about what I'm saying here. I'm not saying supporting Trump is the same as thinking the moon landings never happened. That Donald Trump supporters are just sort of stupid or naive or, duped and so on. No, what I'm talking about is the way that Trump... his pattern of politics, the way he structures things, the narratives he uses, matches

the same that are used in conspiracy theories. It's become his whole style of politics. Whether he's talking directly about conspiracy theories like Obama's birth certificate, or creating new false stories like the 2020 election was stolen, the pattern is always the same: Trump is always presenting himself as the voice of the ignored people, standing up against lying and secretive elites. And he also plays on the traits that appeal to those who find conspiracy theories convincing. He stokes distrust in mainstream sources of authority: because in his words:

"But they could make anything bad because they are the fake, fake disgusting news."

His answers to complex problems are simple and easy to understand. Like shouting to the audience: "Build that wall! Build that wall!" And he adopts a good-and-evil language to disparage his opponents and rivals. Like:

"Crooked Hillary Clinton. And believe me, folks, she is crooked."

So this is another reason why Trump is having so much trouble with the Epstein story: it goes against his whole style of politics. It goes against everything Trump has come to represent for MAGA.

"We are getting flooded with thousands, hundreds of thousands of comments that are very unhappy about this." "President Trump was elected primarily to go after the deep state. We want to go after the deep state." "It seems like you think your base is stupid. That's how I feel. I feel like Trump thinks his base is stupid." "Steve Bannon saying, if this cover-up continues, 10% of the MAGA base will walk away." "And by coming in and being part of the cover-up, the Trump administration has become part of it."

In fact this could be quite dangerous for Trump because the whole conspiracy-populist narrative could turn on him, especially when you consider how much material there is. From [NBC documentary about Trump's past ties with Epstein](#):

"It's party time at Donald Trump's Mar-A-Lago. And among the guests, Jeffrey Epstein, is that Trump and Epstein can be seen ogling the cheerleaders. Trump points one of them out and says, 'She's hot.' Then he says something in Epstein's ear that has the financier doubled up in laughter." "Jeffrey Epstein introduced Melania to Donald Trump." "Trump was a frequent passenger on Epstein's plane known as the Lolita Express (which in reference to the book [Lolita](#) that tells a story about sexual relationship with 14 years old Girl with older man). And Epstein told author Michael Wolff the first time he slept with Melania was on my plane." "In a 2002 interview with New York magazine, Trump showered praise on Epstein, calling him a, quote, 'terrific guy' and saying, 'it is even said he likes beautiful women as much as I do, and many of them are on the younger side.'" "According to Roger Stone, Trump once said that Epstein's pool was filled with young girls when he visited, telling Stone that it was nice to see Epstein let the neighborhood kids use his pool. The neighborhood kids." "There's one of Epstein's accusers, the late Virginia Giuffre, saying she was recruited while working at Mar-A-Lago as a teenager."

"2020: Trump sent well-wishes, well-wishes to Epstein's coconspirator Ghislaine Maxwell after a reporter asked him about her being on trial."

When trump was confronted on all that he just simple responded:

"I haven't really been following it too much. I just wish her well, frankly."

And there's many more quotes and references or other appendix we could show at this point. There is a lot of material here, but I guess I should put my cards on the table. So I don't think Epstein was murdered. I also think it's plausible that there was no client list in here. And I don't think Trump is in the files as a kind of... breaking the law. But I think his name is probably all over them just because he was, as is well-documented, a good friend of Epstein. And so it's just embarrassing for him. And Pam Bondi has told him that. And so he said,... I want it dead buried.

So it is a cover-up. But it's only a cover-up because they said they were going to release all this stuff which wouldn't normally be released, right?

This is not how these investigations work. You don't just release everything on every file. So I guess it's a cover-up, but it's kind of like a minor one compared to what's actually involved. But the interesting thing for me, or at least the thing I feel I can add on, is what this shows us about the internal contradictions of this type of politics. I think this comment from [Alex Jones](#) sums it up:

"And by coming in and being part of the cover-up, the Trump administration has... become part of it."

He says the Trump administration has become part of it. But of course, becoming part of it is the whole point of pursuing political power. You are aiming to become the government. And if you've built your whole movement on castigating elites, questioning the official narratives, what happens when you are the elites, when you have power and when you are the officials?

And as [Joe Rogan](#) puts it:

"Like, okay, well, that's why people are cynical. People are cynical because you, you know, you had all this hope for change, and then you realized like, oh, the same people that are pulling the strings are still pulling the strings."

So there you go, number reason 2: **a conspiracy style of politics is ultimately self-defeating if every time you gain power, the fact you are in power undermines the fundamental story of your politics.**

Well I don't actually think this is fatal for Trump—he's a master of attention and I'm sure soon we'll be talking about something else, but I think we can see the future difficulties MAGA might face. Because one thing that's clear from this episode is that MAGA is not just a personality cult. Like all political movements it's a mix of top-down and bottom-up. While

leaders and influencers might seem (from afar) to be manipulating and controlling what the masses think, ultimately they have to serve the needs, fears and aspirations of their followers, or they will eventually lose support. I remember the first time I realized this about MAGA was [when I watched this clip](#) in which Trump said:

"I recommend taking the vaccines. I did it, it's good. Take the vaccines. But you got... That's okay. That's all right. You got your freedoms. But I happened to take the vaccine."

When I saw that, it was clear that there were some issues—and worth noting that vaccines, often featuring conspiracy theories as well—where MAGA just wouldn't follow Donald Trump. If it wasn't already clear, the Epstein case makes it more so: MAGA has its own autonomy and I think we're only going to see that independence increase. And I think a couple of things follow from this.

First, MAGA will continue when Trump fades. And two, when Trump does fade, it's likely that MAGA will become more extreme, especially as the next generation of leaders compete to be in control of it thus also as I wrote in Part 3 of this article fits well to the notion of [Purity Spiral](#). And this is a kind of weird place to end up but you can see how in some ways, Trump with his lack of ideology, his transactional nature—I mean, look at him changing position on Ukraine at the moment—is a kind of moderating influence on the extremists of MAGA, or what MAGA will be once he's gone. Not only does his leadership cover a lot of ideological divides within MAGA, but he adds a kind of charisma and electability that otherwise they would lack. Now, if you're a Trump opponent, the upside of MAGA becoming more weird and extreme is that they become less electable, but when America has a two party system and the Democrats are capable of electoral stupidity and so capable of just sort of handing power to whatever a bunch of crazies seem to be on the other side, it's kind of hard to know whether this is something we should welcome or fear.

The Lies Never Stop - Ghislaine Maxwell is "Clearing" Trump

With the Epstein coverup still in full media swing, I wanted to do an update on how the "clearing" process to mitigate the damage inflicted on Trump's Presidential reputation is now taking shape. With Ghislaine Maxwell being processed into a minimum security ("cushy") facility, in a way that raises eyebrows, the circle of lies has only gotten thicker as the current US government struggles under the weight of a well deserved scandal that simply will not die. At a certain point, people are fed up with the lack of justice, especially in a situation with such openly disrespectful deflections.

Let me start with a question. How long is a typical media scandal? How long does it last? Lately, it feels like the collective attention span for the entire world has been shrinking rapidly. But what if I said that we actually have an abundance of well-constructed data put together by [Axios](#), [Google Trends](#), and [Schema](#), delving into the reality behind social attention span, media cycles, and public consciousness. Well, fortunately, we do have such data. And it turns out that the average media cycle surrounding politics, social issues, or

even catastrophes takes right around 7 days to unfold on average. Of course, there are always exceptions to this average, but recognizing the fact that we live in the age of readily accessible information, the time between when stories are born, reach peak media frenzy, and subsequently die off completely is generally speaking plus or minus about 7 days. That is an incredibly short amount of time. Each individual day can sometimes feel like an eternity on its own, but the idea that most major media cycles begin and definitively conclude within seven days is kind of mind-blowing. I could go down the rabbit hole of why I think that is, but far more importantly, on rare occasion, once in a while, a story takes hold which refuses to die, subsequently propagating itself further in the media for weeks, months, or even years. Jeffrey Epstein with the implied corruption across political elites, figureheads, and celebrities all around the world. As much as some people wish this wouldn't be true, Jeffrey Epstein is one of those exceptions. And if the pressure continues, it also may become a focal point in United States history because the current government administration is floundering.

What started as a simple media stunt revealing binders that actually contained nothing has become the sort of Achilles heel for an entire political movement. What could very well have remained unspoken is now at the forefront of practically every single news outlet. And as the pressure continues to build, the answers being given, as well as the optics surrounding them, are progressively deteriorating. First, it was performative, like a magician's force, showing nothing real, yet trying to capture attention while doing so. But then, it quickly became about distance. The entire subject is now politically toxic. And as that toxicity grows, people like [Ghislaine Maxwell](#) are attempting to capitalize on it. I want to be clear about something right now. Ghislaine Maxwell is a convicted criminal. Not only did she facilitate horrible crimes, she participated in them. She was charged with perjury, two separate counts, and served as a scout for one of the most disgusting trafficking enterprises in modern history, which operated at scale all around the world. She is the lowest of the low, undeserving of mercy, relief, or pardon. And yet, mercy, relief, and pardon are exactly what she's getting. Presumably capitalizing on the negative media cycle, which is bombarding President Trump right now over his extremely transparent cover up regarding personal connections to Epstein. Ghislaine Maxwell's legal team reached out to the Department of Justice after which there were multiple interviews. Limited immunity was granted and now predictably she is clearing President Trump stating that he never did anything in her presence which would be cause for concern. This is perhaps the most obvious outcome that we could possibly expect because Ghislaine Maxwell has every single incentive to lie about it. Trump is capable of issuing a pardon obviously, so implicating him further in a scandal, which his administration is desperate to evade. So much so that they're reportedly having secret strategy meetings about it, is entirely out of the question for her. But going even further, even without a pardon, her life and her prison sentence especially, can be made exponentially easier, which it has been already. Yeah, Ghislaine Maxwell has now been transferred to Federal Prison Camp (FPC) in Bryan, which is a minimum security facility in Houston, Texas, and known as "one of the cushiest federal detention facilities in the country."

Interestingly, this transfer shouldn't have been possible because sex offenders don't qualify. And yet, there she is on the inmate registry, which is the result of a special set of

circumstances and waiver forms where she was transferred to this minimum security facility directly after speaking with the DOJ. Trump notably described this as not a very uncommon thing. And yet, the truth is it is extremely uncommon, practically unprecedented. Reported by NBC, retired federal prison special investigator Veto Marviglia said,

"In his 27 years on the job, he doesn't recall an instance in which a sex offender was moved to a prison camp."

This is all widely reported now. You can see this in a multitude of YouTube videos and media stories all over the place. Like we said at the onset, the cycle for this, for the Epstein coverup, is refusing to die week after week. But what about something that isn't as widely known? Ghislaine Maxwell is obviously incentivized to lie for Trump's benefit. But something a lot of people may not be aware of is that there's conflicting reports out there about what she said regarding Trump in the past. Now, going on a bit of a tangent with this, there's a couple of different options here on how to showcase what I'm talking about. I could put this article from 2021 up on screen from the Daily Mail and draw quotes from that, but I want to take a minute here and talk about something that kind of bothers me. When it comes to the Epstein stuff in particular, I sometimes see comments about how I uncritically parrot what media sources publish. This almost exclusively comes from the conservative side of the aisle who lament the fact that I would ever trust a media institution blindly and often announce that they're unsubscribing as a result when they do make these comments. Rather than calling these people idiots, even though they typically are, but steps that anyone can take to check the authenticity of something instead of simply crying about fake news all the time. A former producer for [CBS 60 Minutes](#), [Ira Rosen](#), allegedly wrote a memoir. And in that memoir, he allegedly claims that Ghislaine Maxwell confirmed to him that there are incriminating tapes of Donald Trump made by Jeffrey Epstein. That's the gist of it.

Her father was British media mogul [Robert Maxwell](#). Second, there was more to the audio, quite a bit more about the Bill Clinton stuff. But third, that's actually an argument I hear extremely often. Now, one of the standard deflections, it seems, is that if Trump is guilty, so is Bill Clinton. So why aren't we focusing on Clinton? The simple answer is because Clinton isn't in the White House covering this all up right now, obviously. But the more charitable answer is that people do in fact care about that connection. You would be hard-pressed to find someone who understands even a fraction of the Epstein stuff or situation, generally speaking, who isn't openly on board with Bill Clinton and all other associated parties being heavily scrutinized for their involvement. If you want to verify that, just ask people about how the [House Committee on Oversight and Governmental Reform](#) just subpoenaed the Clintons as well as a bunch of other former government officials as well on top of that and see how people feel about it. I don't think you'll find many out there disagreeing with the fact that anyone implicated by heavy association or close friendship with Epstein should be investigated except Donald Trump and his supporters.

To clarify, in an interview with Newsmax, when asked about whether or not he would release transcripts from the meetings held with Ghislaine Maxwell, Trump said

"We don't want people to get hurt that shouldn't be hurt." And I would assume that that was why he was there. I want to release everything. I just don't want people to get hurt."

which is in relatively close alignment with previous statements he's made about how everything is a Democrat hoax where names were planted and innocent people could get hurt, which is a whole lot of bluster coming from someone whose name has been redacted all over the Epstein files. The point I'm trying to make is this. The lies never stop. Perhaps Maxwell is lying, was lying back then or right now because she has every single conceivable incentive to do so and she's done it before. Perhaps Trump is lying or Attorney General Pam Bondi or FBI Director Kash Patel or Deputy Director Dan Bongino and the list goes on. To be honest here, let's not kid ourselves. Trump is definitely lying. That's basically all he does. But at the end of the day, pretty much everyone embroiled in the scandal has lied multiple times. Too many versions of the story have already been told with too many conflicting elements. It's not physically possible for these people to be telling the truth anymore because no version of what they say can remain consistent across even a few days from podcasters to social media all the way to government officials. The story keeps changing because the interpretation of the evidence is even up in the air and those with a vested interest in concealing the truth are hellbent on doing so.

Maxwell is positioning for a pardon. Trump appears to be set on giving her one or at least making her prison sentence as comfortable as possible, which basically has already happened. And the administration surrounding him is dead set on what? Preserving their political careers. They were appointed by him, practically all of them. A lot of them dragged out of insignificant places in order to be there. So, it's kind of hard to tell, but at the end of the day, I can say this. The lies never stop coming.

Part X: Trump's Secret Crypto Empire

On Sept. 9, 2024, the F.B.I.'s criminal investigative division [reported](#) that “as the use of cryptocurrency in the global financial system continues to grow, so too does its use by criminal actors.” The exploitation of cryptocurrency, according to the F.B.I., “was most pervasive in investment scams, where losses accounted for almost 71 percent of all losses related to cryptocurrency.”

Seven days later, Donald Trump [declared on X](#): “Crypto is one of those things we have to do. Whether we like it or not, I have to do it.” In the same post, a month and a half before the election, he promoted his new venture [World Liberty Financial Inc.](#)

Back in the White House, Trump has discovered that what he [criticized as “not money” six years ago](#) could now serve as an ideal way to profit from his presidency. Estimates of the value of his crypto assets vary widely, from [\\$2.9 billion](#) by Fortune to [\\$6.2 billion](#) by Forbes, although Forbes acknowledged the figure is “a dubious estimate given it’s based on supply not yet on the market.” And as Trump said, it’s not, strictly speaking, money.

The transformation was nothing short of remarkable. [In 2019, Trump had tweeted his disdain for Bitcoin and other cryptocurrencies, calling their value “highly volatile and based on thin air”](#) and warning that unregulated crypto assets could facilitate drug trade and illegal activity. By 2021, he was still calling Bitcoin a scam. But by July 2024, standing before a [Bitcoin conference in Nashville](#), Trump laid out his vision:

“I’m laying out my plan to ensure that the United States will be the crypto capital of the planet and the Bitcoin superpower of the world.”

What sparked this dramatic shift? The answer lies in a perfect storm of political opportunity and family ambition.

The Biden Administration's Regulatory Crackdown

When Biden entered office in 2020, his administration moved aggressively to regulate the crypto industry. The goal was investor protection, but the crypto community saw it as hostile interference. [The Securities and Exchange Commission \(SEC\)](#), under newly appointed chairman [Gary Gensler](#), launched an aggressive enforcement campaign.

The SEC began treating cryptocurrencies as securities, bringing with them a mountain of compliance requirements that many crypto companies couldn't meet. Within three and a half years, the agency issued roughly \$6 billion in total penalties across about 100 cases. The crypto industry was furious, and over 50 million American crypto owners were looking for a political champion. Trump saw his opening. [He promised to fire Gary Gensler on day one and end what he called Biden and Kamala Harris's “anti-crypto crusade.”](#) The crypto industry responded with massive campaign donations, marking the first time they had gone all-in on lobbying efforts.

The Family Business Strategy

Behind the scenes, [Donald Jr.](#) and [Eric Trump](#) were the architects of something much bigger than a political pivot. According to investigative reporting by The New York Times, the Trump sons convinced their father that embracing crypto wasn't just smart politics – it could make the family incredibly wealthy. They developed a two-pronged strategy: launch a meme coin and create a crypto bank. Both ventures would prove wildly successful, transforming Trump's wealth in ways that his real estate empire never had.

On January 17, 2025, Trump unveiled his own [Meme coin \\$TRUMP](#). Despite disclaimers that it wasn't an investment opportunity and had nothing to do with his political office, the launch was explosive. Within days, it became one of the most popular and valuable meme coins in the world. Two Trump businesses controlled 80% of all coins, a share worth \$58 billion at its peak – representing about 90% of Trump's net worth. While the value later plummeted, leaving nearly half of buyers at a loss, the Trump family made enormous profits through token sales and transaction fees. The Financial Times estimated earnings of at least \$335 million.

The timing was perfect. Under the Biden administration, such meme coins might have faced SEC investigation due to their speculative nature and tendency to cause investor losses. But once Trump took office and replaced Gary Gensler as promised, the SEC published a statement essentially declaring that meme coins wouldn't be investigated or regulated.

The conflict of interest was stark: the president and his family were profiting from crypto while simultaneously setting crypto policy.

In April 2025, Trump announced that the top 220 holders of his coin would be invited to a private dinner with the president. The top 25 would also receive access to an [exclusive pre-dinner reception and VIP White House tour](#). Foreign crypto investors spent \$148 million on Trump coins for this access, with crypto entrepreneur Justin Sun alone paying \$16 million. When critics suggested this looked like selling access to the president, the White House responded that Trump was "abiding by all conflict of interest laws that are applicable" and called it "absurd" to suggest the president was profiting from his office.

The meme coin was just the beginning. On September 16, 2024, Trump announced [World Liberty Financial](#), a venture that would dwarf everything else. Run by his sons Eric, Donald Jr., and [Barron](#), this crypto bank aimed to become a major player in digital lending and borrowing.

The founding team was eclectic, to put it mildly. Alongside the Trumps were [Zack Witkoff](#) (son of Trump's Middle East envoy [Steve Witkoff](#)), and two entrepreneurs named [Zachary Folkman](#) and [Chase Herro](#). The latter pair had interesting backgrounds – they had previously run a website called "[Date Hotter Girls](#)," sold colon cleanses, and offered get-rich-quick advice.

[World Liberty Financial began selling its own cryptocurrency called WLFI, with the Trump family entitled to 75% of revenue](#) after minimum thresholds were met. They owned \$22.5 billion worth of these coins, with a goal of selling \$300 million worth. Initially, sales were sluggish, reaching only a few million by late October. Then election night changed everything.

Foreign Investment and Legal Troubles

After Trump's victory, WLFI sales exploded. Investors from Singapore, South Korea, Hong Kong, and the United Arab Emirates – all legally prohibited from donating to presidential campaigns – found in WLFI a convenient workaround to back Trump financially.

One investor stood out: [Justin Sun](#), who was being sued by the SEC for fraud and securities violations at the time. The agency alleged unregistered trading of securities, wash trading to inflate prices, and undisclosed celebrity promotions. Sun spent \$75 million on World Liberty's coins after the election. When Trump was inaugurated and Gensler stepped down, the SEC requested to pause the lawsuit against Sun. Coincidence? Sun insisted his investment was simply "a vote of confidence in Trump."

The New York Times uncovered World Liberty Financial's true business model. Rather than simply investing in other cryptocurrencies, the company allegedly proposed "asymmetrical currency swaps" to smaller crypto companies. The deal would work like this: a company buys \$10-30 million worth of WLFI, and in return, World Liberty Financial buys a smaller amount of their coin, netting up to a 20% premium.

According to reports, World Liberty Financial's pitch was their proximity to the president. Some crypto companies felt this was essentially selling presidential endorsements, though many rejected the deals as dishonest.

The conflicts of interest multiplied rapidly. World Liberty Financial announced a partnership with [Athena Labs in December 2024, buying \\$5 million of their cryptocurrency](#). One of Athena's investors had pleaded guilty to violating the [Bank Secrecy Act in 2022](#) – Trump pardoned him in March 2025.

When Trump called for legislation to govern stablecoins (cryptocurrencies pegged to \$1), World Liberty Financial promptly introduced their own [stablecoin, USDT1](#). It quickly became the fifth-largest stablecoin globally with over \$2 billion in market cap.

The coin facilitated a massive \$2 billion investment into Binance by MGX, a state-owned investment company from Abu Dhabi. The deal was led by the UAE's National Security Adviser, raising questions about foreign governments directly contributing to the US president's financial benefit.

The Complete Picture

The scope of Trump's crypto empire extends beyond World Liberty Financial. His media company raised over \$2 billion to buy Bitcoin, just two months after Trump announced a national crypto reserve focused on Bitcoin and Ethereum. Another Trump venture raised \$220 million for Bitcoin mining.

According to Forbes, cryptocurrency now comprises roughly 60% of Trump's wealth. A man who built a real estate empire over half a century doubled his fortune in just one year – the same year he regained the presidency and seized control of crypto's regulatory apparatus.

The New York Times characterized World Liberty Financial as erasing "centuries-old presidential norms, eviscerating the boundary between private enterprise and government policy in a manner without precedent in modern American history."

The picture painted as clear image, that Crime became legal in US ever since Trump took office: an oligarchy where wealthy individuals facing legal troubles suddenly find their problems disappearing, where foreign governments directly enrich the American leader, and where White House access can be purchased with sufficient investment in the Trump family's ventures.

Part XI: Conclusion

How long is 4.543 billion years compared to 3,500 years? The 3,500 years our species has existed as humans might seem minuscule compared to our 4.543-billion-year-old planet Earth. But what about 8 years compared to 249? Only 8 years, compared to the 249-year scale of American democracy. To some, both comparisons might seem like an insignificant percentage, not worth accounting for—a mere statistical blip in the grand narrative of a nation. And yet, within those 8 years, things built almost over the course of two and a half centuries could be destroyed. Not by a meteorite strike, or nuclear disaster, but by a pure and unforgiving spectacle and apparent denial of reality by a mass of over at least 170 million people.

An old saying goes that a lie repeated 100 times eventually becomes truth. But a lie repeated at least 170 million times—what are we to make of that? Yet the very lie was repeated not 170 million times but twice that amount, as Trump was voted for president twice. Can we still really talk about a lie that becomes truth—that Trump is suitable and adept for the presidency of the richest and mightiest country history has ever seen?

The lies don't just evolve into truth by being repeated almost half a billion times. This inadvertently alters the very fabric of what we perceived as truth itself. We have witnessed not merely the corruption of information, but the fundamental restructuring of reality through mass delusion. When 170 million people choose to believe the same falsehood twice, we are no longer dealing with propaganda—we are confronting the collective suicide of human's reason & rationality.

Thus:

In America, they have twice elected a president who has said and done things that violate universal moral values we all share—hoping he would fulfill short-term political promises. They were rewarded with lies, falsehoods, and duplicity in every conceivable claim he had made. Trump is not just someone who should never have been elected to a position of power—yet he was, and he surrounded himself with vultures and idiots feeding upon America's heartland while he himself remained merely a puppet.

But Trump is only the symptom, not the disease. He is the perfect expression of a society that has learned to trade dignity for supposed security, truth for convenient lies, principles for populism. His election reveals something more terrifying than his own moral corruption: it shows that a majority of voters were willing to sacrifice the foundations of democracy for the promise of simple answers to complex questions.

The vultures who flocked around him recognized the opportunity: a people afraid of the future will buy anyone who promises them certainty—no matter how deceptive. They transformed America's noblest tradition, democratic discourse, into a show where the loudest screamer emerges victorious. The idiots he surrounded himself with weren't there by

accident—they were the logical consequence of a system that considers competence elitist and ignorance authentic.

And while Trump played his antics, while his supporters chanted "America First," the country became a living example of how quickly a democracy can crumble from within. Not through tanks or bombs, but through citizens' willingness to despise their own democratic institutions as long as the right demagogue tells them what they want to hear.

This is the bitterest irony of our time: while we fear external enemies, we have elected democracy's internal enemies to power. We have learned to place authority over truth, strength over justice, power over morality. Trump was not the corruptor of American democracy—he was its faithful mirror.

The mathematics are staggering in their implications. In 1776, a handful of revolutionary thinkers conceived a radical experiment in self-governance. For 249 years, that experiment survived civil war, economic collapse, both world wars, and the constant tension between idealism and human frailty. It took nearly two and a half centuries to build the institutions, norms, and shared understanding of democratic governance.

And it may took only 8 years to dismantle them.

This is not hyperbole—it is arithmetic. The rate of democratic decay we have witnessed represents an acceleration of destruction that defies historical precedent. Typically, democracies die slowly, eroded by decades of institutional capture, economic inequality, and social fragmentation. America chose the express route: mass delusion delivered at the speed of social media.

When 170 million people voluntarily abandon their capacity for critical thinking—not once, but twice—we witness something unprecedented in human history. This is not the gradual corruption of a political system; it is the voluntary lobotomy of a civilization. Each vote for Trump was not merely a political choice but an act of epistemological surrender—a conscious decision to reject the very concept of verifiable truth.

Dignity has not merely become violable. It has been degraded to a commodity that can be bought and sold at will. And what's terrifying is this: we were all willing to pay the price. We all watched as the foundations of our civilization became bargaining chips in the great game of political power.

The old adage about lies repeated 100 times becoming truth was coined in a different era, when information moved slowly and verification was still possible. But we live in an age where lies can be repeated 170 million times in an instant, where falsehood can achieve critical mass faster than truth can respond. We have created a democracy that operates at the speed of light but thinks at the speed of medieval superstition.

It was not Terrorism, not Russian Aggression nor Economic Collapse of Capitalism, that defeated us. We did it ourselves—at the ballot box, through our silence, through our

willingness to excuse the inexcusable as long as it served our own short-term fulfillment of illusion about the world.

The question is no longer whether our democracy will survive. The question is whether what survives will still deserve the name. And perhaps more chilling still: if 249 years of democratic progress can be undone in 8 years of willful ignorance, what does that say about the fundamental nature of human civilization itself?

We may have discovered that democracy is not, as we believed, the natural state toward which humanity evolves, but rather a brief and fragile exception to our species' default setting: the worship of deillusional certainty over uncomfortable truth.

Kacper Patryk Sobczak on Trump, 7. September 2025

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